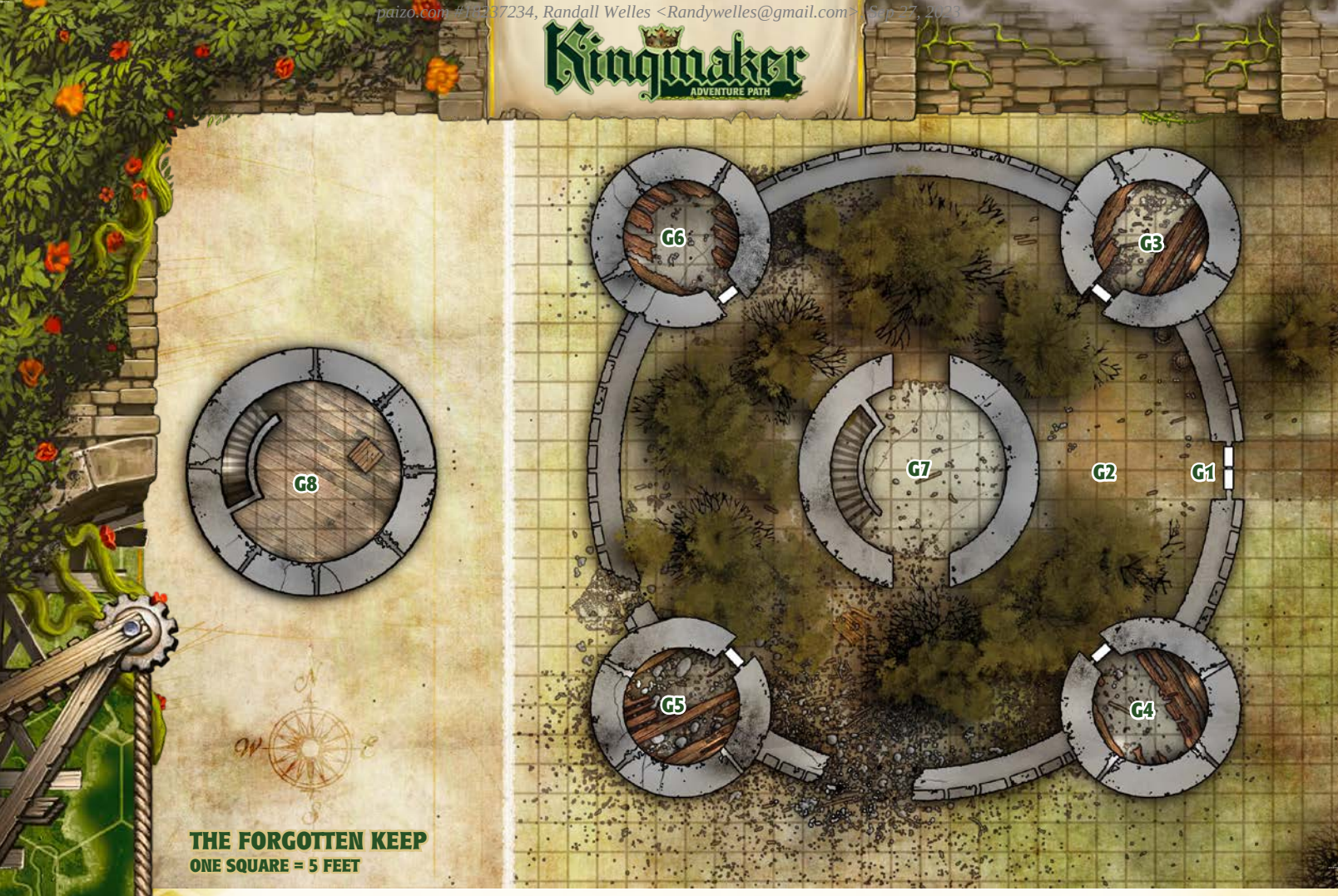
paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



Creature: This tower serves as the home of a twisted, malevolent fey murderer, a quickling named Rigg Gargadilly. Like most quicklings, Rigg is high-strung and prone to violent outbursts of cruelty. He listens carefully for the sound of his trap at area **G1** being sprung and for movement in the courtyard outside. If he sees the PCs, he sneaks into the courtyard and hides in the underbrush, hoping to attack the intruders by surprise from behind when they investigate his tower. He tries to trick the PCs into splitting up by using *dancing lights* and *ventriloquism* to lure them in multiple directions. Once they're spread out, he rushes in to stab one of them and then spring away to find a hiding spot; once there, he waits a round to become invisible again before repeating his dangerous, frustrating tactic. If brought below 30 Hit Points, Rigg abandons the keep and flees, perhaps becoming an annoying recurring villain set on revenge against the PCs for chasing him out of his home.

RIGG GARGADILLY — CREATURE 7

UNIQUE | NE | SMALL | FEY

Male quickling (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 218)
Perception +15; low-light vision
Languages Aklo, Common, Sylvan
Skills Acrobatics +17, Crafting +13, Deception +15, Nature +13, Stealth +17, Survival +15, Thievery +15
Str +0, **Dex** +6, **Con** +2, **Int** +4, **Wis** +2, **Cha** +4
Items hunting spider venom (3 doses), *+1 shortsword*

AC 27; **Fort** +13, **Ref** +17, **Will** +15
HP 70; **Weaknesses** cold iron 5
Slow Susceptibility As quickling.
Can't Catch Me ↷ As quickling.

Speed 100 feet
Melee ❖ *shortsword* +18 (agile, finesse, versatile S), **Damage** 1d6+3 piercing plus hunting spider venom
Primal Innate Spells DC 20; **4th** *shatter*; **2nd** *ventriloquism*; **Cantrips (4th)** *dancing lights*, *prestidigitation*
Fade from View ❖ As quickling.
Sneak Attack Rigg's Strikes deal an extra 3d6 precision damage to flat-footed creatures.
Supernatural Speed As quickling.

Treasure: Rigg keeps his favorite treasure in a clay urn hidden inside the tower in a niche 20 feet above the floor; a PC who Seeks can find it by succeeding at a DC 20 Perception check. The urn contains 27 cp, 131 sp, 19 gp, and a dozen different sparkling gemstones worth 40 gp in all. Rigg hasn't realized that one of these gemstones—a somewhat dull-looking shard of smoky quartz crystal, is in fact an *elemental gem* that can summon a living whirlwind.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

G5. RUINED SOUTHWEST TOWER

The upper reaches of this tower have completely collapsed, filling the interior with debris and rubble.

Treasure: Ten minutes of searching the wreckage and a successful a DC 20 Perception check allows a PC to turn up a long-forgotten elven artifact: a remarkably well-preserved mithral statuette of a elf woman wearing archaic robes, framed by an archway of mithral branches. A PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Religion check recognizes the statuette as a representation of Findeladlara, the elven goddess of art and architecture. The statuette is worth 75 gp and is exactly the type of prize that Lily Teskerten is looking for (as detailed on page 515).

G6. NORTHWEST TOWER MODERATE 5

This tower stretches high into the sky, its upper reaches hidden in the forest's canopy. Hanging vines choking the tower's exterior are festooned with bleached humanoid skulls. These vines nearly obscure dark arrow slits around the tower and, at ground level, a closed wooden door.

The northwest tower is the only one in the keep having withstood the test of time—its walls are still intact, as is most of its roof, though the wooden floors inside collapsed long ago. The door is beautifully carved (though obscured by moss) and barred from the inside, but it's so ancient that a successful DC 20 Athletics check is sufficient for a PC to Force it Open.

Creatures: A grimstalker named Teorlian lives in this tower with his "pet" assassin vine. The assassin vine hides among the normal vines growing on the tower, lurking just above the doorway. Teorlian himself hides inside the tower and climbs along the walls from arrow slit to arrow slit, keeping close watch on the courtyard below. He dresses in a black-and-red loincloth and has a number of scar-like patterns on his arms and shoulders.

Teorlian has allied himself with the Dancing Lady (area **G8**), and often hunts the Narlmarches for new victims to bring back for her to feed on. Their skulls, however, he keeps for himself, and these now adorn the walls of this tower. The Dancing Lady believes that he makes these offerings to her out of a sense of loyalty and perhaps unrequited love. And while Teorlian does love her after a fashion, these offerings are given solely to make her dependent on him, so he can eventually claim lordship of the keep for himself, with the Dancing Lady as his consort.

Teorlian cooperates with Rigg Gargadilly (area **G4**) only as much as he must; should the PCs fight the quickling in the keep's courtyard, the grimstalker stays out of the combat. In the tower, Teorlian directs the assassin vine's attacks and uses it to flank foes. If reduced to fewer than 25 Hit Points, Teorlian flees, climbing up the walls to escape through a hole in the tower's roof to join the Dancing Lady in area **G8**.

ASSASSIN VINE CREATURE 3

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 26
Initiative Perception +10

TEORLIAN CREATURE 6

Elite male grimstalker (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 6, 137)
Initiative Perception +14


RIGG GARGADILLY

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Treasure: Teorlian keeps valuables taken from his victims in a chest: a fine velvet cloak worth 10 sp, a gold necklace worth 6 gp, a silver ring set with an emerald worth 20 gp, a bejeweled silver short sword worth 55 gp, a moonstone worth 3 gp, and 23 sp.

G7. GRAND HALL TRIVIAL 5

This wide chamber has an impressive vaulted ceiling. Though obscured in places by earth and undergrowth, the hall's floor is crafted of smooth stone tiles in multicolored pastel hues. The walls of the chamber are decorated with faded frescoes of sylvan life, showing scenes of beautiful elves engaged in hunting, feasting, dancing, singing, and a bewildering variety of other idyllic pursuits. To the west, a graceful, filigreed stone staircase, garlanded with flowering vines, climbs to the level above.



The keep's central tower is an elegant spire of ivory-colored stone, draped with a riot of vines and other plants. The most complete structure in the entire fortress, its 5-foot-thick walls climb 70 feet to a multi-pointed stone roof.

Hazard: Today, the Grand Hall contains only a cunning trap placed here by the Dancing Lady.

PHANTASMAGORIC FOG TRAP HAZARD 6

RARE MAGICAL TRAP

Stealth DC 25 (expert)

Description Cloying violet mist billows from the undergrowth, filling the heads of any creatures inside with maddening visions of dark moonless nights, twisted malignant trees, and steaming rivers of blood.

Disable Survival DC 28 (expert) to find a path through the Grand Hall that doesn't disturb the undergrowth

Billow Mists ↻ (mental); **Trigger** A creature moves through the undergrowth; **Effect** One round later, the hall fills with violet fog that imposes a –2 circumstance penalty to Perception checks to all creatures within it and exposes anyone who enters it to phantasmagoric fog.

Phantasmagoric Fog (inhaled, poison); **Saving Throw** DC 24 Will; **Maximum Duration** 6 rounds; **Stage 1** stupefied 1 (1 round); **Stage 2** confused and stupefied 1 (1 round); **Stage 3** confused and stupefied 2 (1 round).

Reset The trap resets after 1 hour.

G8. THE DANCING LADY SEVERE 5

The stairs end in a circular room featuring wide windows draped with hanging vines that offer panoramic views of the keep's overgrown courtyard and the forest beyond. An open circular skylight in the ceiling provides glimpses of the sky overhead. The walls between the windows are carved with exquisite nature motifs highlighted in gold and silver leaf. A riot of flowers, plants, and bushes sprout from the thick loam that carpets the hall, as if one were walking in a fantastic glade elevated high above the forest floor.

This floor once contained the private residence of the lord of the keep. Its wooden interior walls have long since rotted to dust, turning it into one single chamber. Permanent, one-way illusory walls conceal the windows from the outside, though the glass in

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

the windows and skylight broke or fell away ages ago, allowing a variety of vegetation to take root here. The ceiling is 40 feet high.

Creature: The tower's sole resident and current lady of the keep is a baobhan sith called the Dancing Lady. She appears as an alluring, graceful elven woman with pale skin, golden hair, and emerald-green eyes. She wears a flowing white gown of archaic elven style, tied at the waist with a blood-red scarf. Like all baobhan sith, the Dancing Lady entrances creatures with her captivating dance and then drinks the blood of the living. Though she likes to think that the quickling Rigg Gargadilly in area **G4** and Teorlian the grimstalker in area **G6** have sworn fealty to her and worship her as their queen, in reality, they have only agreed to ally themselves with her out of mutual benefit. Nevertheless, the grimstalker has become quite smitten with the Lady and regularly brings her fresh victims, though not for the reasons she thinks. If the grimstalker in area **G6** fled from the PCs, he is found here.

The Dancing Lady uses her captivating dance to entrance any attackers. She follows this with *entangle* to ensnare anyone who resists. Once she has captivated at least one victim (preferably an elf or human), she Grapples and drains their blood. If necessary, she casts *suggestion* to persuade an opponent to defend her or force an attacker to leave combat. If forced into melee combat, she focuses her attacks on opponents presenting as female, attempting to tear them limb from limb with teeth and claws.

THE DANCING LADY CREATURE 8

UNIQUE | CE | MEDIUM | FEY

Female baobhan sith (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 33)

Perception +16; low-light vision

Languages Aklo, Common, Sylvan

Skills Acrobatics +18, Deception +18, Nature +15, Performance +18 (+20 dancing), Stealth +16

Str +4, **Dex** +6, **Con** +3, **Int** +3, **Wis** +3, **Cha** +6

AC 28; **Fort** +12, **Ref** +17, **Will** +14

HP 135; **Weaknesses** cold iron 10

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ claw +20 (agile, finesse), **Damage** 2d6+7 slashing and 1d6 persistent bleed

Primal Innate Spells DC 26; **4th** *suggestion*; **3rd** *mind reading* (at will); **2nd** *entangle*

Captivating Dance ❖❖ (enchantment, incapacitation, mental, primal, visual) As baobhan sith, but with a DC 26 Will save.

Change Shape ❖ (concentrate, polymorph, primal, transmutation) The Dancing Lady can transform into a large bat, with the effects from the bird option in the *aerial form* spell (*Core Rulebook* 316).

Drink Blood ❖ As baobhan sith.

Treasure: The Dancing Lady possesses many valuable treasures salvaged from the ruins and stolen from her victims: a life-sized alabaster statue of a dancing elven woman worth 55 gp (but 12 bulk), a virtuoso lyre, a small jade statuette of a coiling snake worth 4 gp, and an ancient filigreed elven water clock worth 66 gp (3 bulk). The Lady's bed is covered with a snow-white bearskin coverlet worth 3 gp. A finely carved wooden wardrobe beside the bed holds two royal outfits worth 10 gp each, three courtier's outfits worth 3 gp each, and several other tasteful, once-expensive articles of clothing now heavily stained with blood (and thus worthless). A small wooden coffer atop a rosewood table contains three vials of perfume worth 10 gp each, a gem-studded tiara worth 20 gp, and a *serum of sex shift*. A nearby chest holds 310 cp, 25 sp, and 19 gp in leather sacks.

RESTORING THE KEEP

As mentioned on page 84, once the PCs defeat the creatures dwelling in the Forgotten Keep, they can use it as the basis for a new castle if they choose to build a settlement here. If they do so, consider having some lingering mysteries continue to vex the PCs, almost as if some long-term curse or fell influence over the keep continues to plague the site. One potential plot could involve the eventual manifestation of the Dancing Lady's ghost. Since transforming the baobhan sith into a ghost increases its level by 2, you shouldn't begin this plot development until the PCs are 7th or 8th level, at which point facing an undead version of this already frightening foe can bring them back to the Forgotten Keep for one more adventure!

Bringing the Forgotten Keep into the kingdom can also attract other attention from the south. In time, historians from the elven nation of Kyonin could pay the PCs a visit with a request to explore, examine, and possibly even restore the Forgotten Keep to its original glory. Treat this development as a Diplomatic Overture kingdom event (page 557) that occurs during the Event Phase of a Kingdom turn that plays out a few months after the PCs claim the Forgotten Keep. If this kingdom event resolves with a success or a critical success, elven diplomats seek to establish a permanent presence in the area, and a New Subjects kingdom event automatically triggers at the end of the next Kingdom turn. If, on the other hand, the Diplomatic Overture resulted in a critical failure, the end of the next kingdom turn brings an automatic Public Scandal, with certain citizens accusing the PCs of appropriating the elven ruins for their own shady agendas.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



PART 9:

M'BOTUU

Although there are other boggard communities in Hooktongue Slough, the boggard settlement of M'botuu is the largest. The boggards of M'botuu threaten trade routes and have made the region from the southern River Kingdoms to Brevoy too dangerous for river trade. Although the exiled boggard Garuum might request that the PCs seek revenge for him against his old knot (see the Garuum's Revenge quest on page 84), or the PCs might seek out members of the knot after hearing rumors about them, no one during this adventure specifically tasks the PCs with defeating the M'botuu boggards to reopen the East Sellen trade route.

The word "M'botuu" loosely translates as "Those Who Swim in Blood." M'botuu legend claims their knot sprang wholly from the marsh itself when Gogunta, their vile demon goddess, flooded this part of the River Kingdoms by vomiting up a swamp. The boggards then multiplied over the years, waging war against the hated water-walking bog striders, slaughtering human settlers, and eventually dominating the entire region.

With the arrival of Drelev's settlers from Brevoy, however, times have drastically changed for M'botuu. Sepoko, the M'botuu priest-king, has grown increasingly agitated by the number of interlopers in the region and has been attempting to gather the various boggard families from the outlying region under his banner to form an army, but all that's resulted from this attempt has been a massive civil war as the boggards bickered over who should actually lead the army. Now, having seen their once-

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

feared leader's commands so blatantly mocked and ignored by the other boggards of the Slough, Sepoko's followers question his leadership. As a result, Sepoko has been making secret visits to the spirit naga of the Swamp Scar (area **HT9**) in the hope that her magic can turn the tide against those who shamed him on the battlefield. Instead, he's only managed to get himself *inveigled* by the naga, who has been using him to send boggards west to the Scar for her to eat. Rather than sending his own boggards, though, Sepoko has increased the raids on nearby knots, much to the delight of his followers, who see this as proof that their leader has not lost his ferocious side.

THE BOGGARD VILLAGE

The village of M'botuu is located in Hooktongue Slough at area **HT6**.

A total of 51 boggards dwell in M'botuu; the majority lurk in the wet muddy caves below the village itself. Seven of the boggards are Sepoko's most faithful wardens and remain completely loyal to him; the others are currently somewhat unsure of their leader. If Sepoko and all his wardens are killed, the remaining boggards of M'botuu slink off into the swamp and no longer directly oppose river traffic.

Many of the boggards lurking in M'botuu are hardly challenges for the level the PCs will need to be to fight Sepoko and his wardens. This gives the PCs a chance to feel powerful by fighting lots of foes at once without much danger, and it lets them feel tough when swarms of boggards run for cover. But extended fights against lots of lower-level opponents can quickly get old for a group of mid-level PCs; as soon as you feel that this is the case, have any other boggards cower and flee, only playing out battles against the boggard wardens and their priest-king. Sepoko may even gather his guards to his side and seek the PCs out once he learns they're invading his village, taking the fight to them rather than waiting for them to come to him. In any event, 10th-level PCs shouldn't be earning any experience for defeating low-level boggards!

H1. BONE ISLAND LOW 10

Clean-picked bones litter this small island at the lake's edge. Several human skulls line the island's perimeter, some placed just inches deep in the water. They all face away from the lakeshore, staring north across the lake as if watching for intruders from that direction.

The boggards use this mound as a refuse pile for discarded remains from their many victims, arranging the skulls as a warning for anyone approaching from the lake. A pit at the island's center serves as an emergency escape route from the underground boggard lair. A ladder formed of tree roots and femur bones leads down to area **H6**. The tangled ground of this island is difficult terrain.

Creatures: Sepoko keeps two of his wardens posted here to watch the lake for boats or bog striders. They wear woven reed hats lashed with pieces of skulls to better blend with the island's bones as they crouch among the reeds; these measures grant them a +2 circumstance bonus on Stealth checks. They use their terrifying croak ability on the first round of combat, incidentally alerting all of the community that there's trouble.

BOGGARD WARDENS (2) CREATURE 9

RARE | CE | MEDIUM | AMPHIBIOUS | BOGGARD | HUMANOID

Male and female boggards (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 44)

Perception +19; darkvision

Skills Athletics +19, Intimidation +18, Stealth +19 (+23 in water), Survival +17

Str +6, **Dex** +4, **Con** +3, **Int** +0, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +3

Items *+1 blowgun* (5 hunting spider venom darts), *+1 hide armor*, *+1 striking trident*

AC 28; **Fort** +18, **Ref** +19, **Will** +17

HP 160

Speed 20 feet, swim 25 feet; swamp stride

Melee ❖ *trident* +22, **Damage** 2d8+9 piercing

Melee ❖ tongue +21 (reach 10 feet), **Effect** tongue grab

Ranged ❖ *blowgun* +20 (agile), **Damage** 1 nonlethal piercing plus hunting spider venom

Nature's Edge Boggard wardens are trained to take advantage of their foes' weak points when they're on unfavorable terrain. Enemies are flat-footed to the boggard warden if they're in natural difficult terrain.

Sneak Attack A boggard warden deals 2d6 extra precision damage to flat-footed creatures.

Swamp Stride As boggard.

Terrifying Croak ❖ (auditory, emotion, fear, mental) As boggard, except DC 28.

Tongue Grab As boggard, except AC 24 and 10 HP.

H2. TREE-FROG SENTRIES TRIVIAL 10

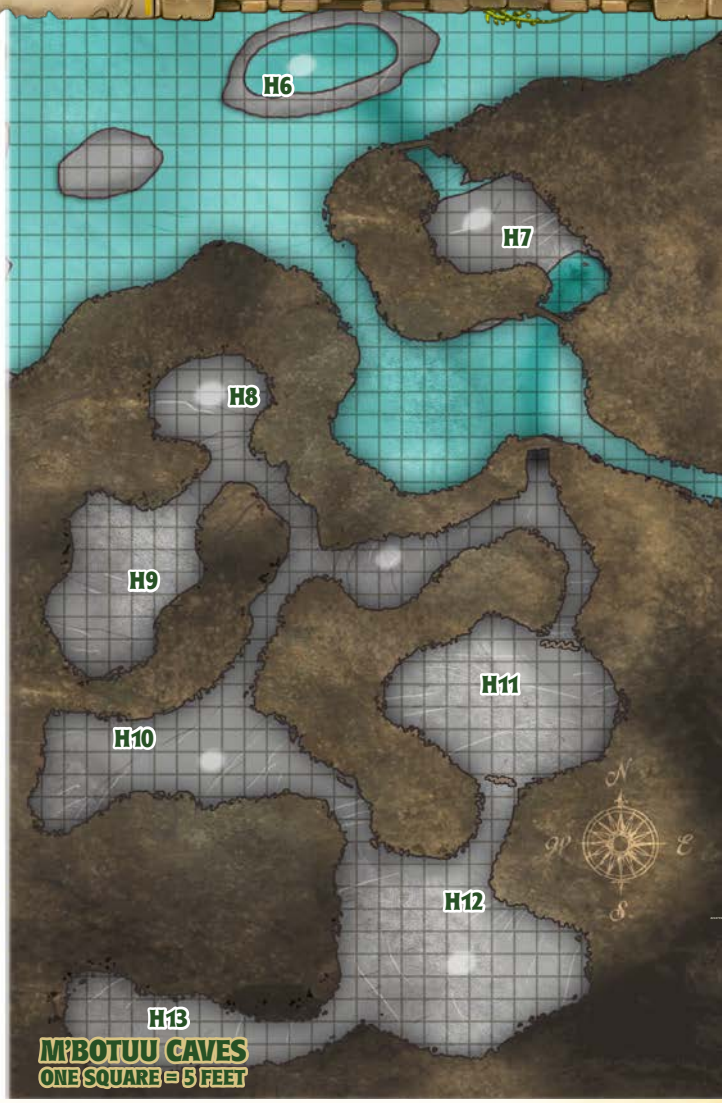
Large cypress trees loom over the surrounding swamplands at each of these locations.

Creatures: Each of the areas marked **H2** on the map contains a pair of boggard scouts—but unlike the wardens, these sentries aren't very well trained or motivated. They spend more time making faces at one another or watching the sky for birds or flying insects than maintaining vigilance. As a result, these boggards suffer a –4 penalty on all Perception checks. If alerted to trespassers, they raise a terrifying croak, alerting the rest of the village, and hop down to attack.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023





BOGGARD SCOUTS (2) CREATURE 1

Pathfinder Bestiary 44
Initiative Perception +7

H3. FIRE PIT

A wisp of smoke rises from this fire pit's smoldering coals, lazily drifting toward a massive stone statue chiseled to resemble an immense, multi-eyed, menacing frog. Five old ropes hang from the statue's open maw.

The boggards use this clearing for rituals dedicated to their frog-demon-goddess, Gogunta. As the knot's priest-king, Sepoko conducts the ceremonies himself. They mostly involve water torture, hot coals, and tiny, sharpened sticks for bloodletting while the victims are lashed inside "Gogunta's" mouth by the five bloody ropes. Since the boggards have started sending their victims out to the Swamp Scar, though, they've not used this site for sacrifices; a successful DC 20 Perception check allows a PC to realize that there hasn't been much activity here recently.

H4. PRISONER HUT TRIVIAL 2

A large, crude hut stands in this part of the clearing, its circular roof thatched with dry, brown fern fronds.

Creatures: Sepoko's raiders recently captured a bog strider named Ka-Kekt and imprisoned him here; they plan to march the bog strider out to the Swamp Scar in a few days. If the PCs free Ka-Kekt, the bog strider thanks them as best he can before making his way back to Tok-Nikrat (page 101); if the PCs can communicate with him, he invites the PCs to visit Tok-Nikrat and promises them a reward for their kindness (Save the Bog Strider quest, page 101).

KA-KEKT CREATURE 2

Male bog strider (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 43)
Initiative Perception +8

H5. EMPTY HUTS

These small, crude huts seem to be built from freshly cut timber and thatching. Originally built to house additional

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

boggards for the planned boggard army, these huts have never been used and are quickly falling to ruin.

H6. ESCAPE ROUTE

This low-ceiling room is wet and cramped. Thick ropes of dripping roots hang from above, and a large pool of water ripples to the east.

This room connects to area **H1** above; the pool leads to a submerged tunnel that winds under the lake southeast to area **H7**.

H7. POISON FACTORY TRIVIAL 10

Two water-filled passageways slope upward into this muddy cavern. Along the eastern wall lie several covered baskets and a pile of filthy gourds.

Creatures: Three boggard swampseers toil in this room. The latched baskets contain several large and quite dead blue dragonflies destined to be pulped, rendered, and reduced down as the primary ingredient for blue dragonfly poison. If the PCs enter, the boggards croak in panic, using their destructive croaks on the PCs if possible to damage them and raise the alarm before escaping to the south to warn Sepoko.

BOGGARD SWAMPSEERS (3) **CREATURE 3**
Pathfinder Bestiary 45
Initiative Perception +11

H8. LARDER

The excited buzz of agitated insects fills this round cavern, emanating from a row of wooden cages. Along the far wall hangs a variety of leather sacks, harvested roots, and swamp-pickled meats.

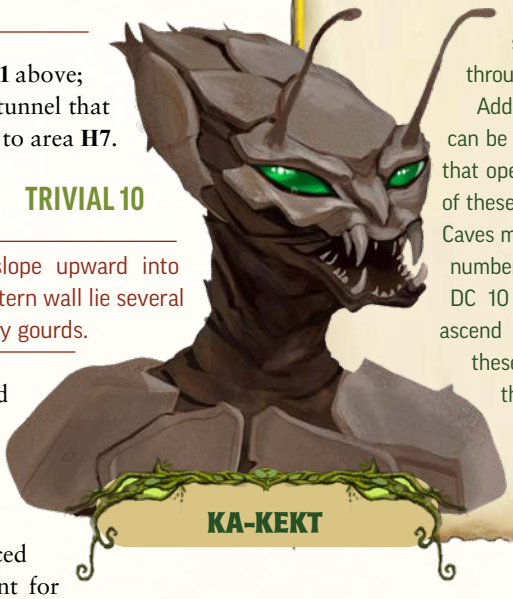
The boggards keep foodstuffs here, including small cages containing dozens of house cat-sized dragonflies. Foraged vegetables and fruits, along with hunks of pickled venison hang from sharp hooks hammered into the wall. If the PCs release the dragonflies, the insects quickly exit the boggard mound, heading for the open leather flap in the ceiling. This causes a flurry of activity among any boggards aboveground as they scramble to recover their favorite livestock.

Treasure: A DC 27 Perception check made while Searching the larder reveals a *moderate potion of acid resistance* forgotten behind a heap of pickled meat.

MUDDY CAVERNS

Areas **H6–H13** of M'botuu consist of a network of caves. Although sized for Medium creatures, these caves are hardly comfortable. Thick mats of roots hang from the ceiling, and the floors are thick morasses of mud, water, and fungus. All of these areas are considered difficult terrain as a result, but boggards, due to their swamp stride ability, can move through these areas with ease.

Additionally, several of these caves can be accessed via holes in the ceiling that open into low mounds above. Each of these holes (indicated on the M'botuu Caves map as lighter patches) includes a number of knotted roots; a successful DC 10 Athletics check is required to ascend or descend from the caves via these routes, and it's a 10-foot drop to the muddy floor. The PCs can find these "door flaps" automatically if they are standing in the spot where they egress up on top.



KA-KEKT

H9. FEAST HALL TRIVIAL 10

Two long mats of dried rushes extend down the center of this chamber. Between them rest large round baskets meant to act as serving platters. Scraps of leftover bones, insect carapaces, and tangled roots lie scattered along the walls.

This area serves as the village's primary dining hall. Eight boggards are in here sloppily eating dragonflies, swamp fruits, and hunks of red, raw meat. They croak and shriek if the PCs enter, noisily fleeing to area **H12** to seek protection from their king if possible, fighting only if they're cornered.

BOGGARD WARRIORS (8) **CREATURE 1**
Pathfinder Bestiary 44
Initiative Perception +7

H10. COMMUNAL QUARTERS TRIVIAL 10

A dozen sleeping pallets woven from dry reeds and grasses line this chamber's floor to the west. Exits include passages to the north and southeast, as well as a large leather flap leading to the surface above.

Creatures: A dozen boggards dwell here, busying themselves with the manufacture of baskets, blowguns,

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

darts, and leather armor. As with the other boggards, they croak, panic, and flee at the sight of the PCs.

BOGGARD WARRIORS (12) **CREATURE 1**

Pathfinder Bestiary 44

Initiative Perception +7

H11. BARRACKS TRIVIAL 10

Reed curtains hang over the two exits from this cavern, painted with strange wriggling patterns marred in many places by mold and mud. Soggy sleeping mats line the western wall, while three wooden dummies stand to the east. They're decorated with bits of carapace shells and stick weapons to make them appear vaguely human in form.

This chamber serves as a barracks, training room, and, occasionally, gaming room for Sepoko's wardens.



SEPOKO

Filthy, woven-reed sleeping mats line the western wall, leaving the center of the room open.

Creatures: A total of 11 raucous boggard warriors gather here to enjoy their favorite pastime, a game called "Lick Bug." They've placed cages of cat-sized dragonflies throughout the chamber, and one of the boggards—(designated the Lick Boss)—has secretly coated one of them in a clear layer of scorchbulb (a spicy swampland pepper). If the PCs wait until the game begins, the Lick Boss's assistant—another boggard called the Cagekeeper—releases the dragonflies so the remaining boggards can take turns catching and eating them with their sticky tongues. The boggard who gets the painfully spicy dragonfly loses the game and spends hours in pain while his companions laugh at them. The boggards react to interruptions with panic and flee to area **H12**, although any boggard with a scorchbulb-seared tongue is in too much pain to do more than writhe on the ground.

BOGGARD WARRIORS (11) **CREATURE 1**

Pathfinder Bestiary 44

Initiative Perception +7

H12. CHIEFTAIN'S THRONE ROOM SEVERE 10

Three passageways lead into this large cavern. The vaulted ceiling rises fifteen feet to a leather flap leading outside. A throne of wood lashed together with leather and decorated with skulls rests against the eastern wall, flanked by two braziers emitting a cold, white light.

Creatures: It's likely that a large number of panicked boggards have fled toward this area at the PCs' approach to seek protection from their priest-king's. In this case, most of them have been ordered to swarm out the escape tunnel in the center of the room to scatter into the swamp, although a fair number of loyalist boggards lurk fretfully along the sides of the room, eager for the chance to see Sepoko deal with the intruders.

Sepoko has spent the past several weeks under the magical influence of the spirit naga Ngara (area **HT9**), and as a result has had something of a crisis of faith. He still worships Gogunta, but his faith has been shaken by his growing obsession with the "Legless Lady," as he calls Ngara. So far, he's managed to juggle this crisis and maintain his devotion to Gogunta, but the stress of battle could well see that end.

Sepoko is attended at all times by a pair of boggard wardens. On the first round of combat, he uses *summon fiend* to add an invidiak demon (*Bestiary 2* 65) to his side, then he orders the demon and his wardens to

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #13237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

engage the PCs in melee while he hangs back and uses his magic at range. He generally avoids damaging his allies with area effect spells, but if he can catch most of the PCs in the area of effect, he's willing to allow some collateral damage.

If reduced below 50 HP, Sepoko's remaining faith in Gogunta shatters, and he drops to his knees and croaks out a prayer to the Legless Lady to save him and smite the intruders. Of course, no divine intervention comes, and any surviving boggards who witness this failure realize their leader has fallen. From this point onward, Sepoko loses access to all of his divine abilities, including spellcasting. Amid a sudden chorus of "Kill the heretic!" in Boggard, the remaining boggards forget about the PCs' presence and swarm forward, eager to tear Sepoko limb from limb in hopes of showing Gogunta, who must surely be watching, that they still fear her.

If the naga's *inveigle* on Sepoko is dispelled, the boggard drops to his knees in shame as he realizes what's happened to him. He then calls for a truce, hoping to recruit the PCs to kill the naga for him. Sepoko is willing to "loan" two boggard wardens to the PCs if they agree to go on this quest for him.

SEPOKO CREATURE 11

UNIQUE | CE | MEDIUM | AMPHIBIOUS | BOGGARD | HUMANOID

Male boggard cleric (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 44)

Perception +22; darkvision

Languages Boggard

Skills Athletics +21, Deception +23, Intimidation +21, Religion +20, Stealth +20 (+24 in water), Survival +20

Str +4, **Dex** +3, **Con** +4, **Int** +0, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +4

Items *+1 hide armor*, *+1 striking frost mace*, silver religious symbol of Gogunta

AC 31; **Fort** +21, **Ref** +18, **Will** +24

HP 200

Speed 20 feet, swim 25 feet; swamp stride

Melee ❖ *mace* +22 (shove), **Damage** 2d6+8 bludgeoning plus 1d6 cold

Melee ❖ tongue +21 (reach 10 feet), **Effect** tongue grab

Divine Prepared Spells DC 30, attack +22; **6th** *blade barrier*, *harm* (×5), *summon fiend*; **5th** *dispel magic*, *flame strike*, *heal*; **4th** *air walk*, *divine wrath*, *heal*; **3rd** *blindness*, *heal*, *stinking cloud*; **2nd** *darkness*, *resist energy*, *spiritual weapon*; **1st** *command*, *heal*, *sanctuary*; **Cantrips (6th)** *daze*, *divine lance*, *prestidigitation*, *read aura*, *shield*

Cleric Domain Spells 2 Focus Points, DC 30; **6th** *commanding lash*, *touch of obedience*

Divine Font As cleric (*harm*).

Inveigled Sepoko has been inveigled by the naga Ngara. This effect can be removed with *dispel magic* (6th level; counteract DC 31).

Swamp Stride As boggard.

Terrifying Croak ❖ (auditory, emotion, fear, mental) As boggard, except DC 30.

Tongue Grab As boggard, except AC 27 and 14 HP.

BOGGARD WARDENS (2) CREATURE 9

RARE | CE | MEDIUM | AMPHIBIOUS | BOGGARD | HUMANOID

Male and female boggards (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 44)

Perception +19; darkvision

SEPOKO'S VENGEANCE

30 XP | 30 KINGDOM XP

Sepoko, ashamed at falling under the control of the spirit naga, asks the PCs to help him get revenge by confronting the naga at the Swamp Scar and killing her.

Source: Sepoko (area **H12** of M'botuu)

Completion: Kill Ngara and bring Sepoko proof.

Reward: Sepoko vows to keep his boggards in line and won't meddle in river traffic—he'll let trade pass by without interference from his people. If the PCs' kingdom has any Claimed hexes in Hooktongue, this triumph reduces Unrest by 1d6 and grants 4 bonus Resource Dice on the next Kingdom turn. M'botuu's Negotiation DC (page 519) is reduced to DC 22. Sepoko also gives them the Taldan-stamped gold ingots in his treasury (area **H13**).

H13. TREASURE ROOM

This narrow passageway leads to a long, shallow cave whose ceiling never rises more than five feet high.

Treasure: Sepoko uses this cavern to secure the village's wealth. The wooden crates, rotting burlap sacks, and several small casks contain 12 pp, 157 gp, 404 sp, 182 cp, five black opals worth 10 gp each, a gold bracelet decorated with a forest animal motif worth 25 gp, a box of 12 Taldan-stamped gold ingots worth 10 gp each, a pouch containing three *moderate healing potions*, and a *moderate maestro's instrument*—a harp bearing the likeness of Cayden Cailean.

M'BOTUU AND THE KINGDOM

As detailed on page 97, the PCs can potentially bring M'botuu into their kingdom, but the boggards who dwell here remain evil. At the start of every Kingdom turn in which the boggards remain a part of the kingdom, the PCs must succeed at a DC 11 flat check; failure indicates their influence increases the kingdom's Corruption or Crime by 1 (players' choice). This continues until the PCs can achieve a critical success with the Send Diplomatic Envoy to the village to convince them to either minimize their cruelties or adopt a less disruptive lifestyle. Of course, if all of the boggards are slain and the PCs simply use the site that remains, these problems can be avoided entirely.

paizo.com #13237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



CHAPTER 3

STOLEN LANDS

BY TIM HITCHCOCK

PART 1: TROUBLE AT OLEG'S 162

This part assumes the PCs are still 1st level, but should still provide a challenge for 2nd-level characters.

PART 2: BANDITS OF THE GREENBELT 168

The PCs should be 2nd level when they confront the bandits at the Thorn River camp.

PART 3: AGAINST THE STAG LORD..... 172

The PCs should be 3rd level when they confront the Stag Lord.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



PART 1:

TROUBLE AT OLEG'S

While this campaign assumes that the PCs travel directly to Oleg's Trading Post after helping to defend Lady Jamandi's manor from the Black Tears, the nature of a sandbox campaign allows the players to drive the course of the narrative as they see fit. Nonetheless, Kingmaker's overarching plot doesn't truly begin until they make that first fateful trip to the trading post.

Oleg's Trading Post is a repurposed border fort located at the southern edge of Rostland (and thus Brevoy—area **RL1** on the map of the Stolen Lands). To the south, the green line of the Narlmarches looms only a few miles away. Owned and operated by a stern and somewhat unimaginative man named Oleg Leveton and his wife Svetlana, the trading post's remote location and inconvenient distance from a major river prevents it from realizing significant financial success. This situation suits the Levetons fine, as they chose the remote location out of a desire to escape the constant machinations and political maneuverings they saw dominating urban life in Restov. All they ever really wanted from the trading post was a place to live far enough from the sins of civilization without being so distant that they couldn't enjoy most of its benefits. Accepting a charter from Restov to rebuild an abandoned fort into a trading post seemed like the perfect solution.

Oleg and Svetlana have spent the past several months renovating the old fort. Their customers are few and far between, consisting mostly of trappers,

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

hunters, and an eccentric local hermit named Bokken. Until recently, trading in furs, jerky, and the occasional magic potion from Bokken has provided the couple enough coin to keep them in business. Unfortunately, the new trading post has caught the attention of the Stag Lord's bandits, who have been shaking him down on a regular basis.

Oleg is a man with a no-nonsense attitude and fierce pride. Were it not for the fact that he fears for his wife's safety, he would have doubtless sacrificed his life to the bandits in a foolish attempt to defend his stock when they first paid a visit three months ago. Being forced each month to hand over his inventory to the bandits shames him, but he masks his shame with gruffness and stubborn determination. His wife Svetlana knows she's the reason he hasn't stood up to the bandits, and she also knows how much the situation pains him: that act of humility is crushing his soul. She's pleaded with him several times to abandon the post and return to Restov, but Oleg has stubbornly refused defeat. His sole concession to Svetlana's wishes has been to send requests to the city for reinforcements whenever a trapper or hunter stops by on their way back to civilization. He recently received word back that a group of guards is coming to aid him, but no sign of such protection has yet arrived, and the bandits are due to make their monthly visit to the trading post. The PCs' arrival gives Oleg his first real chance to stand up to the bandits.

Statistics for Oleg and Svetlana, as well as information on how the trading post changes over the course of this Adventure Path, can be found on page 52 of Chapter Two.

OLEG'S TRADING POST

A 10-foot-high wooden palisade surrounds Oleg's Trading Post. A watchtower—remnants from the site's original use as a border fort—rises at each corner of the stockade, each armed with a run-down catapult. These catapults are in no condition to be fired, and repairing them would take many weeks of work; they're no use against the soon-to-arrive bandits. The single entrance into the palisade is through a 30-foot-wide wooden gate. Scaling the palisade walls requires success on a DC 20 Athletics check to Climb. The map of Oleg's Trading Post is available as *Pathfinder Flip-Mat Classics: Bandit Outpost*.

Specific locations are listed below.

A1. MARKET YARD

This open area is where most trade takes place. The two tables near the fire pit are used to serve food to visitors and to display small wares, or for guests in the nearby guesthouse to use.

A2. GUESTHOUSE

Oleg rents out the beds here to anyone who wishes to stay the night. His price of 5 cp per bed per night includes a rustic breakfast and a filling dinner.

A3. STABLE

Oleg keeps his jittery horse Claptrap here. He rents the other stalls for visitors' steeds at a rate of 2 cp per stall per night, including a day's worth of feed and water and a complimentary rubdown for the horse.

CLAPTRAP **CREATURE 1**

Jittery riding horse (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 209)

Initiative Perception +5

A4. STORAGE PEN

This fenced area has a wooden roof to keep off most of the rain and snow—large trade goods are stored here until enough accumulate to warrant a trip to the city to sell them off. As Oleg has been forced to turn over his stock to the bandits, the pen is currently empty.

A5. MIDDENS

Several 3-foot-deep composting pits and middens have been dug into the soil of this area.

A6. MAIN HALL

This squat but solid wooden building is Oleg and Svetlana's home as well as the storeroom for the trading post. The double doors leading out to the market yard can be barred but not locked.

A7. DINING ROOM

This is a comfortable room with a few chairs and a table. Oleg and Svetlana generally don't host meals here, due to the room's small size.

A8. OFFICE

This is where Oleg keeps his ledgers and meets with important visitors—in theory. As of yet, no one of importance has bothered to visit the trading post. A successful DC 20 Perception check is enough to discover an iron key hidden behind a loose board in the wall; this key unlocks the door to the stockroom (area **A9**).

A9. STOCKROOM

This room is used to store most of the trading post's stock. Oleg keeps the door to the stockroom locked (DC 20 Thievery to Pick the Lock); the key is hidden in the office. The inventory currently consists of a suit of leather armor, a heavy wooden shield, two hand axes, five javelins, a longbow, two dozen arrows, a scythe, two spears, two *minor healing potions*, one lesser antidote, one lesser antiplague, six torches, two weeks

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



OLEG'S TRADING POST
ONE SQUARE = 5 FEET

of rations, a number of animal furs worth a total of 3 gp, and a chest containing 7 gp, 27 sp, and 108 cp.

A10. STOREROOM

This room contains two barrels of drinking water, a half-full barrel of lantern oil, three common lamps, a dozen candles, a week's worth of firewood, a hooded lantern, cookware, 70 feet of rope, a tent, and enough food (mostly cheese, hard bread, and dried venison) to last for 2 weeks.

A11. BEDROOM

This modest room is where the Levetons sleep.

THE STAG LORD

80 XP

Slay the Stag Lord and thus disrupt the organized bandit activity in the Greenbelt.

Source: The official charter from Restov–this charter is given to the PCs as soon as they set out for the Stolen Lands at the start of Chapter Two (page 38). It states that the PCs must strive against all banditry in the Greenbelt; they'll be rewarded if the Stag Lord can be removed from power.

Task: The Stag Lord is not interested in surrendering; the PCs will likely need to kill him in order to complete this quest.

Completion: Restov must have confirmation of the Stag Lord's defeat–if his body is not available as proof, his helm will do. Alternately, an agent of the swordlords (likely Ivenzi; page 32) will travel to Oleg's Trading Post to personally confirm the banditry has been addressed.

Reward: 200 gp, plus a new charter to settle land and establish a kingdom in the Greenbelt; this charter and its ramifications are detailed in Chapter 4.

ARRIVAL AT OLEG'S

Oleg and Svetlana are expecting visitors. A traveling hunter on his way back from Restov recently delivered the message that the Levetons' request for defensive aid against the bandits is just about approved, but it

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

will still be a few days before a patrol can be sent. The message went on to inform the Levetons that a group of adventurers chartered to explore the Greenbelt would be along sooner, though, and they could well be of use in defending the post against the bandits. Oleg and Svetlana take this news in different ways.

When the PCs arrive, Svetlana greets them warmly, presenting them with hearty stew and warm bread, and she has even opened a bottle of wine to thank them for coming to their aid. Oleg makes sure to keep busy repairing a leak in the roof over the guesthouse (area **A2**). When he sees the PCs, he climbs down to greet them, all sweaty and gruff. While Oleg likes the idea of having extra help to defend against the bandits, he's disturbed by the implications of authorities sending anyone to "explore the Greenbelt." Even though the bandits have been causing him trouble, he doesn't welcome even the hint of an attempt by Restov to expand civilization into the Stolen Lands, for this would engulf his new home back into the society he's worked so hard to avoid. But he knows better than to voice his opinions aloud, so opts instead for a gruff attitude, leaving the majority of the interaction with the PCs to his wife. Svetlana tells them she's expecting the bandits to arrive in the morning for their monthly "tax collection," and if the PCs are willing to help, she'll give the adventurers free room and board—an offer that Oleg mutters unhappily about but knows better than to countermand.

Once the characters agree to help, the Levetons can tell them what they know about the bandits.

First Visit: The bandits' first visit was three months ago—they threatened to burn down the trading post if the Levetons didn't agree to hand over all of the furs and trade goods they'd accumulated from various hunters and trappers.

Subsequent Visits: Since then, the bandits have returned twice more, each time within an hour of sunrise on the first day of the month. The Levetons have learned to have their "taxes" ready and hand them over quickly—the bandits always seem eager to return to their camp somewhere to the south in the Greenbelt, which makes Svetlana think their camp is about a day's ride away.

Bandit Numbers: The first time the bandits visited, there were a dozen of them—10 lower-ranking criminals led by a cloaked man armed with a bow and a woman who carried two hatchets. The woman did the majority of the talking on that first trip, and her black sense of humor coupled with the way she smiled when she spoke of the fate awaiting the Levetons if they didn't comply frightened the two all the more. The woman seemed particularly sharp and observant, whereas the man seemed a bit more crude and foolish. This, plus the fact that the woman quite nearly lopped off Oleg's right hand with one of her hatchets in a cruel bit of mockery, convinced the Levetons she was the most dangerous of the bandits. As it was, the woman grabbed Svetlana's wedding ring right off her finger and tossed it to one of her men as payment for "not shortening Oleg's reach."

On the second and third visits, only the crude, hooded man accompanied the bandits. On the second visit, he came with just six other men, while on the third, he came with only four. The Levetons suspect that the bandits have let down their guard and think the owners of the trading post are completely cowed. Hopefully, when they visit tomorrow, they'll be even fewer in number, and the scary woman with the hatchets won't be with them!

AMBUSHING THE BANDITS MODERATE 1

The PCs have the remainder of the day and the following night to set up their defenses and prepare for the bandits' upcoming visit. The Levetons suggest the PCs hide in the guesthouse or the stable and wait until the bandits busy themselves loading furs and other goods onto their horses, then the PCs can rush out of hiding to attack them.

The Levetons have no love for their tormentors and hope to see them all dead. Oleg even has plans to hang the bandits' bodies from the southern palisade wall as a warning to other brigands. Still, Oleg stresses that neither he nor his wife are soldiers and won't aid in any plan that puts them or the trading post in additional danger or that doesn't end up at least teaching the bandits to seek easier victims elsewhere. Give the PCs whatever time they need to plan their ambush, allowing them to explore the trading post and come up with uses for the supplies and buildings found therein.

Creatures: Once the PCs establish a plan, three bandits under the command of Happs Bydon arrive as expected. About an hour after sunrise, the four brigands approach from the south on horseback. If the gate to the trading post isn't open, they array themselves nearby and call out threats to the Levetons such as, "Open the gates, unless you want us to throw in a little fire to speed your arses up!" The bandits don't expect any sort of resistance. If the trading post is open to them, they arrogantly ride in and begin making crude comments and threats against the Levetons while loading their horses. Left to their own devices, they finish the job in 20 minutes and leave the Levetons physically unharmed but emotionally devastated.

If the PCs decide to ambush the bandits as they load their spoils, Oleg agrees to begin the interaction with them as usual, but he wants Svetlana to hide in the safety of their bedroom. Svetlana immediately points out that her absence would surely alert the bandits that something is up, and Oleg is forced to agree. Ultimately, who ends up where is left to the PCs, but if one of the

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Levetons hides, all skill checks involving tricking the bandits (including Stealth checks made as initiative checks) suffer a cumulative –1 circumstance penalty.

Once the fighting starts, Oleg and Svetlana both run for cover—you can assume they remain safely out of combat for the battle's duration. The bandits aren't expecting resistance, so for initiative, allow each PC to choose any skill appropriate for their chosen tactics, such as Deception, Stealth, or Survival. In addition, the bandits themselves are so agog at being ambushed that they suffer a –2 circumstance bonus on their initiative checks and are flat-footed during the first round of combat.

If the characters don't bother hiding and decide to confront the bandits openly, they lose these elements of surprise. The bandits don't immediately attack, but quickly raise their guard. They pretend to be simple travelers seeking a quick breakfast and maybe a few hours of rest. If these circumstances force Oleg and Svetlana to interact with the bandits, either the Levetons endure their mistreatment (if Oleg feels Svetlana is at risk) or Oleg foolishly roars and attacks one of the bandits in an attempt to force a confrontation. If the PCs try to just wait out the bandits, they thank the Levetons for their food and leave without revealing their true purpose. Two days later, Happs returns with five bandits to try again. If the characters are still present, Happs and his bandits act more aggressively and add "rob the clueless strangers" to their list of crimes for the day. These circumstances cause Oleg and Svetlana to grow less friendly and more concerned that the "heroes" who have come to their home might not be any better than the bandits.



HAPPS BYDON

Happs is a crude and foul-mouthed man who turned to banditry after he was caught running a protection racket in Restov while serving as a soldier and city guard. He fled the city when he learned that the law was coming for him, abandoning his wife and two children to suffer the shame of his crimes. He's found that banditry agrees with him—he quite enjoys the outdoors and Kressle's companionship.

Happs is overconfident and enjoys boasting during battle, calling out attacks and hollow threats that he's ill-equipped to carry out. As the battle progresses, if his called attacks and threats continue to fail, he grows increasingly grim and quiet. He prefers to fight with his longbow, letting his bandits take the risks in melee. He uses his alchemist's fire against PCs in a tight group or against the stables as a distraction to draw the PCs out of combat and into firefighting or panicked horse control. The bandits themselves are classic bullies, eager to inflict pain but cowards at heart. They do their best to team up and flank foes at the start of a fight, but sometimes make poor tactical decisions (such as to waste rounds of combat chasing a foe at range rather than switching to longbows, or sometimes switching targets and leaving other bandits without a flanking partner).

Happs knows his position as second-in-command in the Thorn River bandits is tenuous at best. He hopes that a few more months of robbing the trading post will earn him a promotion, so he won't back down from a fight in front of his flunkies—as long as another bandit can see him, he fights to the death. The other bandits aren't as committed to the cause; they shriek in pain and fear when reduced to fewer than 6 Hit Points and attempt to flee back to the Thorn River bandit camp (page 169), on horseback if possible. If Happs

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

is defeated, any surviving bandits immediately flee. If all three of Happs's bandit crew are slain first, Happs immediately flees or, if he's taken damage, surrenders.

If Happs or any of his bandits are captured, they volunteer that Kressle, the leader of the Thorn River camp, will come for Oleg and Svetlana sooner rather than later, and if the brigands think any of their group have escaped to tell Kressle about the PCs, she'll seek revenge on the party as well. If Coerced, they will tell the PCs how to find their camp, or they will lead them there. They can also answer most of the questions about the Stag Lord that the bandits back at camp can answer (Interrogations, page 171), though they warn the PCs that they are no match for the Stag Lord.

HAPPS BYDON — CREATURE 0

UNIQUE | LE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Male human bandit

Perception +4

Languages Common

Skills Athletics +4, Intimidation +5, Nature +4, Stealth +5, Survival +4

Str +2, **Dex** +3, **Con** +2, **Int** +0, **Wis** +0, **Cha** +1

Items composite shortbow (20 arrows), dagger, leather armor, silver Stag Lord amulet (worth 3 gp), trail rations (2 days), 15 sp

AC 15; **Fort** +6, **Ref** +7, **Will** +4

HP 17

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ dagger +6 (agile, finesse, thrown 10 feet, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+2 piercing

Ranged ❖ composite shortbow +7 (deadly d10, propulsive, range increment 60 feet, reload 0), **Damage** 1d6+1 piercing

Ranged ❖ dagger +7 (agile, finesse, thrown 10 feet, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+1 piercing

Focused Target ❖ (concentrate) Happs designates a single creature he can see as his target; when he does so, he issues a litany of mockery at the target. Happs gains a +2 circumstance bonus to Survival checks to Track the target, and the first time he hits the target in a round, he deals an additional 1d8 precision damage to the target. These effects last until Happs uses Focused Target again.

THORN RIVER BANDITS (3) — CREATURE -1

UNCOMMON | CE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID | MINION

Human bandits

Perception +2

Languages Common

Skills Athletics +5, Intimidation +2, Stealth +4

Str +1, **Dex** +2, **Con** +1, **Int** +0, **Wis** +0, **Cha** +0

Items dagger, leather armor, shortbow (10 arrows), silver Stag Lord amulet (worth 3 gp), rations (2 days), 1d8 sp

AC 14; **Fort** +5, **Ref** +6, **Will** +2

HP 8

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ dagger +5 (agile, finesse, thrown 10 feet, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+1 piercing

Ranged ❖ shortbow +6 (deadly d10, range increment 60 feet, reload 0), **Damage** 1d6 piercing

Ranged ❖ dagger +6 (agile, finesse, thrown 10 feet, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4 piercing

Treasure: The silver amulet worn by each bandit indicates their association with the Stag Lord's army. It depicts an open-faced helmet made from the skull of a fanged predator, with antlers extending from the top of the helmet down either side. A PC examining a Stag Lord amulet can attempt a DC 17 Banditry Lore or a DC 20 Society check to Recall Knowledge. On a success, the PCs recalls rumors of a new bandit leader calling himself the "Stag Lord" rising in prominence in the Stolen Lands. On a critical success, the PC recalls hearing that the Stag Lord has been recruiting smaller bands of criminals under his banner, awarding these amulets to those who join his band.

SETTLING IN AT OLEG'S

This adventure assumes that the PCs defeat, or at least drive off, the bandits. While Oleg is worried the remaining bandits will come for revenge, he also suspects they're cowards at heart and won't try anything against the trading post for some time; hopefully before then, the aid promised by Restov will have arrived to bolster the post's defenses.

Thankful for the help, Oleg offers the group a reward consisting of 12 gp and all the potions and alchemical elixirs from his stockroom (area **A9**). Svetlana tells the PCs that they're welcome to stay in the guest house free of charge as long as they want, with meals provided for free. Oleg also lets the PCs take any bits of gear they want from the bandits, then claims anything left over as new stock. If the PCs claim the gear and propose selling it to Oleg, he'll gladly purchase it from them at full price as an additional way to thank the PCs for helping out, but he makes it perfectly clear that future transactions will be at regular prices (and he steadfastly pretends not to notice the look that Svetlana shoots him when he tells the party this).

Oleg's Trading Post should serve the PCs well as a home base until they're able to establish their own headquarters elsewhere in the Stolen Lands. You can use the trading post to introduce new information, rumors, and quests in the form of visitors, wanted posters, or the like. Chapter Two (page 52) provides additional information about life at Oleg's Trading Post, including key NPCs who visit the post (such as Kesten Garess and Jhod Kavken), and several opportunities the PCs might be offered while staying with Oleg and Svetlana.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



PART 2:

BANDITS OF THE GREENBELT

The Stag Lord keeps a fair number of bandits at his side in his fort on the northern shore of the Tuskwater, but not all the bandits are loyal to him. Several wander the wilds of the Greenbelt, allowed to do what banditry they can among travelers (even, at times, stealing north into Rostland) as long as their individual leaders report back to the fort once a month with their dues. He also maintains a second camp of bandits many miles north of his fort, at area **GB7** on the Thorn River. Not only does this camp give his wandering bandits a guaranteed safe place to gather and share news, but it also lets his followers control the northernmost ford in the Greenbelt. It is from the Thorn River camp that those who have been tormenting Oleg's Trading Post hail. Until the PCs deal with the Thorn River bandits, the brigands continue to harass travelers around the trading post. Left to their own devices for more than a month, they'll recruit enough new members to double both their numbers and resources. If they attain this feat, they launch a major attack on the trading post in an attempt to burn the place down for daring to defy their wishes.

After the PCs defend the trading post in Part 1 of this chapter, finding and defeating the bandits at the Thorn River camp should become a priority. If the PCs captured one of the bandits alive during Part 1 and successfully interrogated him, the bandit can lead the characters right to this camp. Alternately, a skilled

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

tracker can attempt a DC 15 Survival check to Track any bandit that fled the fight to the camp. The tracks lead back into the woods, then south to Thorn River, skirting the northern bank until they reach the bandit's creekside campsite.

THE THORN RIVER CAMP

The Thorn River bandit camp is relatively large, and well defended by several hidden platforms in the trees. The encampment itself is about 60 feet from the Thorn's north bank—a path winds alongside a shallow creek that leads directly up to the campsite. This path continues for another 200 feet north of the camp before turning into a standard game trail.

Points of interest within the camp's bounds are detailed below.

B1. CLEARING

The bandits created this semi-permanent campsite by cutting a small clearing. Tree trunks and logs serve as chairs, all centered around a stone-lined campfire. A heap of kindling and smaller sticks lies nearby. The bandits generally prefer to sleep under the stars but, for wetter nights, they keep six folded tents stored under the platform at area **B2**.

B2. EAST WATCH POST

A wooden platform 20 feet off the ground gives a great view of not only the campsite but also the trail leading off to the west. A rope ladder allows access; if it has been pulled up to the platform, access from below is still possible by succeeding at a DC 10 Athletics check to Climb one of the nearby trees. Tents, firewood, food, and other supplies are stored beneath a canvas tarp below this post.

Treasure: The bandits keep their loot here, hidden from casual view. The platform itself is somewhat camouflaged. Anyone using it to hide gains a +1 circumstance bonus to Stealth against anyone attempting to spot them from the ground. A lesser thunderstone is kept in a small hollow of the tree for use as needed to raise alarms.

B3. WEST WATCH POST

This post is identical to the east watch post, save that it contains no significant supplies other than a lesser thunderstone to be used as an alarm.

B4. THE LOGS

Two thick logs lie positioned alongside the forest trail. Bandits sometimes use the logs as cover or roll them across the path to create obstructions. Doing so requires DC 20 Athletics check made as a three-action Interact activity.

B5. THE WAGON

An old, broken-down wagon sits here.

Treasure: The bandits occasionally use the wagon as part of a set-up to dupe travelers, and they keep all the components needed to quickly construct a *spike snare* (*Core Rulebook* 591) handy here to aid in this pursuit.

THE BANDITS SEVERE 2

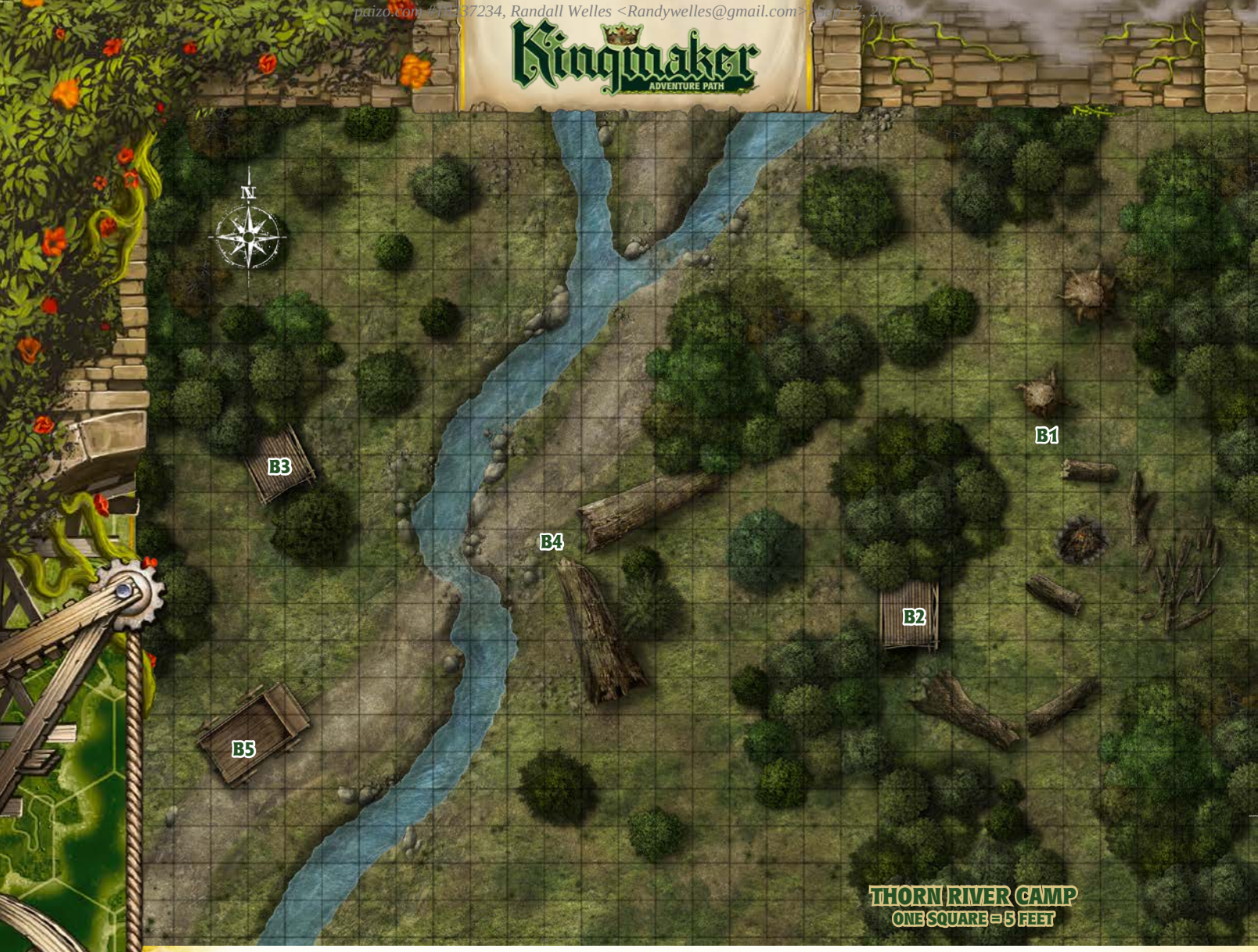
Creatures: A woman named Kressle leads the Thorn River bandits. A career bandit, she grew up in the River Kingdoms. Never spending more than a week in one spot when growing up, Kressle has banditry in her blood—as a child, she was already helping her parents rob travelers and rough up pilgrims for some quick cash. When her parents were killed during a botched roadside ambush, Kressle fled north from Mivon and into the Greenbelt. She made her way through the region with a bit of luck, only to be caught by the Stag Lord's bandits. When two of them lost fingers to her hatchets, their thoughts turned from robbery to escape, and she followed the maimed and frightened bandits right up to the Stag Lord's fort. Impressed with her skill and bravery, the Stag Lord executed the cowards who'd lost fingers and recruited Kressle on the spot. After serving at the fort for a few months, the Stag Lord sent her north to run the Thorn River bandit camp; she has enjoyed the resulting mix of freedom and responsibility. Her "arrangement" with Oleg is only the latest of her initiatives enacted since her arrival in the area.

Kressle and Happs live with nine other bandits in the Thorn River camp; though, during the day, only six would typically remain on site. Happs took three of them with him on his ill-fated trip to Oleg's, leaving Kressle with six other bandits to hold the camp. If the bandits anticipate the characters' arrival and have at least a day to prepare for the encounter, Kressle makes sure all six of her surviving minions are present and prepared to defend the camp. If not, when the characters first arrive, they encounter just four bandits, with the others having left for the day to hunt, gather firewood, and patrol. If the characters take longer than three days to reach the camp, the bandits learn what happened to Happs, and all remain in camp.

One bandit always remains stationed on the watch platform at area **B2** and another at area **B3**; if either one perceives a threat to the camp, they use the thunderstone at their station to raise the alarm and hopefully disorient intruders, then fire arrows down at any visible threats while the remaining bandits at area **B1** grab their weapons and join the fight. If the bandits expect the PCs, they post an additional bandit hidden behind the logs at area **B4** and heap some of their loot atop a *spike snare* in the wagon at area **B5** hoping to lure greedy characters into its slashing jaws.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



KRESSLE CREATURE 1

UNIQUE | NE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Female bandit leader

Perception +6

Languages Common

Skills Athletics +8, Intimidation +7, Nature +5, Stealth +7, Survival +6

Str +3, **Dex** +2, **Con** +1, **Int** +0, **Wis** +1, **Cha** +2

Items hatchets (2), *lesser healing potion*, studded leather, silver Stag Lord amulet (worth 3 gp), 8 gp, 5 sp

AC 15; **Fort** +8, **Ref** +7, **Will** +6

HP 22

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ hatchet +8 (agile, sweep, thrown 10 feet), **Damage** 1d6+3 slashing

Ranged ❖ hatchet +7 (agile, sweep, thrown 10 feet), **Damage** 1d6+1 slashing

Hatchet Flurry ❖ **Frequency** once per round; **Requirement** She wields hatchets in each hand; **Effect** She attacks with both hatchets, making two Strikes at the same target. Apply her multiple attack penalty to each Strike normally.

Maiming Chop Kressle has a violent knack for striking grievous wounds to her opponent's hands. If she scores a critical hit on a target with a hatchet Strike, the target must succeed at a DC 17 Fortitude save or become clumsy 1 (or clumsy 2 on a critical failure). This condition persists until the target receives any amount of healing.

THORN RIVER BANDITS (6) CREATURE -1

Page 167

Initiative Perception +2 or Stealth +4

Treasure: The bandits' spoils are hidden under mundane supplies like food, firewood, and tents beneath the platform at area **B2**. Their stash currently includes 9 gp, 121 sp, a pair of silver earrings worth 15 gp, a wooden music box worth 8 gp, three crates of furs and pelts worth 5 gp per crate, and 8 bottles of herbal liquor, each worth 2 gp.

The liquor was specifically requested by the Stag Lord, and a captured bandit can inform the characters that if the Stag Lord doesn't get this shipment, he'll

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

likely grow more aggressive. If the PCs use the liquor as part of a ruse to enter the Stag Lord's fort, the Stag Lord drinks an entire bottle almost immediately. The precise effects of liquor shipments on the Stag Lord are described on page 174.

Characters looking for Svetlana's wedding ring (quest on page 53) won't find it here, as it was recently stolen by mitflits and spirited away to the Old Sycamore (area **GB14**).

INTERROGATIONS

So long as Kressle remains alive, the bandits remain relatively loyal and well behaved. As soon as the PCs defeat Kressle, however, their loyalty to the Stag Lord vanishes, and they attempt to flee. Those who can't escape quickly surrender and beg for mercy. Like an increasing number of the Stag Lord's bandits, these thugs are dissatisfied with the rule of their master, whose grip on reality seems to be slipping into the bottom of a whiskey cask. While they continue to support their lord, they aren't foolish enough to die for him, nor do they pass up any seemingly good opportunities. No bandit offers to help the characters before learning the hard way that they are outclassed, but characters can convince those captured alive to reveal crucial information concerning both the Stag Lord and the Greenbelt itself.

Once a bandit surrenders, their responses to likely questions are as follows.

Who's your boss? "Our boss is a monster of a man. Calls himself the Stag Lord. He's a deadeye with the bow, and I saw him crush a prisoner's hand to mush in one fist. Come to think of it, I've never seen him without his creepy stag helmet on—some say he ain't got no face under it, but not me—I think that creepy helm *is* his face!"

How many bandits work for your boss? "It's hard keeping track of who's working for the boss, so we use a master phrase as a sort of password to get into the fort on the northeast shore of the Tuskwater."

What's the password? "Unless it's been changed recently, the current phrase is, 'By the bloody bones of Saint Gilmorg, who wants to know?' And no, I have no idea who 'Saint Gilmorg' is."

What's with all the booze? What is the Stag Lord like? "The Stag Lord is a bloody drunk. All that booze under the platform is for him. He's half of what he used to be, and he ain't never been right in the head. I hear he punched a horse for spittin' in the yard a few weeks ago. Personally, I wouldn't care if he dropped dead tomorrow, but even drunk out of his mind, he's still got a fair amount of fight to him."

Who's the Stag Lord's boss? Are there any other bosses? "The Stag Lord keeps a strange old man locked up in the basement. I suspect the old guy might actually be running the show, using the Stag Lord as a puppet, you know. I got a look into the old guy's eyes once, and it terrified me. He ain't someone I'd want to cross."

Where's Svetlana's Ring? "A couple of bags of loot were stolen a while back by a group of filthy gremlins—the annoying little pests live under the old sycamore tree to the east. We were lucky that what they snatched was mostly just copper and some cheap-looking trinkets, otherwise the Stag Lord would have our skins for sure! That ring we took from the trader woman was in there, though, I'm sure of it."

Will you help us fight the Stag Lord? The bandits fear the Stag Lord, and if this topic comes up, they blanch and shake their heads in fear.



KRESSLE

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



PART 3:

AGAINST THE STAG LORD

The Stag Lord and his bandits represent the first major threat the PCs must face in the Stolen Lands, and his potential defeat means more than just safety for Oleg and Svetlana—it symbolizes the adventurers' growing control over their domain and proves to Restov that the PCs have what it takes to begin their own kingdom. Certainly, as word spreads of the Stag Lord's demise, other would-be bandit gangs think twice before looking at moving in on his territory!

Defeating the Stag Lord won't be easy for the PCs at the start of this Adventure Path—they should take their time building up their resources and abilities first. At the very least they should have dealt with their bitter rivalry with Tartuccio (as described in Chapter Two on page 41) before turning their attention to the Stag Lord.

THE STAG LORD'S FORT

The PCs can learn the location of the Stag Lord's fort by interrogating bandits or simply exploring—it's a landmark on its own, after all, and difficult to miss once one reaches the largest lake in the Greenbelt. It is located at area **TW3** on the map of the Stolen Lands.

Full details on the Stag Lord can be found on page 604.

THE BANDITS

Although the bandits involved in the attack on Oleg's Trading Post, the bandits stationed at the Thorn River camp, and the bandits the characters might run into as wandering monsters all serve the Stag Lord, only a select few are allowed to live in the fort with him: three lieutenants and seven other bandits. If the PCs

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

manage to thin their ranks via multiple forays against the fort, assume that enough bandits roam the hills for the Stag Lord to replenish 1d6 bandits each day; he cannot replace his three officers.

Although the seven bandits are identical as far as game statistics go, they remain unique individuals. Listed below are brief descriptions of each bandit—you can use these notes to give each a personality, especially if the PCs decide to infiltrate the fort disguised as new bandit recruits.

Ayles Megesen: Ayles is a soft-spoken man whose calm demeanor should not be taken for passivity. Ayles enjoys the act of torture the most among the bandits, and often spends hours after a fight "exploring" surviving victims.

Cragger Kench: A former cutpurse, Cragger was beaten senseless by the Stag Lord for stealing and drinking a bottle of his liquor. His injuries have left him resentful and cautious with concern to provoking his leader's wrath—causing him to take long pauses before speaking.

Backhanded Jeb Megesen: Ayle's younger brother, Backhanded Jeb believes he got his nickname for the powerful strike he's accustomed to unleashing on foes, when in fact he earned his moniker by talking out both sides of his mouth.

Falgrim Sneeg: Falgrim Sneeg is an older Varisian man with graying hair and an unruly beard. A former mercenary, he possesses an unnerving calm in the face of violence. He is the target of Kesten Garess's plot for revenge (more information can be found in the Finding Falgrim quest on page 54).

Norry "Gorgon" Driper: Smaller than only Auchs, Norry tends to snort and rumble like an enraged bull, exhibit clumsiness in rooms full of fragile treasure, and sport rancid breath that his fellow bandits claim could easily petrify the living. He wanted "Ox" as his nickname in the band, but alas, it was already taken.

Jex the Snitch: The least popular with the men but perhaps the Stag Lord's favorite minion is this aptly nicknamed man. His penchant for reporting the other bandits' mistakes to the Stag Lord is likely to earn him a shallow grave before long.

Topper Red: Topper Red was a struggling street poet from Pitax. He fled that city when an affair turned sour, and he eventually joined the Stag Lord's ranks while romanticizing the thrilling life of a lawless brigand.

THE LIEUTENANTS

In addition to the seven rank-and-file bandits, the Stag Lord keeps three notable lieutenants on hand, each for a different reason. Orders from any of these three men are generally followed without hesitation; only when an order directly contradicts the Stag Lord's commands (implied or otherwise) will the other bandits question a lieutenant.

Akiros Ismort: Of the three lieutenants, Akiros is the least satisfied with his lot in life—but that's nothing new for him. Akiros's parents were simple farmers in a proud rural area in Taldor, and they wanted to raise him to be a protector of the town—as a paladin of Erastil, no less. Every moment of Akiros's life was spent in preparation for his acceptance into the order, yet not one month after he achieved his parents' dream and became a paladin, Akiros fell in love with the married daughter of one of his hometown's wealthier merchants, a woman named Rosilla. The affair ended all too soon when Rosilla's husband found out and confronted Akiros in public. When Rosilla publicly announced that the fling with Akiros was a mistake, the would-be paladin's true nature came to the surface: He flew into a fury and killed both Rosilla and her husband. With dozens of witnesses in shock at his unexpected violence, he fled his hometown forever.

Akiros barely made it out of Taldor, stowing away on a merchant ship bound up the Sellen River for Mendev. Akiros switched ships dozens of times as he fled north, losing himself in the River Kingdoms, living as a bandit, a vagabond, and a criminal, where he grew to enjoy his newfound rages. Recently, his wanderings took him into the Stolen Lands. He'd heard of the Stag Lord and, still unsure of where he needed to be in life, he sought out this new liege. Akiros has been with the Stag Lord only a few months, but already his commanding presence has earned the leader's favor; Akiros is now second-in-command, much to Dovan's displeasure. Ironically, Akiros has come to the realization that life as a bandit is even more hollow than his life as a paladin of Erastil was, and when the PCs make their attack on the fort, he sees in them an opportunity for a new life and, perhaps, redemption. At some point, once the battle for the fort begins, you should have Akiros tear the Stag Lord amulet from his throat, cast it aside, and step in to fight with the characters. This can either be at a point where things are looking bad for the characters and they could use a little extra help, or it can be at the start of the battle.

Auchs: Auchs is as simple as Akiros is complex. A lumbering lummox of a man, Auchs is simpleminded in everything but cruelty. He loves the sound of sobbing and screaming when the sounds aren't coming from him, and he gleefully crushes and pummels bandits and prisoners alike according to the commands of his fellow lieutenants or the Stag Lord. Illiterate, Auchs can spell only his name—and he's no longer sure about that, since Dovan gleefully taunted him that it's spelled "Ox." He's traveled with Dovan for the past six months, ever since the smaller man saved

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

him from being killed for starting a deadly brawl in a Daggermark marketplace. Auchs is rarely far from Dovan's side, although he is taking an increasing liking to Akiros (much to Akiros's annoyance).

Dovan from Nisroch: Until Akiros usurped the role, Dovan was comfortably the second-in-command of the fort. Secretly pleased with the Stag Lord's alcoholism, Dovan has been actively encouraging the man to drink, for as long as the Stag Lord is in his cups, more power over the bandits rests in Dovan's hands. Dovan himself is a mystery to the bandits—a dark, tattooed figure with an obvious taste for pain and cruelty. All they know of him is that he claims to hail from Nisroch.

In fact, Dovan hails from Ustalav, where he grew up amid the horrors of the Widow's Boudoir in Caliphas. When he discovered that he was on the menu for a particularly violent evening, Dovan gathered his things and quietly fled town, spending the next several months enjoying all the decadences and freedoms the River Kingdoms had to offer. After a close call with a press gang, Dovan "recruited" Auchs by saving the huge man from a brawl Dovan engineered. Dovan often grows tired of Auchs's childish talk but is just as pleased with how well the oaf takes to torture—and the security his friendship brings can't be denied. Of late, Dovan has been plotting ways to kill Akiros, but he can see how much the Stag Lord and the other bandits admire him, so he knows he needs to make his move subtly. Before the PCs arrived, his best idea was to somehow get Auchs to attack and kill the fallen paladin, but he has yet to come upon a reliable way to goad Auchs into attacking Akiros.

BANDIT CANT

The Stag Lord's bandits often speak in slang and catchphrases to prevent outsiders from understanding their plans. Two key phrases are noted below.

Master Phrase: The bandits use this phrase to identify themselves to whomever is working the main gate. When spoken, the gate opens. The Stag Lord changes the phrase regularly as a safety precaution, or in the event he believes the phrase has been compromised. The current master phrase is "By the bloody bones of Saint Gilmorg, who wants to know?"

Infiltrated Phrase: Bandits speak this phrase if they believe an outsider has infiltrated their ranks or they suspect a traitor. The current infiltrated phrase is "And so the stink marks the jackal in a den of wolves."

METHODS OF APPROACH

The method the characters settle on for approaching and handling the Stag Lord's fort is up to them, but two options are particularly likely.

Infiltration: The characters might bank on the fact that the bandits at the fort don't know all the bandits who work for the Stag Lord in the Stolen Lands. Certainly, if they learn the master phrase from the bandits at the Thorn River camp, they'll have a ticket into the fort. By dressing in defeated bandits' clothes and openly displaying a stash of supposedly stolen goods, the characters gain a +2 circumstance bonus on checks made to Disguise themselves as bandits or Lie about their motives; if they display the alcohol from the Thorn River camp, the results of those checks are shifted up one degree of success.

News of an alcohol delivery spreads swiftly, causing the Stag Lord to emerge joyfully from his room in area **C8**, seize the liquor, and instruct Akiros to "pay these fine people a bonus of 5 gold coins each" before he returns to his quarters to drink himself into a stupor. It takes the Stag Lord an hour to pass out, at which point stealthy characters might even steal into his chamber and ambush the slumbering bandit lord. Poisoning the liquor is also a potential solution for taking out the Stag Lord. If any such attempt fails to kill the Stag Lord, though, he wakens filled with anger and calls for full support, in which case the PCs might find themselves fighting the entire bandit camp at once.

Particularly crafty characters could work to lure away individual bandits to a secluded place to kill, incapacitate, or even recruit them. They could even try to sow seeds of dissent—if the characters interact with the bandits and learn their personalities, getting the bandits to turn on one another proves a very real option, provided the characters are able to succeed at enough Diplomacy checks to Make an Impression or Request, Deception to Lie to plant the idea of insurrection, or Intimidation to Coerce a bandit into taking action.

Assault: The Stag Lord's fort is heavily defended, and even if the characters can get inside the walls, the bandits are wily and tenacious foes. A combination of infiltration (to get inside) and assault (once the characters are in position) might work the best. Once a fight begins, the bandits raise the alarm by shouting, but the Stag Lord himself doesn't immediately respond, misinterpreting the alarm for general bandit roughhousing and then fighting against a sudden bout of sickness and dizziness from his latest binge. You can thus delay the Stag Lord's entrance into the battle for a particularly dramatic moment—perhaps just as the characters think they're about done with the fight, or after they suddenly gain Akiros's aid, or maybe even as they're trying to flee. With the death of the Stag Lord, the will of the remaining bandits breaks and they flee the fort quickly, not eager to face justice at the PCs' hands. In this event, only Akiros stays behind to offer the characters his continued aid. Dovan and Auchs flee with the rest, although Dovan could well return later

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

on to plague the characters, particularly if one of them caught his eye as a possible victim to torture (Dovan prefers elves for this grisly pursuit).

THE HAUNTED HILLSIDE — SEVERE 3

A narrow path of hard-packed earth winds up the hillside approaching the Stag Lord's fort—this path is 30 feet wide, 300 feet long, and provides no cover. The remaining hillside surrounding the fort is devoid of shrubbery save for isolated thorny vines, but a few large boulders provide cover for a stealthy approach. If the PCs observe the fort from the cover of heavily vegetated hills 300 feet away, succeeding at a DC 15 Perception check reveals that the guards who stand at watch don't seem to keep much of an attentive eye on the hillsides.

There's a reason for this, and one that helped the Stag Lord settle on this location as his fort: The ruins he has chosen to live in were once a small monastery dedicated to Gyronna, a lesser-known goddess of extortion, hatred, and spite whose faith has always been strong in the River Kingdoms. Yet when the monks lapsed from proper worship and began to leave their cruel ways behind in favor of a more minimalist monastic lifestyle, Gyronna grew insulted. One night, she caused the dead of the monastery's extensive graveyard (which surrounded the monastery on the south, east, and west hillsides) to rise up and attack the monks, dragging their still-living bodies into the earth and leaving the building abandoned.

Creatures: The unquiet dead still lurk in the soil of the surrounding hillside, even though their unmarked graves are forgotten. The bandits learned the hard way that the former residents do not take kindly to intrusions upon their place of interment—while the main path to the fort doesn't encroach on any burial sites, approaching from any other landward route rouses the undead guardians. The ancient curse laid by Gyronna allows them to emerge from the ground anywhere from 30 to 150 feet from the fort.

Initial contact with the ground causes the earth to burst open as four zombie shamblers lurch from their resting places to attack the intruder. Each zombie erupts from the dirt within 20 feet of a PC. The undead are prone at the start of their turn, and the squares in which they emerged are treated as difficult terrain due to the nasty-smelling divots in the land their emergence leaves behind. In all, there are 12 zombies haunting the hillside. At the beginning of each round, attempt a DC 10 flat check. On a success, one additional zombie erupts from the ground; on a critical success, two zombies join the fray. This continues each round until all 12 zombies have emerged to join the battle. If the characters are swift about dispatching the zombies, they can avoid being overwhelmed. Of course, a fight against zombies immediately attracts the attention of the bandits, who may or may not take a few pot shots at the characters.

FIGHTING BANDITS

Each of the encounters in this part gives difficulty ratings for a 3rd-level party who confronts only the bandits specifically encountered there—individually, these fights would be relatively simple combats, but any confrontation in the fort is likely to swiftly alert every bandit at once. An all-out brawl with all 10 bandits is beyond an Extreme 3 encounter, so if your group is only 3rd level you should strive to have the bandits rally in waves rather than forcing the PCs to take them all on at once. As a general rule, it's best if the PCs don't face all three of the lieutenants at once. Of course, canny PCs will find ways to turn the lieutenants against each other, or even recruit one to their side!

Once the Stag Lord himself enters the battle, he can quickly overwhelm the situation. As a result, you should either time his entrance for after the PCs have defeated most of the other bandits or have recruited "aid" in the form of an angry owlbear or defecting lieutenant. Alternatively, when he enters the battle, you can simply have the other bandits step back out of fearful respect to let the Stag Lord fight without implying he needs help.

ZOMBIE SHAMBLERS (12) — CREATURE -1

Pathfinder Bestiary 340
Initiative Perception +0

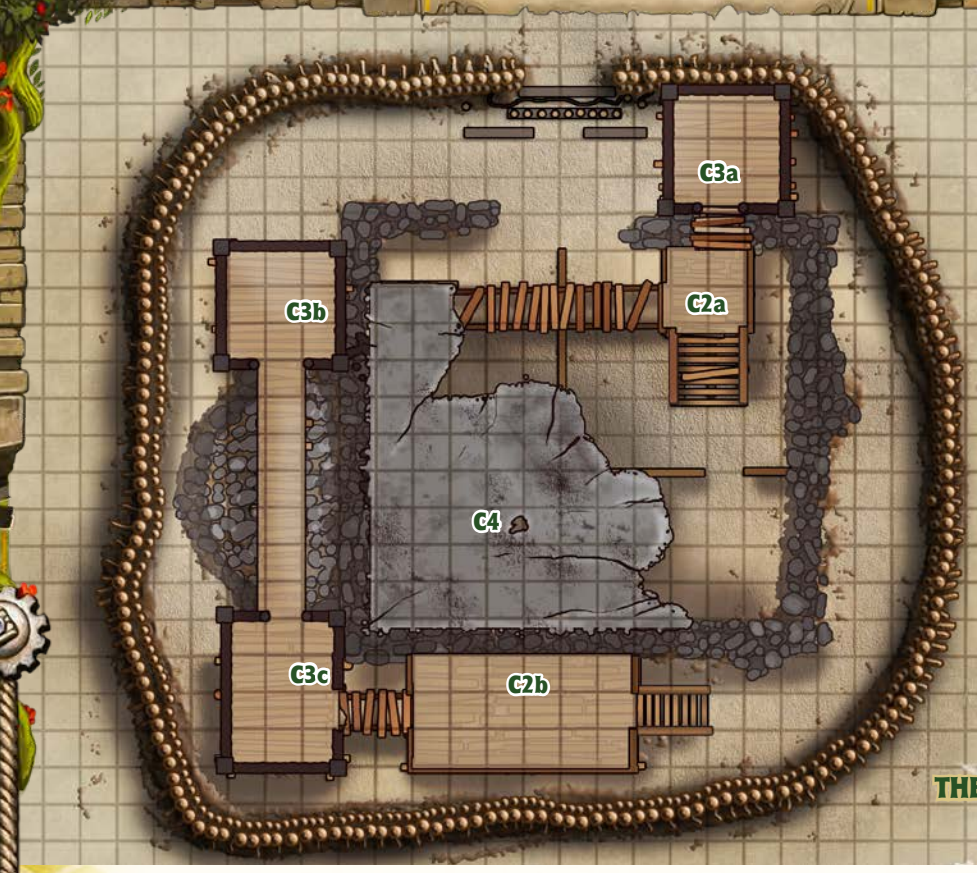
THE PALISADE

The palisade surrounding the fort is 15 feet high, consisting of vertical logs sharpened into spikes at the top. A 30-foot-wide zone around the outer perimeter of the palisade does not trigger any zombies (see above), although already active zombies can pursue PCs into this area. Succeeding at a DC 20 Athletics check allows a character to Climb the palisade, but clambering over the top requires success on a DC 15 Reflex save to avoid taking 1d6 piercing damage from spikes and splinters. A critical failure on the Reflex save results in the climber losing their grip and falling on the side of their choice, delivering an additional 7 bludgeoning damage; if this character successfully Grabs an Edge to arrest the fall they instead take another 1d6 piercing damage from the spikes (DC 15 basic Reflex save).

Just southeast of the fort, a slightly sunken section of ground covers a forgotten stone trapdoor. Succeeding at a DC 20 Perception check allows a character to note

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023





THE STAG LORD'S FORT
ONE SQUARE = 5 FEET

that there's something strange about the area; on a critical success, the character immediately realizes the sunken area covers a buried trapdoor. If the PCs want to try to access this trapdoor, one PC must take the Dig Up the Trapdoor exploration activity—additional PCs can aid that character by Following the Expert. Once the trapdoor is exposed, it can be opened, but doing so requires success at a DC 15 Stealth check to avoid making too much noise and alerting a guard in the fort. Once opened, the door reveals a 10-foot-deep shaft down to area **C11b**.

DIG UP THE TRAPDOOR

EXPLORATION MANIPULATE

Digging up the trapdoor requires a DC 18 Athletics check, but PCs lacking proper tools (such as shovels) suffer a –2 item penalty. A PC can substitute a spell attack roll for this Athletics check if the spellcaster comes up with a creative way to excavate the soil. Digging Up the Trapdoor automatically alerts the guards in the fort if any PC involved in the activity fails any Stealth check (DC 25 during the day, but just DC 15 during the night) as determined by the result of the Athletics check to Dig.

Critical Success The project takes 5 minutes and requires only 1 Stealth check.

Success The project takes 10 minutes and requires 2 Stealth checks.

Failure The project takes 15 minutes and requires 3 Stealth checks.

Critical Failure The project takes 20 minutes and requires 4 Stealth checks.

C1. THE YARD TRIVIAL 3

A small, dusty yard separates the palisade from the inner structures. The ground here is hard-packed, barren earth. A few barrels lie against the inner wall of the palisade, with wooden or metal buckets nearby.

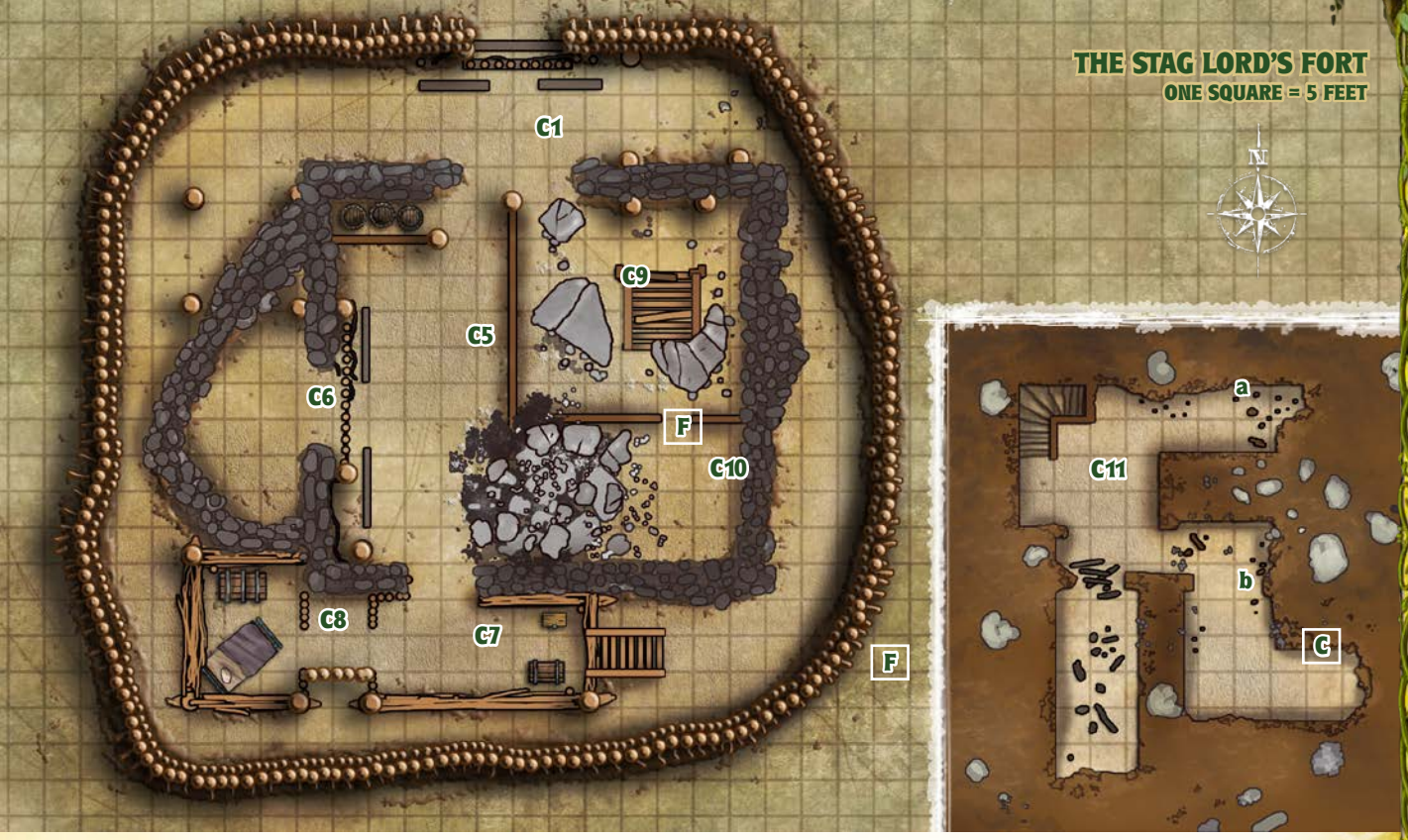
This inner yard encompasses the entire central structure of the reclaimed building, although the walls come quite close to the palisade in places. The barrels contain drinking water that can also be used in a pinch to fight fires.

Creatures: The bandits keep two horses in the fort. The horses are hitched in cramped conditions under the northeast watchtower (area **C3a**). Initially, both horses seem somewhat skittish and make noise at the PCs' approach unless soothed. To calm both horses at once, a PC must succeed at a DC 15 Nature check to Command an Animal.

As might be expected, bandits don't make the most thoughtful masters, and the horses aren't particularly loyal to them. Any character attempting to communicate with the horses by using *speak with*

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



animals or similar abilities can learn quite a bit about the bandits, including their personalities (but not names), and the areas where they're normally found, as well as the fact that there's a scary monster that likes to eat horses kept inside the fort in a cave.

RIDING HORSES (2) CREATURE 1

Pathfinder Bestiary 209
Initiative Perception +5

C2. WALKWAYS

The fort has two 20-foot-high wooden walkways. The northern one (area **C2a**) connects the armory (area **C9**) to the northeast watchtower and the central roof. The southern one (area **C2b**) leads from the yard (area **C1**) to the southwest and northwest watchtowers. The stairs leading up to the walkways are steep, functioning as difficult terrain. Both walkways are creaky, imposing a –2 circumstance penalty to Stealth checks.

C3. WATCHTOWERS TRIVIAL 3

The bandits erected these three watchtowers to give themselves a sheltered place to keep watch. Each watchtower is 20 feet high, with a peaked roof arching another 10 feet above, and is surrounded by a two-foot-high wooden railing that grants those within the tower cover from outside attack.

Creatures: One bandit stands guard in each tower. If a guard spots anyone, he shouts a warning to the others and stands ready to fire with his longbow if it becomes apparent that the visitors are troublemakers. When the PCs first arrive, Ayles Megesen stands watch at **C3a**, Falgrim Sneeg at **C3b**, and Jex the Snitch at **C3c**. The last of those posts is regarded as the least desirable, since noise there can rouse the Stag Lord's anger in his barracks directly below; more than one bandit has suffered a beating for walking too loudly here.

If any of these bandits sees one of the others die, the other two lose their nerve and retreat to area **C5** to warn their fellow bandits there.

STAG LORD BANDITS (3) CREATURE 0

UNCOMMON | NE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Human bandits
Perception +4
Languages Common
Skills Athletics +4, Intimidation +4, Nature +4, Stealth +5, Survival +4
Str +2, **Dex** +3, **Con** +2, **Int** +0, **Wis** +0, **Cha** +0
Items composite longbow (20 arrows), *lesser healing potion*, longsword, studded leather, silver Stag Lord amulet (worth 3 gp), 1d8 gp

AC 15; **Fort** +6, **Ref** +7, **Will** +4
HP 16

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Speed 25 feet
Melee ❖ longsword +6 (versatile P), **Damage** 1d8+1 slashing
Ranged ❖ composite longbow +7 (deadly d10, propulsive, range increment 100 feet, reload 0, volley 30 feet), **Damage** 1d8+1 piercing

C4. CENTRAL TOWER TRIVIAL 3

At the center of the fort, thick stone walls surround a cracked and crumbling platform of heavy stone. Huge chunks of the roof collapsed long ago, shattering into the rooms below. Sediment collects in cracks and along corners of the remaining roof, sprouting tiny blades of grass and rivulets of moss. A bedroll on a pile of straw sits in the center of the platform, a small collection of toy knights and dragons surrounding it.



AUCHS

Creature: This flat-topped central area may look unsafe, but the remaining roof is actually quite sound. This central tower is the abode of the slowest-witted of the bandits, the lummox Auchs. He doesn't mind sleeping in the rain at all, and his collection of knight and dragon toys are his pride and joy. If they're hurt or touched in any way, his rage is instant—he attacks the interloper until the toys are released no matter who it is. The other bandits have come to learn this and avoid messing with the toys as a result.

Auchs is singularly unimaginative in battle, roaring wordlessly and wielding his club in both hands. He fights to the death if Dovan is visible, but otherwise surrenders and begs for his life if brought below 5 HP. If granted mercy, Auchs happily becomes the loyal companion of whoever "saved" him, but his natural tendency toward cruelty will eventually make for later problems.

AUCHS CREATURE 2

UNIQUE | CE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Male human bandit lieutenant
Perception +6
Languages Common (cannot read)
Skills Athletics +10, Survival +4
Str +4, **Dex** +2, **Con** +4, **Int** –2, **Wis** +0, **Cha** –1
Items club, knight and dragon toys worth 45 sp, leather armor, *lesser healing potions* (2), leather armor, silver Stag Lord amulet (worth 3 gp)

AC 15; **Fort** +12, **Ref** +5, **Will** +3
HP 40

Speed 25 feet
Melee ❖ club +10 (thrown 10 feet), **Damage** 1d6+6 bludgeoning
Hit 'Em Hard ❖❖ Auchs unleashes a particularly powerful attack and makes a melee club Strike that counts as two attacks when calculating his multiple attack penalty. If this strike hits, he deals an extra 1d6 points of damage; on a critical hit, the creature struck must succeed at a DC 18 Fortitude save or be knocked prone.

C5. CENTRAL ROOM MODERATE 3

The edges of this drafty room are crammed with small goods. Dirty bowls and utensils lie on the floor next to a few crumpled bedrolls, and a chamber pot sits tucked into a corner. Despite the draft, a noticeable stink of unwashed bodies and stale food lies heavy in the air. A large iron gate is wedged behind a ten-foot-wide gap in the western wall. Chips of ancient plaster flake from the walls, exposing the stone construction; whatever plaster still clings to the stonework is covered with strange and erratic scribbles and pictographs. The floor is hard-packed earth. In the southeastern corner, a pile of rubble fallen

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

from the platform twenty feet above blocks passage to another room.

A PC who succeeds at a DC 15 Religion check to Recall Knowledge recognizes that the wall markings are ancient graffiti left by the long-departed cultists of Gyronna.

Creatures: The first time the PCs visit this room, Dovan is here with four other bandits. Cragger, Topper, and Backhanded Jeb are quietly playing a complex card game, trying to keep their voices down so as not to annoy the Stag Lord, though the former two are growing increasingly frustrated with Backhanded Jeb's twisting, endless arguments about the rules. Norry tears into a whole roast turkey at one table, and Dovan sits quietly in a chair in the corner, sharpening his knives.

If the alarm is raised as a result of the PCs approaching the fort openly, all of these bandits save for Dovan (who remains seated) move out to area **C1** to greet the visitors. If the characters claim to be bandits or have a delivery, one of them fetches Akiros from area **C7**, and it's him the PCs need to convince of their honesty in order to gain entrance.

A rope tied to a stake near the gate to area **C6** is used to open the gate; it requires a total of three Interact actions to undo the rope and tug on it to lift the gate, releasing Beaky from area **C6**. The bandits release Beaky only if things are going poorly, as they know the owlbear is likely to attack whatever it can get its claws on. The bandits work together to open his cage, so that each can Stride away after the gate is opened.

If the PCs attack the guards in the yard, Dovan watches from this area for a round or two to judge how tough these intruders are. As soon as the PCs knock out a bandit, Dovan releases the gate to the owlbear's cage then flees into area **C1**, luring the owlbear out into the open before he dodges into area **C9**, then climbs up to area **C2a**, leaving the owlbear distracted by the easier-to-reach PCs. If forced into a fight, Dovan attempts to flank opponents with his fellow bandits. He tries to flee into the wilds if reduced to fewer than 7 HP (and could well come back for revenge against the PCs later), but if cornered, he fights to the death.

DOVAN FROM NISROCH CREATURE 2

UNIQUE | NE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Male human bandit lieutenant

Perception +8

Languages Common, Shadowtongue

Skills Acrobatics +6, Athletics +7, Deception +8, Society +6, Stealth +8, Thievery +8

Str +1, **Dex** +4 **Con** +1, **Int** +2, **Wis** +0, **Cha** +2

Items daggers (3), *+1 rapier*, silver Stag Lord amulet (worth 3 gp), studded leather, turquoise earrings worth 13 gp each, 2 gp, 28 sp

AC 18; **Fort** +7, **Ref** +10, **Will** +6

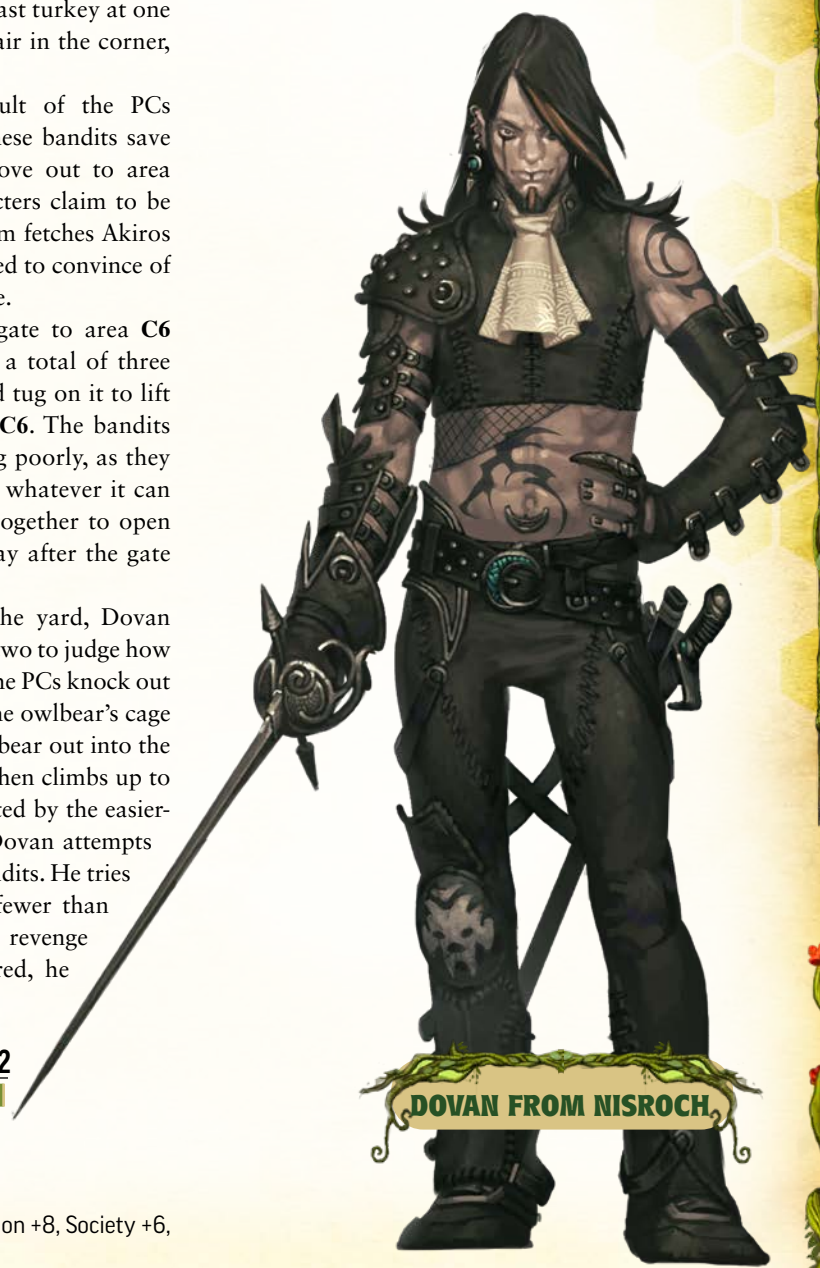
HP 30

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *rapier* +12 (deadly d8, disarm, finesse), **Damage** 1d6+3 piercing

Melee ❖ dagger +11 (agile, finesse, thrown 10 feet, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+3 piercing

Ranged ❖ dagger +11 (agile, finesse, thrown 10 feet, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+1 piercing



DOVAN FROM NISROCH

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Mobility When Dovan takes Strides and moves half his Speed or less, that movement does not trigger reactions.

Nimble Dodge ↷ **Trigger** A creature targets Dovan with an attack, and he can see the attacker. **Effect** Dovan gains a +2 circumstance bonus to AC against the triggering attack.

Sneak Attack Dovan deals an additional 1d6 precision damage to flat-footed creatures.

STAG LORD BANDITS (4) CREATURE 0

UNCOMMON | NE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Page 177

Initiative Perception +4

C6. OWLBEAR PEN LOW 3

This area is little more than an atrocious-smelling cave dug out of a pile of rubble. Large, bloody bones, likely from horses or elk, lie scattered on the ground.

Creature: Two weeks ago, during a hunt, the bandits brought down an owlbear. Rather than killing the creature for food, the Stag Lord took a liking to the strange beast and ordered the bandits to haul the unconscious-but-still-living monster back to the fort. They put the owlbear in this chamber and rigged a gate out of an old portcullis they scavenged from the main entrance. The owlbear has since recovered fully from its wounds, and it roars and hoots every night, keeping the bandits awake but, strangely, not annoying the Stag Lord, who has taken to calling the monster by the name "Beaky." The bandits keep it fed by tossing chunks of elk and other meat through the bars, enough so that it hasn't yet tried to break out of its cage.

If the gate is opened, the owlbear rumbles out of the cage to attack the closest target. Releasing Beaky from his cage makes noise enough to wake the Stag Lord, who stumbles out of his room after spending 1d4+4 rounds rousing from his stupor. If Beaky confronts the Stag Lord, the owlbear hesitates for just a moment before betraying its would-be master and attacking him.

BEAKY CREATURE 4

Owlbear (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 259)

Initiative Perception +13

C7. STORAGE ROOM TRIVIAL 3

This long room contains a few piled crates, bags, salvaged lumber, and boxes of dried meat, cheese, and bread. A bedroll is unrolled on the dirt, and a small lantern sits on a nearby crate.

This room serves two purposes—first as storage for basic supplies such as grains, dry goods, firewood, tools, and dried meat.

Creature: The second purpose this room serves is as housing for the Stag Lord's bodyguard and second-in-command. Until recently, that role was filled by Dovan, but Akiros currently has that honor—an honor he's not sure he wants. The awkward combination of bitter resentment and blatant fawning the position creates among the other bandits annoys Akiros, and he has been waiting patiently for his opportunity to turn on the Stag Lord and perhaps extract himself from membership in the group. He has grown moodier and gloomier as a result and spends most of his time sleeping or brooding in this room, sharpening his weapons, oiling his armor, or writing his memoirs in a small journal.

Akiros fights with the ferocity of one who doesn't care if he lives or dies; he rages on the first round of combat, and focuses his attacks first on healers, then other spellcasters, and finally on non-spellcasters. He fights to the death.

AKIROS ISMORT CREATURE 3

UNIQUE | CN | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Male human bandit lieutenant

Perception +10

Languages Common

Skills Athletics +11, Intimidation +9, Religion +7, Survival +7

Str +4, **Dex** +1, **Con** +3, **Int** +0, **Wis** +0, **Cha** +2

Items chainmail, composite longbow (20 arrows), *lesser healing potions* (2), *+1 longsword*, steel shield, rusted iron holy symbol of Erastil, silver Stag Lord amulet (worth 3 gp), 8 gp

AC 18; **Fort** +11, **Ref** +8, **Will** +7

HP 53

Shameful Memories (emotion, mental, visual) If Akiros sees another creature openly wearing Erastil's holy symbol, he must attempt a DC 15 Will save. Unless he critically fails his saving throw, he is temporarily immune to Shameful Memories for 24 hours.

Critical Success Akiros is unaffected.

Success Akiros is distracted by shame and becomes sickened 1 for 1 round.

Failure Akiros becomes sickened 2 with his shame.

Critical Failure As failure, but Akiros is stunned 1 as well. He does not become temporarily immune to Shameful Memories, and he can be affected by this weakness again; this likely means he will have to immediately attempt the save again once he recovers from the stun.

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *longsword* +12 (versatile P), **Damage** 1d8+6 slashing

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Ranged ❖ composite longbow +8 (deadly d10, propulsive, range increment 100 feet, reload 0, volley 30 feet), **Damage** 1d8+2 piercing

No Escape ↷ **Trigger** An adjacent foe moves away. **Effect** Akiros can Stride up to his speed, following the triggering creature and keeping it in reach throughout its movement until it stops moving or Akiros has moved his full Speed.

Rage ❖ (concentrate, emotion, mental) Akiros flies into a rage. He gains 6 temporary Hit Points, deals 2 additional damage with melee Strikes, takes a –1 penalty to AC, and can't use other actions with the concentrate trait. This effect lasts for 1 minute, until he falls unconscious, or until there are no enemies he can perceive, whichever comes first, at which point he loses any remaining temporary Hit Points from Rage and can't Rage again for 1 minute.

C8. THE STAG LORD'S BARRACKS SEVERE 3

Thick layers of animal hides insulate this room's walls. In one corner rests a ragged bed draped with threadbare silks and thick furs. A stout chest serves as furniture, cluttered with empty liquor bottles. A few more bottles lie scattered about the floor, leaving the room reeking of stale alcohol.

Creature: Unless the fort is under attack or on alert for intruders, the Stag Lord can be found here, dissolute in his drink and plotting dark and terrible cruelties. A predator and villain of ruthless reputation, lately he's isolated himself, partaking in fewer raids and letting his men do the work for him. In the interim, he's been languishing in his spoils, particularly the drink, and increasingly relies upon his reputation to maintain his authority. A bitter and violent drunk, he despises everything, including himself, whom he perceives as a hideous monster. The flesh of his entire body and face ripples with thick scars left by acid burns he suffered as a child as the result of his father's torture. He cannot stand the sight of his own face, and before he had his helm to cover up his shame, he often took to wearing a leather hood.

In most cases, once the Stag Lord enters combat, the other bandits know better than to get in his way, and none of them targets creatures that are facing the Stag Lord. He prefers to fight with his bow if possible, but he won't hesitate to switch to melee as the need arises. Humans are his favorite targets, for in many of them he sees the face of his father. He drinks a *healing potion* if reduced below 20 hp, but otherwise fights to the bitter end.

THE STAG LORD CREATURE 6

Page 604

Initiative Perception +15

Treasure: The chest opens to reveal bedding and other miscellaneous items, including a bolt of burlap cloth, old clothing, an iron ring, and three crudely stitched leather masks. The Stag Lord's best treasures are tucked away underneath those items: 21 gp, a polished azurite crystal worth 9 sp, a carnelian worth 8 gp, a piece of hematite worth 3 gp, a shard of obsidian worth 4 gp, a red garnet worth 30 gp, a pewter belt buckle depicting a pair of entwined succubi worth 5 gp, and a silver charm bracelet worth 20 gp.



AKIROS ISMORT

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

C9. ARMORY

Though ruined walls still separate this area from the other rooms, most of the ceiling has collapsed. The only remaining bit of roof covers the inside corner, forming a dry storage area which has been extended out with hides strung from a wooden frame.

The stairs leading up to area **C2a** are creaky and impose a –2 circumstance penalty to Stealth checks.

Treasure: Unlocked chests piled up in the dry storage area hold 10 longbows, 260 arrows, five short swords, five spears, four 50-foot lengths of rope, a set of chisels, two hammers, three tins of iron nails, and four suits of leather armor.

C10. PIG-ROAST ROOM

A shallow, stone-lined cooking pit containing ash and partially burnt logs sits in this rubble-filled room.

The bandits use this area to roast wild pigs, get drunk, and regale each other with embellished stories. Anyone inspecting the room can attempt a DC 15 Perception check to note a large slab of wood near the inner wall that covers an opening in the ground. Under this is a hidden stairway down to area **C11**. The bandits know about this stairway since the rooms below are where they store their stolen goods, but they aren't fond of going downstairs because of the "freak" who lives down there. None of the bandits suspect this is the Stag Lord's decrepit father.

C11. CELLAR MODERATE 3

This room feels miserably damp, and greasy swaths of mold cake the carved stone walls and floor. The ceiling fifteen feet overhead is thick with cobwebs. Three archways in the walls open into other rooms, all of which are filled with mounds of crates, furs, sacks, weapons, and other presumably stolen loot.

Though it was once used as storage for food, water, tools, and other necessities, the Stag Lord and his bandits use the basement to store the majority of their stolen goods.

Creature: The storage cellar is not without a guardian, although the bandits loathe and fear the decrepit old man who lives in these rooms. Only the Stag Lord knows the truth: this ancient, malformed creature is his father. Imprisoned and abused at the hands of his son, Nugrah spends most of his time in a nest made of ropes, rags, and furs at the far end of area **C11c**.

In his youth, Nugrah belonged to the Green Faith, but when his wife Keirthe died in childbirth, Nugrah turned his back on that order. He turned to forbidden rituals in an ill-advised attempt to bring back his wife by sacrificing a fellow druid in an effort to "trade" his wife's death for the druid's. Appalled by his monstrous acts, Keirthe's spirit appeared before him, cursed his name, then departed forever into the afterlife. Soon after, the other members of his circle of druids discovered his act and confronted him on the spot.

The Green Faith banished him from the order, sparing Nugrah's life only that he might care for his infant son. He converted to the worship of Gozreh, finding strange solace in the violence and impassive cruelty in nature, and in the years that followed, Nugrah increasingly blamed his son for his misfortunes and treated him as one of the very animals he increasingly grew to see as untrustworthy beasts. Often, he threatened to kill his son, and made murderous attempts on more than one occasion, such as by leaving him outside in the winter or beating him bloody. Once, Nugrah tortured the child near to death by dousing him with acid. This event left his son so gruesomely scarred that for years the boy covered his frightful face with a burlap sack.

Then, one night, the relationship between the two shifted. His son had become a man, one physically and emotionally scarred with terrible, dark desires, and after a near-fatal beating Nugrah realized that he had become the victim in the family. In sour and sickly vengeance, his son, now known as the Stag Lord, deals him the same hand the old man once forced him to play. Nugrah now lives in fear of the son who mercilessly keeps him alive to endure his fate.

Today, Nugrah obeys his son's commands to guard the treasures kept here, otherwise passing the time crafting twisted fetishes and praying to Gozreh for an end to his wretched existence even as he lacks the courage to take back his own life.

As soon as Nugrah notices intruders entering the cellar, he casts *meld into stone* to step into the southern wall of area **C11c** to listen and wait. While in the stone, he casts *barkskin*, *spider climb*, and *longstrider*. He then clambers out of the wall and up onto the ceiling to scuttle forward to see who has intruded in his den.

Nugrah's first act in combat is to cast *summon animal* to call a giant ant (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 20) to attack the PCs. He remains near the ceiling as the giant ant fights, casting spells down on the PCs and trying to remain out of melee combat. If it looks like he's going to be forced to fight, he drops to the ground, casts *shillelagh* on his club and fights to the death, although he will not pursue foes out of the cellar.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

NUGRAH **CREATURE 5**

UNIQUE | NE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Male human druid of Gozreh

Perception +14

Languages Common, Hallit

Skills Deception +11, Intimidation +13, Nature +12, Stealth +9, Survival +12

Str +1, **Dex** +0, **Con** +2, **Int** +0, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +4

Items club, filthy rags, wooden (and bloodstained) symbol of Gozreh

AC 17; **Fort** +10, **Ref** +6, **Will** +15

HP 75

Speed 20 feet

Melee ❖ club +12, **Damage** 1d6+3 bludgeoning

Primal Prepared Spells DC 23, attack +21; **3rd** *meld into stone*, *summon animal*; **2nd** *barkskin*, *heal*, *spider climb*; **1st** *hydraulic push*, *longstrider*, *shillelagh*; **Cantrips (3rd)** *detect magic*, *electric arc*, *light*, *prestidigitation*, *ray of frost*

Survival of the Fittest ↻ **Trigger** A 1st- or higher-level animal summoned by Nugrah is killed within 30 feet of him; **Effect** Blood-red energy flows from the slain creature into Nugrah's mouth. He immediately heals 1d6 Hit Points per level of the slain animal, gaining any excess healing as temporary Hit Points that last for 10 minutes. As long as he possesses these temporary Hit Points, blood-red energy ripples across his flesh and his AC increases to 22.

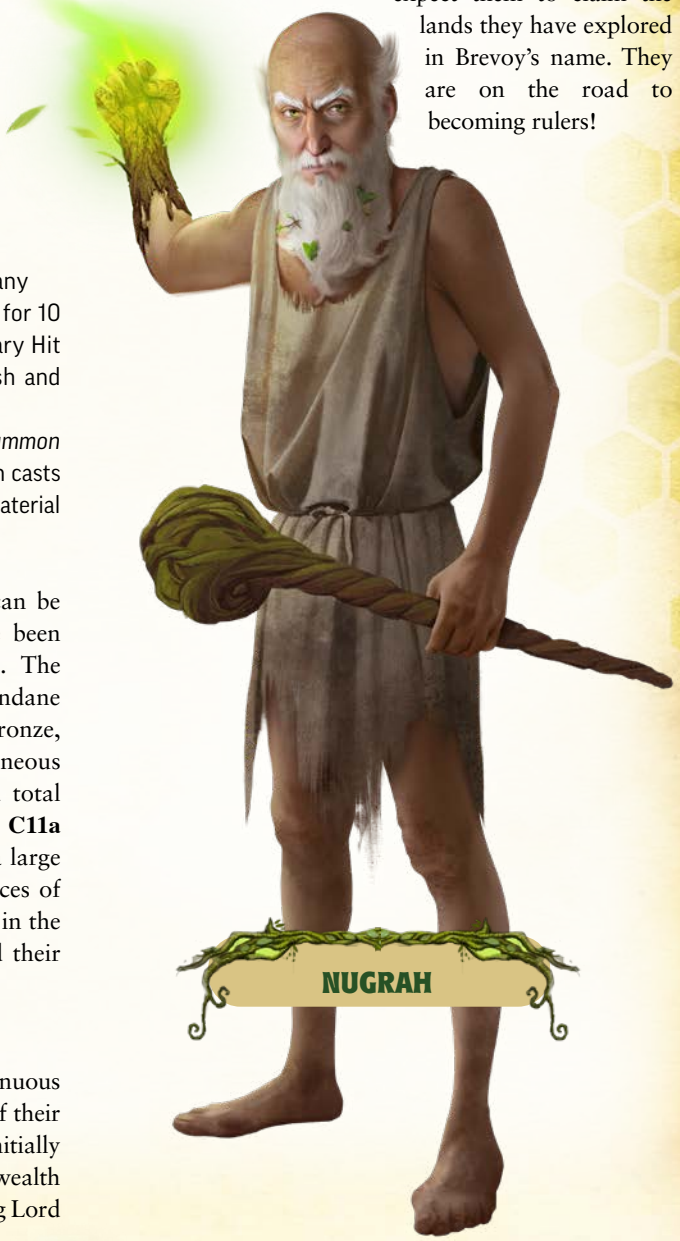
Swift Summon ❖❖ **Prerequisite** Nugrah has a *summon animal* spell prepared and available. **Effect** Nugrah casts *summon animal* but does not need to use a material component.

Treasure: A large amount of stolen wealth can be found in these three rooms—the bandits have been stockpiling their ill-gotten goods for months. The majority of the wealth kept here consists of mundane trade goods like pelts, furs, tobacco, iron, bronze, miscellaneous weapons and armor, and miscellaneous adventuring gear and tools worth a combined total of 45 gp. In addition, one of the chests in area **C11a** contains 2 pp, 21 gp, 42 sp, and 800 cp, while a large bag in area **C11b** contains 30 gp in various pieces of stolen jewelry. This wealth could come in handy in the next adventure as the characters begin to build their own home in the Greenbelt.

CONCLUDING THE CHAPTER

The Stag Lord's bandits are held together by a tenuous combination of greed for coin and nervous fear of their leader. Most of the bandits joined the group initially after being recruited and given promises of great wealth in the near future, but it wasn't long before the Stag Lord himself, and his penchant for unpredictable cruelty, became the primary element that held the bandits together. With the Stag Lord's ousting, the remaining bandits quickly rout (although the lieutenants could linger in the region to torment the characters, or perhaps to join them). With this, the PCs have completed a significant part of their charter, although it's likely they'll still have unexplored reaches of the Greenbelt to cover. When word of the Stag Lord's defeat reaches Lady Jamandi, she is quite pleased with their progress.

The Stag Lord's defeat signals the end of this chapter but merely the beginning of the characters' time in the Stolen Lands. They can certainly continue to explore areas of the northern Greenbelt, but a new and much more exciting charter awaits them: the swordlords expect them to claim the lands they have explored in Brevoy's name. They are on the road to becoming rulers!



NUGRAH

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



CHAPTER 4

RIVERS RUN RED

BY ROBERT G. McCREARY

PART 1: HOME SWEET HOME 186
The PCs should be 4th level during the events of "Home Sweet Home."

PART 2: TROLL TROUBLE 200
The PCs should be 5th level before they attempt to invade Hargulka's fortress

PART 3: HUNTING THE BEAST 208
The PCs should be 5th level before they attempt to confront the owlbear.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



PART 1:

HOME SWEET HOME

The Stolen Lands are not a stagnant place. Even as the PCs gain their first footholds in the wilds, plans beyond their borders and outside their knowledge have already been set into motion. Others, including the Tiger Lord barbarians, the expansionist King Irovetti of Pitax, the sinister cult of Lamashtu, and the undead cyclops Vordakai, each have their own designs on the region. Unknown to them all, Nyrissa waits and watches, eager for one group to seize control and establish the last kingdom she requires to satiate the Lantern King's rage. While most of these machinations are destined to remain isolated and at odds for a while, two emerging threats confront the PCs sooner than the others: the troll king Hargulka and an enormous owlbear—both indirectly influenced by Nyrissa as early tests to ensure that the PCs' kingdom will have the mettle she needs when the time comes to harvest her final nation.

Even before Restov took an official interest in the lands to the south, lone hunters, trappers, and loggers made their presence felt in the forests of the Stolen Lands. To Nyrissa, these newcomers, along with the land's indigenous residents (including kobolds, lizardfolk, and a handful of good-aligned—and thus untrustworthy—fey) had far too much independence for her liking. So she visited the troll Hargulka in a dream, planting in his mind ideas of territorial expansion and aggression and tricking him into thinking he wanted to claim more power. Hargulka abandoned his original den and moved into an abandoned dwarven fort in the southern Stolen Lands, using it as a base to gather

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

power and stage raids against the intelligent denizens of the area. As this chapter progresses, Hargulka's minions and other denizens of the southern Greenbelt grow increasingly violent, attacking travelers and terrorizing locals. By manipulating the troll into destabilizing the region, Nyrissa hopes to make the lands easier to claim when the time comes.

The Stag Lord's bandits were also influenced by Nyrissa, but they were not the first group of brigands she manipulated. Before them, Nyrissa had targeted a group led by a ruthless hunter named Eirikk, a man who made extensive use of trained and untrained (but mostly loyal) wild animals and monsters, using them in frequent attacks on traveling merchants north and west of Hooktongue Slough. This tactic was made possible in most part due to a gift Nyrissa gave Eirikk: a *ring of bestial friendship* (page 588) made from a lock of her hair—a ring that, unknown to Eirikk, bore an unfortunate curse. Just as the Stag Lord later would, Eirikk considered Nyrissa a "secret benefactor" and hoped someday to instead make her his "secret lover." When she told him about the up-and-coming new nation of merchants expanding quickly in the Greenbelt, and in the same breath casually mentioned a particularly violent mated pair of gigantic owlbears dwelling in the Sellen Hills, Eirikk saw this as an excellent chance to impress the nymph. If he could gain the allegiance of these enormous owlbears and conquer this new kingdom, how could his secret benefactor resist his charms? Certainly, the prospect of switching his predation to a nascent kingdom pleased him, as Fort Drelev's defenses had grown ever more skilled at repulsing his bandits and trained beasts.

And so Eirikk led his bandits west into the Narlmarches. He found the male alone in his den and, using the *ring of bestial friendship*, managed to calm it down enough to make his first attempt at friendship. Then the ring's curse came into play: the female owlbear returned, sensed the enchantment, and flew into a frenzy. Eirikk and his men were forced to kill it, causing the male to throw off the enchantment. The briefly controlled owlbear killed the entire bandit party, Eirikk included. Yet while the plan ended poorly for Eirikk, everything had gone exactly as Nyrissa had planned—she had never valued the bandit's skills in the first place and wanted only to incite the massive owlbear into a blood rage. Furious and maddened at the loss of its mate and the wounds it suffered, the enormous owlbear flew into a rampage, and the PCs' new kingdom and capital city lie right in its path. If these forces are not dealt with, the rivers of the Stolen Lands will run red with the blood of the latest doomed attempt to civilize them!

FOUNDING DAY

While Rostland could send its own official agents south to expand into the Stolen Lands, such an act would cause unwanted repercussions for the delicate political situation in Brevoy. Rostland wants a safe southern border and an ally it can count on if things go badly, but it doesn't want to antagonize its northern counterpart Issia by appearing to make blatant land grabs to expand its power. The backroom politics occurring in Restov as the swordlords covertly attempt to increase their own power continue to be an element as the *Kingmaker Adventure Path* progresses, manifesting primarily as story-based Kingdom events. Rostland will eventually be forced to cut official ties with the projects it's starting in the south when Issia begins to react poorly to what northern Brevoy has begun to interpret as an act of aggression. All of this increasingly puts the PCs in charge of their own fates in their newly founded kingdom.

For now, Lady Jamandi and the rest of Rostland remain supportive of the PCs' kingdom-building, while remaining relatively hands-off. Full details for how to build a kingdom appear in Appendix 2 of this book, and you should take time with your players to get things up and running before continuing with the campaign. Feel free to roleplay out as much or as little of the establishment of the kingdom's charter, heartland, and government as you wish. The sample charter presented as **Handout 4–1** on the next page presents a generic version of the document provided by Lady Jamandi; tailor it for your players as needed.

The kingdom- and settlement-building elements of the *Kingmaker Adventure Path* add a unique spin to the game, both in play and in pacing. As the kingdom grows, the PCs' responsibility to it increases. Not only do they need to worry about gathering gear and strength for their own adventures, they'll need to take care of an entire kingdom's needs. This style of game play isn't for everyone; you know your players better than we do, and if you're worried that managing kingdoms and building cities will bore your players (or worse, that it might cause party strife when your players have different levels of interest in this element of game play), consider running Kingmaker as a more standard campaign. In this case, the evolution of the Stolen Lands into a kingdom should happen in the background, with NPCs taking on all of the leadership roles needed to develop the kingdom. This chapter, and those that follow, will have periodic "Kingdom in the Background" sidebars that you can use to track the size of the growing kingdom and the resources it provides for the PCs.

The pace at which the PCs' kingdom gains levels should roughly follow the PCs' own level increases.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



Be it known that the bearers of this charter, having delivered the northern reaches of the Greenbelt from the scourge of banditry, having provided detailed maps of the lay of the land, and having done no small amount of work in the exploration of said land and in the removal of hostile monsters and local hazards, are hereby granted the right to rule. The nature and laws of rule are theirs to define, and the wellbeing of this new nation is theirs to protect. In accordance for providing a stable nation to the south of central Rostland, let there be a generous stipend of funds, support, and advice provided to this fledgling nation as a token of Restov and Brevoy's goodwill, such that future relations between kingdoms might be mutually beneficial. So witnessed under watchful eye of the Lordship of Restov.

HANDOUT 4–1

While the mechanics of kingdom building are self-contained, many events assume that the party's level and the level of their kingdom are within 2 of each other, if not equal. If you find that the PCs are getting 3 or 4 levels ahead of the kingdom's level, consider slowing down exploration and encounter play to focus on running several Kingdom turns in succession, allowing the kingdom to catch up.

KINGDOM EVENTS

As the *Kingmaker Adventure Path* progresses, the PCs will have their wits and skills tested by more than personal combat or exploration of the wilds. Random Kingdom events can occur at the end of each Kingdom turn during the Event phase, but these are not the only events that will test the PCs' abilities as rulers. Other developments, such as those presented in this part, take place as the story of Kingmaker unfolds. Unlike the random Kingdom events detailed at the end of Appendix 2, story events play out during Downtime outside of a Kingdom turn, and in many cases require more roleplaying or even encounter mode play to resolve. Still, the PCs' kingdom comes into play during these events; full rules for resolving these events appear beginning on page 539 of Appendix 2.

Because these events assume that the PCs have taken some time to formalize their kingdom and establish their first settlement as its capital city, it's a good idea to have the PCs spend several months of game time building up their new home so that there's a place for these events to occur. The PCs can make liberal use of the Downtime rules during this period if they wish, along with spending time ruling their country, or even continuing to explore zones 1–6 of the Stolen Lands in between Kingdom turns. Ideally, the PCs explore these zones for a few weeks, then return home and run things there for a few months, giving you a chance to run the following events before proceeding with Part 2 of this chapter.

EVENT 1: THE SLAIN TOWNSFOLK — SEVERE 4

This event takes place after the PCs establish their first settlement and have resolved at least one Kingdom turn. Not long after this, as citizens begin to travel to the settlement and settle down into new lives, the PCs learn some unsettling news: just outside the settlement, two unfortunate villagers—a female human farmhand named Saki and a male human shepherd named Beven—were brutally slaughtered on consecutive nights. The villagers ask the PCs to do something, fearing the depredations of bandits or of some beast

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

from the surrounding wilderness. Consider tailoring the personalities and makeup of these villagers such that your PCs will feel a particular need to protect them, as this event should help to set up the PCs as rulers who want to save their people from the dangers of the Stolen Lands. Later, you can have these same villagers play additional roles in the campaign, using them as a springboard to introduce more and more custom NPCs into your game.

The perpetrator of these slayings is a werewolf, and as such you should time this event to take place just before the last day of the full moon. Knowing that the coming night is going to be a full moon is automatic for the PCs should they ask, but don't volunteer this information unsolicited, as it's likely to spoil the secret!



KUNDAL

Gathering Information

The PCs automatically know, via rumors and requests for aid, where the victims' bodies are being kept (see Investigating the Bodies, below). A PC can attempt to research additional information about the event with a DC 15 Diplomacy check to Gather Information. On a success, they learn that Saki was slain two nights ago while she was out gathering starberries (the sparkling these berries make under the night sky making them easier to spot); the next night, Beven and his flock of six sheep were slaughtered coming home from pasture. Neither had any known enemies. The bodies—humans and sheep alike—were savaged, and talk that a "maneater" of some sort might be stalking the hinterlands is spreading. On a critical failure, rumors of the murders have been colorfully (and inaccurately) embellished, saying that the corpses showed signs of being torn apart by human teeth.

Investigating the Bodies

If the PCs have built a shrine, cemetery, or similar structure in their village, the bodies are kept there; otherwise they're at an outbuilding on Beven's farm. Success on a DC 20 Medicine or Nature check or a DC 15 Hunting Lore check to Recall Knowledge while examining the bodies reveals that all were killed by bites from a large animal—most likely a wolf or warg—and appear to have been partially eaten. A critical success also notes additional unusual details, such as bruises in keeping with hands gripping the victims, that suggest the most likely perpetrator was a werewolf.

KINGDOM IN THE BACKGROUND

During Rivers Run Red, the NPC leaders of the new kingdom decide to call the new nation Narland and establish a capital city named Shrikewall on the north shore of the Tuskwater at the site once used by the Stag Lord as a fort. After an initial growth spurt, Shrikewall soon stabilizes as a prosperous small town the PCs can use as a home base or a place to buy and sell gear. Halfway through this adventure, two new settlements appear as well: one to the north around Oleg's Trading Post (a village named Olegton) and one to the west at a ford on the Skunk River deep in the Narlmarches (a village named Tatzlford, after the beasts that dwelt in the area until recently).

Investigating the Kill Sites

Both sites are along the same road or trail into the village, separated by a distance of only a few hundred yards. At either site, succeeding at a DC 20 Survival check made to Track reveals the presence of large wolf prints that lead into a nearby copse of trees where bloodstains and additional tracks confirm the killer's passage, but further tracks leading away from the trees aren't obvious. At this point, success at a second DC 20 Survival check reveals a set of barefoot human tracks made around the same time as the wolf prints; these lead out of the woods and back toward town. A critical success on the second check allows the PCs to track the human footprints to the location the killer has chosen as his home in the village (see Confronting the Killer below).

Confronting the Killer

The source of these killings is a trapper named Kundal who recently arrived in town. If the PCs have built an inn in the village, he has taken a room there; otherwise, he's paying weekly rent on a shack in one of the settlement's housing lots.

Kundal spends his days hawking his wares in a marketplace or simply on the streets, while each night he drinks himself into a stupor. Unknown to the townsfolk and to the trapper himself, Kundal has become afflicted with lycanthropy. He knows that something is wrong—he's been plagued by dreams of blood and fury and has been drinking himself into oblivion each night to stop the dreams. Unfortunately,

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

his body still hears the call of the moon, and on the past two nights he has transformed into a werewolf and gone on the hunt, only to wake up the next morning in the forest, covered in blood and clad in torn clothes.

If the PCs specifically ask around town whether anyone has been acting strangely, success on a DC 20 Diplomacy check to Gather Information reveals that the locals have noticed Kundal's recent arrival and that he has been seen stumbling around disheveled and drunk in the early morning of the past few days. If the PCs critically succeeded at tracking his prints from one of the kill sites, those prints lead right up to his shack or the inn he's staying at, at which point asking about anyone acting strangely in that specific area shifts the rolled result for the check to Gather Information up one degree of success.

If Kundal is staying in a shack when the PCs track him down, they can use Thievery to pick the simple lock on the door. If he's staying at the inn, the innkeeper will simply give them a key to the room; the PCs are town officials, after all. Either way, the man himself isn't there, though his room appears lived-in. A PC succeeding at a DC 20 Perception check finds a single blood-stained golden earring under Kundal's bed. This damning bit of evidence fell free only to become tangled in Kundal's fragmented clothes after he slaughtered Saki, then tumbled away under his bed unseen when he returned home and ripped off his tattered clothing to destroy it.

If the PCs show this blood-stained earring to anyone who knew Saki, that NPC confirms it belonged to her. If the PCs examined Saki's body, succeeding at a DC 20 Perception check allows them to recall that Saki's corpse was missing an ear, and that a match for this earring was on her remaining ear. In addition, if PCs search the room, they'll discover Kundal's ledger and bow (see Rewards on page 191).

Kundal stays out of town the whole day, hoping that being away from civilization will stop his gory dreams. When night falls, however, he transforms again. His instincts take over, and he hunts the same approach into town where his previous victims were slain. If the PCs patrol this region, they become his new targets; Kundal rolls Stealth for initiative. If the PCs decide to stake out his room, they'll encounter him in his human form when he returns from the hunt after killing again. Kundal looks startled at first but then his lycanthropic instincts take over and he shifts involuntarily into his hybrid form to attack. In this scenario, the PCs can roll for initiative with Stealth if they wish. In any case, if Kundal is reduced to 15 or fewer HP, he shifts into wolf form and tries to flee into the wilds. In the unlikely event that he's captured alive, Kundal is a mix of defiant, outraged, and ashamed at his actions, but he won't resist attempts by the PCs to cure him of his condition.

If the PCs do nothing to investigate the attacks or fail to discover Kundal's lycanthropy, he claims his third victim—a merchant named Norben. The attack happens at the very edge of town, as Norben—a newcomer to the settlement and thus unaware of the previous nights' murders—rides into town in the predawn hours. This third night of horror increases the kingdom's Unrest by 1. The kingdom then automatically suffers a Monster Activity Kingdom event (in addition to any other potential random Kingdom events) during the next Kingdom turn as Kundal continues to prey upon the settlement. This will continue each month until the werewolf is dealt with.

KUNDAL CREATURE 7

UNIQUE | CE | MEDIUM | BEAST | HUMAN | HUMANOID | WERECREATURE

Male human werewolf (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 330)

Perception +15; low-light vision, scent (imprecise) 30 feet

Languages Common, Hallit; wolf empathy

Skills Athletics +17, Nature +11, Stealth +15, Survival +15

Str +4, **Dex** +2, **Con** +2, **Int** +0, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +0

Wolf Empathy (divination, primal) Kundal can communicate with lupines.

AC 25; **Fort** +16, **Ref** +13, **Will** +17

HP 140; **Weaknesses** silver 10

Attack of Opportunity ↻

Speed 35 feet

Melee ❖ jaws +17, **Damage** 2d12+9 piercing plus curse of the werewolf

Melee ❖ claw +17 (agile), **Damage** 2d8+7 slashing

Ambush Strike ❖❖ **Requirement** Kundal rolled Stealth for Initiative, and it's the first round of combat. **Effect** Kundal Strides up to his speed and then attempts a jaws Strike and a claw Strike against a single adjacent target. Apply his multiple attack penalty to each Strike normally.

Change Shape ❖ (concentrate, polymorph, primal, transmutation) Human with fist +16 for 1d4+7 bludgeoning, or wolf with Speed 40 feet and jaws with Knockdown.

Curse of the Werewolf (curse, necromancy, primal); as werewolf, but a DC 25 Fortitude save.

Moon Frenzy (polymorph, primal, transmutation) Kundal's moon frenzy functions a bit differently than for typical werecreatures: he doesn't become Large sized, but he does grow much more swift and powerful. His speed increases to 35 feet during moon frenzy and increases the damage of his jaws by +2 (these adjustments are calculated into the stats above). In addition, while in moon frenzy, at the start of his turn, Kundal gains an additional reaction that can be used only to make an Attack of Opportunity.

Rip and Drag ❖ **Requirement** Kundal damaged a target with his jaws Strike with a previous action this round. **Effect** Kundal chews the bitten creature as he attempts to overwhelm them by attempting an Athletics check against the bitten creature's Fortitude DC.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Critical Success Kundal inflicts 5d6 piercing damage on the target, exposes them to the curse of the werewolf, and can Stride up to half his speed. If his target is Medium or smaller, he drags the target with him into a new adjacent square.

Success Kundal inflicts 5d6 piercing damage on the target and exposes them to the curse of the werewolf. He can reposition the target up to five feet into an adjacent square.

Failure As success, except only 2d6 piercing damage.

Critical Failure Kundal fails to inflict any damage.

Rewards: If the PCs defeat Kundal before he can claim a third victim, the kingdom's citizens breathe a collective sigh of relief; reduce the kingdom's Unrest by 1. If the PCs manage to capture Kundal alive and cure him, instead reduce Unrest by 1d4. If they capture him alive and simply exile or execute him, the uncertainty or violence of the resolution results in no change to Unrest at all.

Regardless, once Kundal's reign of terror is put to an end, grant the PCs 30 Kingdom XP.

Once the PCs defeat or capture Kundal, they'll have a chance to read through his ledger if they search his room; if they don't think to do so, the innkeeper or whoever takes over his home brings the ledger to the PCs' attention a few days later. This thin, leather-bound folio documents animals he's delivered to various employers. Most of these are pretty minor—deliveries of animal pelts or the like—but one entry in particular stands out. This entry is dated at about the same time the PCs fought the Stag Lord, and mentions a bandit named Eirikk, to whom Kundal delivered three brush thylacines, a tiger, and a boar. In addition to being the largest single delivery in the ledger, the entry bears a notation indicating the animals were to be unharmed and ready to be trained to fight. If the PCs captured Kundal alive, he can explain he was hired to provide the animals to Eirikk in Hooktongue Slough but didn't ask why. Kundal knows Eirikk has since left that area but doesn't know where the bandit went or anything about Nyrissa or the owlbears.

Kundal's *+1 composite longbow* awaits discovery in his quarters; he doesn't bring this with him on his werewolf-enhanced hunts.



KUNDAL

EVENT 2: THE RABBLE-ROUSER SEVERE 4

Not all threats come in the form of bandits, werewolves, and trolls. After the PCs' kingdom has had a chance to start to grow—preferably once they've expanded a settlement into a town and their kingdom has reached 4th level—their new nation catches the attention of their neighbors to the west: Pitax. And while visitors from this kingdom may be commonplace, one early arrival is anything but a common visitor.

Creature: Grigori is a charismatic orator and an agent of Pitax who seeks to undermine the PCs' authority while spying on their kingdom. He shows up in the kingdom's capital while the PCs are out adventuring and immediately begins giving speeches criticizing and denigrating their leadership. More and more of the townsfolk gather to hear him talk and, as the days wear on, he builds a wellspring of support among the disaffected settlers in the town. Every decision the PCs make has a winner and a loser, and Grigori is gifted at shifting focus to the losers in these decisions and riling them up. Whether it is appealing to the citizens who didn't get what they wanted when the PCs build a new city block, to spinning a narrative that paints a recent event in the most horrid light for those for whom the outcome was a negative, a properly played Grigori should become a constant barb in the players' side and one of the most memorable villains they encounter. Grigori takes great pains to avoid breaking any of the

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

PCs' laws so that they have no justification to arrest him other than that they want to silence him.

Grigori isn't fully aware of how King Irovetti is using him. In order to cover his tracks and retain plausible deniability, Irovetti used layers of agents to hire Grigori; as far as he knows, Grigori was hired to cause trouble in this fledgling town by agents from Fort Drelev to the west, not by the ruler of Pitax itself.

If the PCs have built an inn, that's where Grigori's been staying; otherwise, he's arranged to stay in a shed or unused house in one of the capital city's housing lots. By the time the PCs first learn of the bard, his orations have increased the kingdom's Unrest by 1. Ignoring the rabble-rouser and hoping he'll go away is the worst way to handle this problem; if the PCs allow Grigori to continue to do his thing, see Repercussions below for the ramifications.



The first time the PCs have a chance to see Grigori in action, he is giving a talk in the town commons, speaking of the PCs' "gross negligence" in abandoning the town to "go gallivanting through the Narlmarches on fool's errands" and leaving the town exposed to banditry, monster attacks, and worse. He takes care to bring up recent dangerous events in particular, be they random events the PCs' kingdom endured or Kundal's attacks on the citizens. He further suggests that the PCs may be responsible because their wilderness explorations drive monsters into more civilized areas. He claims that the PCs have acquired much wealth during their adventures, and have used it only to enrich themselves, not to aid the town or its citizens; he lists any recent (or not-so-recent) acquisitions the PCs have made (whether purchased, gifted, or found) as examples.

Several townspeople have gathered to hear Grigori talk, and shouts of agreement and mutters of discontent increase as the speech progresses, helped along by Grigori's subtle use of magic. Without intervention, the discontent only grows over time. If the PCs intervene, Grigori attempts to eloquently refute any points they try to make while trying to goad them into violence. His goal is to provoke them into attacking him.

GRIGORI **CREATURE 7**

UNIQUE | CN | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Male human bard (page 596)

Initiative Perception +15

Using Force Against Grigori

If the PCs try to remove Grigori forcefully, he accuses them of oppression and of trying to "thwart the voice of the people." Should the PCs attack him, Grigori does nothing to defend himself, at least for this first skirmish, and such actions only cause more people to turn from the PCs and heed Grigori's words. Use the crowd of the kingdom's citizens as a shield for Grigori, with those unarmed citizens trying to stop the PCs from arresting the bard. If it becomes apparent that the PCs will be successful in arresting him or restraining him, Grigori attempts to flee into the city (using an infiltrator's elixir as soon as possible to aid in his escape), but if cornered he does his best to fight back. Only if he's brought below 30 HP does he give up the fight and surrender.

Diplomatic Negotiations

If the PCs approach him in private, Grigori's attitude is hostile (although he won't initiate combat). He would rather have his confrontation with the PCs in a public venue, but if the PCs prevent it, he uses Deception to convince them he'll tone down his rabble-rousing antics, only to start back up a few days later. Under no circumstances will Grigori divulge anything beyond the fact that he is working for "parties interested in seeing your little nation fail," and that he aims to remove the PCs from their positions of authority over the town; even those admissions are made only under duress. Any successful attempts at Diplomacy or Intimidation quiet him for 1 day, but he returns to the town commons the next day to continue his tirades, with new tales of his "repression" at the hands of the PCs. Should the PCs later attack him, Grigori defends himself and does his best to make the fight as public as possible, hoping the townsfolk see him as the victim and the PCs as overbearing thugs.

A War of Words

Rather than confront Grigori on the streets, the PCs can use his own tactics against him by launching a campaign of debate and introducing counterpoints of their own. When the PCs do so, they must take the Fight Propaganda downtime activity to build up citizen support and combat Grigori's undermining efforts to bring the kingdom down. By taking this activity, the PCs attempt to build up Support Points to eventually defeat Grigori's attempts to slander the government.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Once this tactic is adopted, Grigori works to undermine progress each day that the PCs don't continue this tactic. Each day that passes with no PCs attempting to Fight Propaganda, Grigori's tireless efforts reduce the total amount of Support Points gained by 1d4.

FIGHT PROPAGANDA

CONCENTRATE DOWNTIME

A PC spends the day working to fight against Grigori's efforts to spread rumors, misinformation, and propaganda against your kingdom. A PC can use Deception to fight fire with fire by slandering or redirecting Grigori's efforts to backfire on him. A PC can use Diplomacy to convince the citizens that the kingdom's leaders are making the right choices and have the nation's best interests at heart. A PC can use Intimidation to try to frighten Grigori out of town or to make citizens wary about speaking out against the government. All three choices can build up Support points, but the repercussions for failing vary according to the skill chosen to Fight Grigori's Propaganda efforts. Regardless of the skill chosen, it's a DC 24 check.

Critical Success The party gains 2 Support Points. The next Fight Propaganda check attempted by a PC gains a +2 circumstance bonus as a result of the positive momentum of their efforts.

Success The party gains 1 Support Point.

Failure The party loses 1 Support Point.

Critical Failure The party loses 1 Support Point, but also suffers an additional penalty to the kingdom as a whole, depending on which skill check was attempted to Fight Propaganda.

Deception Grigori exposes some of the PCs' deceitful acts to the public, inspiring criminals in the kingdom to step up their game using similar tactics performed by the PC. Increase the kingdom's Crime by 1 and Unrest by 1.

Diplomacy Grigori seizes on the PC's poor attempt to be diplomatic and spins those failures into "evidence" of corruption among the city's leadership. Increase the kingdom's Corruption by 1 and Unrest by 1.

Intimidation Grigori takes advantage of the PC's bullying to drive citizens to engage in riots and vandalism. Increase the kingdom's Decay by 1 and Unrest by 1.

SUPPORT POINT THRESHOLDS

As the PCs build Support Points by Fighting Propaganda, they erode Grigori's influence over the kingdom. To completely defeat him, the party must achieve 15 Support Points, but the following Support Point thresholds grant additional bonuses along the way.

5 Support Points The skill check that resulted in achieving this threshold gains momentum. As long as the Support Points maintain a minimum threshold of 5, future checks attempted to Fight Propaganda using this same skill gain a +2 status bonus. If Support Points are reduced below 5, this bonus is lost; it can be regained (potentially with a new type of skill) by reaching the threshold of 5 points again.

10 Support Points Grigori's campaign has suffered significant setbacks, and he now reduces accumulated Support Points by only 1 per day that the PCs don't continue to Fight his Propaganda. The party can have him arrested (and move on to Grigori's Trial) at this point, but doing so is a bit premature and causes those in the kingdom who are still swayed by his influence to become disgruntled. Increase the kingdom's Unrest by 1d6 and Strife by 2.

15 Support Points Grigori's campaign is defeated, and the bard can now be arrested without any negative repercussions; move on to Grigori's Trial.

Repercussions

Every week that passes with Grigori actively pursuing his goals, increase the kingdom's Unrest by 1. If Grigori is still active when a Kingdom turn begins at the end of the month, increase the kingdom's Unrest by 1d6 at the start of the turn, and during that turn's Event Phase, the PCs must deal with a Public Scandal event (page 563) in addition to any other potential random event for that phase. These conditions continue to plague the kingdom until Grigori is dealt with—either by force or by rhetoric.

If Grigori is slain without being given a fair trial, the threat he poses is ended immediately, but if the act becomes public knowledge, the public is disturbed—increase Unrest by 1d4+1 and Strife by 2.

If Grigori is successfully bribed to end his campaign and that knowledge goes public, increase Unrest by 1d4+1 and Crime by 2.

If Grigori is convinced to cease his activity via mind-controlling or similar magic and this information becomes public, increase Unrest by 1d4+1 and Corruption by 2.

For all of these repercussions, the PCs can avoid the increase to Unrest and Ruin by keeping the methods they used to deal with Grigori secret, yet if word ever gets out about such clandestine activities, the Unrest and Ruin increases apply in full force at that time as the public's trust in their leaders erodes.

If Grigori is arrested without having broken specific laws, increase Unrest by 2d4 and record the number of points gained; if the PCs put Grigori on trial and he's found guilty, reduce Unrest by that number.

Grigori's Trial

If you choose to run Grigori's trial as a downtime activity, it takes one week to resolve. This special kingdom event should take place during the next kingdom turn.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

GRIGORI'S TRIAL — EVENT +0

CONTINUOUS | DOWNTIME | LEADERSHIP

Event Once Grigori has been arrested, the PCs have the option of putting him on trial during a following Kingdom turn's Activities phase. As this is a leadership activity, it must be one of the three activities performed during Step 3 of the Activities phase. Each Kingdom turn that passes with Grigori imprisoned without a trial, increase the Kingdom's Unrest by 1d4 and Corruption by 1. If a Public Scandal random event ever occurs while Grigori is imprisoned, he is released from prison on a technicality and all previous Support Points are zeroed out as he begins to spread propaganda again, starting the whole process over from the start. If a Justice Prevails random event occurs while he's imprisoned, Grigori is either executed, exiled, or rehabilitated (players' choice) as part of that event, with the corresponding repercussions as detailed below for a successful trial.

During Grigori's trial (which lasts for several days over the month), attempt a DC 27 Intrigue, Politics, or Statecraft Kingdom skill check. This DC is equal to Grigori's Deception DC (DC 27). Each PC can attempt to lower this DC with a successful DC 24 Deception, Diplomacy, or Intimidate check, or with a DC 19 Legal Lore check; each success reduces the Kingdom skill check DC by 1 to a maximum reduction of 5 at DC 22.

Kingdom Skill Intrigue, Politics, or Statecraft; **Leader** Emissary

Critical Success The trial concludes and finds Grigori to be guilty. Reduce Unrest by 1d6, and the party must choose between the following options on how to sentence Grigori, with each option granting a different reward to the kingdom.

Execution Grigori is executed publicly. Increase Decay by 1 but reduce Crime by 2; if Grigori becomes a recurring foil, he does so as an undead creature.

Exile Grigori is released and escorted out of the kingdom. Reduce Strife by 1; Grigori can become a recurring foil.

Imprisonment Grigori is sentenced to a longer prison term. At the start of every Kingdom turn that follows, the PCs can choose one of the other three sentences (Execution, Exile, or Pardon) to end his imprisonment, or instead to keep him imprisoned. Remember that as long as Grigori is imprisoned, Public Scandals and Justice Prevails random Kingdom events have additional effects, but his imprisonment no longer automatically increases Unrest and Corruption.

Pardon Grigori is pardoned for his crimes and allowed to go free. Increase Strife by 1 but reduce Corruption by 2 unless Grigori has been imprisoned for at least 1 year, in which case the Strife increase is ignored. Whether or not he returns as a recurring foil once released is left to the GM to determine, based on how the PCs treated him up to that point.

Success As critical success, but do not reduce Unrest. Pardon cannot be chosen at this time (but can be later if the PCs imprison Grigori).

Failure The trial fails to reach a resolution. The PCs can attempt this leadership activity again if they have any more leadership activities available on this Kingdom turn, otherwise Grigori remains imprisoned for another month and the trial can be continued during the next Kingdom turn.

Critical Failure The trial ends with Grigori being found not guilty. He is released from imprisonment but knows better than to stay where he's not welcome. He flees the kingdom and may become a recurring foil. Increase Unrest by 1d4 and two Ruins of the party's choice by 2.

Resolution This event is resolved with a Success, Critical Success, or Critical Failure, as detailed above.

A Recurring Foil

Regardless of how this complex event plays out, this event foreshadows future developments in the *Kingmaker Adventure Path*. While Pitax makes no more overt moves against the PCs in this chapter, the PCs should come out of this encounter knowing that they have enemies out there somewhere. They'll learn soon enough what plans the Lord of Pitax has for their new kingdom, and they'll eventually have the opportunity to face King Irovetti in person and hold him accountable for his crimes in Chapter 8. If Grigori survived this event, he may return at a later date to vex the PCs as the antagonist behind the scenes for random dangerous Kingdom events, or even as a leveled-up foe during Chapter 8.

Final Rewards

If the PCs manage to handle Grigori without resorting to battle, award them XP as if they had defeated him in combat. Once Grigori is defeated, grant the PCs' Kingdom 30 XP; increase this to 80 XP if he is successfully put on trial.

EVENT 3: DESPERATE SPIES — SEVERE 4

If the PCs seem to be hesitant at starting Part 2 of this chapter on their own, you can use this event to help spur them on to take action against the trolls. As King Hargulka expands his power, he grows more curious and concerned about the proximity of the PCs' kingdom. He understands that his troll minions are not the most subtle, so instead he sends two kobolds he's captured to spy on the PCs' kingdom for him.

These two kobolds are a curious pair named Kereek and Prazil. Their fear of Hargulka is slightly greater than their fear of adventurers and big cities, so they do their best on their spy mission to learn what they can about the kingdom without getting caught.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

DISCOVER DESPERATE SPIES — EVENT +3

CONTINUOUS | DANGEROUS | SETTLEMENT

Location The kingdom's capital city.

Event The kobold spies slink and skulk around the city, looking for weaknesses to report back to Hargulka and taking advantage of opportunities to perform minor acts of vandalism and sabotage. Once this story event begins, it continues daily for a week. Each day, the kingdom attempts a skill check to resolve the event.

Kingdom Skill Defense or Intrigue (secret), DC 23; **Leader** Warden

- **Critical Success** The two kobold spies are captured and kept imprisoned until the PCs have a chance to speak to them.
- **Success** Rumors of kobold spies in town begin to spread. Attempt a DC 11 flat check; on a failure, increase Unrest by 1.
- **Failure** Someone or something in town is causing trouble. Increase Unrest by 1.
- **Critical Failure** Not only do the kobolds continue to cause trouble (increase Unrest by 1), but they also perform acts of vandalism and sabotage. Increase Decay by 1.

Resolution This daily event ends on a Critical Success or after 7 days have passed.

Creatures: The PCs can step in personally to track down and corner the two kobolds in Exploration mode by taking 8 hours to Search. If the settlement has sewers, the kobolds hide there and gain a +2 circumstance bonus to their Stealth checks; in order to discover, corner, and confront the duo, a PC must succeed at a Perception check against the kobolds' Stealth DC.

Once the kobolds are discovered, they attempt to flee rather than fight. If the PCs capture them, or if they're captured as a result of a critical success in the event above, they can be interrogated. Both kobolds are fearful for their lives, be they in the PCs' hands or in Hargulka's hands. They were pressed into service by Hargulka after the troll attacked their band, the Treeshouters (once located several miles south of area **NM7**). Presented with the option to serve the troll in a way that afforded them their lives, Prazil and Kereek readily agreed. Hargulka sees the two as a combination of pet and trophy, and while the kobolds hate and fear Hargulka equally, they do their best to serve him to protect their surviving kin.

Black-scaled Prazil—very excitable and a little dimwitted—views Kereek as his best friend. Clad in makeshift armor consisting mostly of a breastplate and a scale loincloth, Prazil is a cheerful optimist who's happy to meet others and typically sees the best in people. Incredibly loyal to his friends, if combat breaks out, he fights to the death to protect Kereek.

Red-scaled Kereek, on the other hand, is all cunning and pragmatism. He's willing to do whatever he must to get the job done, though his giant ego blinds him to his own shortcomings. He lords over Prazil, though in his heart he cares for his protector more than he realizes. He's willing to abandon Prazil if he must, but he will plot vengeance against an enemy who forces him to do so.

The kobolds eagerly agree to guide the PCs to Hargulka's lair if asked, hoping to earn their lives (if not their freedom) by being helpful to the PCs. They can even provide a crude map of some of the chambers within his lair.

If, on the other hand, Kereek and Prazil manage to avoid being caught for a week, the PCs can encounter them again in Part 2 once they begin exploring Hargulka's domain.



PRAZIL

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

KEREEK AND PRAZIL CREATURE 5

UNIQUE CN SMALL HUMANOID KOBOLD

Male kobold spies (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 212)

Perception +12; darkvision

Languages Common, Draconic

Skills Acrobatics +13, Deception +10, Stealth +13, Survival +12, Thievery +13

Str +1, **Dex** +4, **Con** +3, **Int** +0, **Wis** +3, **Cha** +1

Kereek's Items dagger, robes, *wand of burning hands* (1st)

Prazil's Items breastplate, *+1 silver warhammer*, steel shield

AC 21; **Fort** +11, **Ref** +14, **Will** +17

HP 85

Speed 25 feet

Melee (Kereek) ❖ dagger +11 (agile, finesse, thrown 10 feet, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+3 piercing

Melee (Prazil) ❖ *warhammer* +13 (shove), **Damage** 1d8+3 bludgeoning

Kereek's Arcane Spontaneous Spells DC 22, attack +14; **3rd** (2 slots) *burning hands*, *slow*; **2nd** (3 slots) *burning hands*, *invisibility*, *obscuring mist*; **1st** (3 slots) *burning hands*, *magic missile*, *pest form*; **Cantrips (3rd)** *daze*, *mage hand*, *message*, *produce flame*, *shield*



KEREEK

Hurried Retreat ❖ As kobold warrior.

Smash Kneecaps ❖❖ Prazil attempts a warhammer Strike on a creature that is at least Medium sized and that has legs. He gains a +2 circumstance bonus to his attack roll and deals an extra 1d8 points of damage on a hit. The creature struck must succeed at a DC 22 Fortitude save or have its Speed reduced by 10 feet for 1 minute.

Sneak Attack Prazil deals an extra 2d6 precision damage to flat-footed creatures.

Rewards: If the PCs manage to catch the kobolds or prevent them from spending a full week spying and vandalizing, grant them 30 Kingdom XP and regular character XP as if they had defeated the pair in combat. If instead they confront the kobolds in battle and defeat them, they earn XP as normal, but only earn 10 Kingdom XP.

EVENT 4: THE CULT OF GYRONNA SEVERE 4

It's not long before another menace invades the PCs' kingdom, this one much more subtle than a murderous band of trolls or a rampaging owlbear: a cult of sinister cultists devoted to the hag-goddess Gyronna. This event should begin at some point after the PCs' kingdom reaches 4th level, and after they've started to deal with Grigori's rabble-rousing.

As a goddess of hatred, extortion, and spite, Gyronna's cult represents a threat to any community, and tales abound of isolated communities throughout the River Kingdoms that tore themselves apart from within due to the machinations of the Angry Hag's priestesses. Once the cult infiltrates the PCs' capital city, the cultists must be found and eliminated before they can set the townspeople at one another's throats.

Creatures: The cult is still in its early stages, comprising four women under the leadership of a cleric of Gyronna named Malgorzata Niska. By day, "Goody" Niska is a respected midwife, a position that has enabled her to recruit new members to her growing flock as well as providing her opportunities to steal newborn babies and swap them with changelings.

All five cultists are outcasts who harbor only hatred and malice for their fellow townsfolk. They carry symbols of a bloodshot eye and wear ragged black smocks called "shabbles" when enacting their rites, but they take great care to hide these items when not using them. They otherwise appear no different from normal townspeople or travelers.

This event manifests as a Cult Activity event (page 556), except that it does so as an Event +2 rather than an Event +1. After the Intrigue check to discover where the cult's headquarters are located, run the following encounter instead of attempting the Folklore check to defeat the cult.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

The cult meets in the cellar of a barn on the outskirts of town. The barn doors are kept warded with an *alarm* spell (with the password being "Annoryg"), while the concealed trapdoor to the cellar can be found with a success on a DC 20 Perception check. Malgorzata previously led the cult in a successful *consecrate* ritual, making the entire cellar a sacred space that provides the cultists a +1 status bonus to attack rolls, skill checks, saving throws, and Perception checks, and all lawful good creatures take a –1 status penalty to those checks. Attacks made by worshippers of Gyronna within the area deal an additional 1 evil damage.

In the cellar, Malgorzata leads the other cultists in their dark rites before a simple altar of piled stones topped with a glittering gem that looks like a glaring bloodshot eye. The chamber is lit by softly glowing lanterns that hang from wall-mounted hooks. As soon as she notices the PCs, she commands the other four cultists to attack. Malgorzata has no wish to die and flees if she is reduced to 40 Hit Points. Fanatic converts, the other four fight as long as Malgorzata lives. If she is killed or flees, they lose their nerve and flee.

MALGORZATA NISKA — CREATURE 5

UNIQUE | CE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Female human cult leader

Perception +13

Languages Common

Skills Deception +13, Intimidation +13, Religion +11, Society +9

Str +4, **Dex** +2, **Con** +0, **Int** +0, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +2

Items leather armor, dagger, shabble, *wand of heal (1st)*, wooden religious symbol, 23 sp

AC 21; **Fort** +9, **Ref** +13, **Will** +15

HP 85

Spiteful Command ↷ (auditory) **Trigger** Malgorzata is targeted with an attack or single-target spell. **Effect** Malgorzata commands a Gyronna cultist within reach of the triggering creature to attack the creature, allowing it to make a melee Strike after the triggering action resolves its effects.

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ dagger +13 (agile, finesse, thrown 10 feet, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+6 piercing

Ranged ❖ dagger +13 (agile, finesse, thrown 10 feet, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+6 piercing

Divine Prepared Spells DC 22, attack +14; **3rd** *crisis of faith*, *vampiric touch*; **2nd** *heal*, *paranoia*, *spiritual weapon*; **1st** *alarm*, *bane*, *ray of enfeeblement*; **Cantrips (3rd)** *chill touch*, *daze*, *divine lance*, *light*, *shield*

Cleric Domain Spells 1 Focus Point, DC 22; *waking nightmare*

Divine Rituals *consecrate*

GYRONNA CULTISTS (4) — CREATURE 0

UNCOMMON | CE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Female human cultists (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 229)

Initiative Perception +4

Treasure: The fist-sized cat's eye chrysoberyl atop the altar is worth 50 gp, but success on a DC 20 Religion check to Recall Knowledge recalls that the goddess Gyronna watches the world through such stones, and should the PCs defile or steal from her shrine, they risk



MALGORZATA NISKA

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

incurring her wrath and being cursed. Whether or not these stories are true in this chrysoberyl's case is left to the GM to decide.

In addition, a plain wooden coffer hidden behind the altar contains a payment of 100 gp, along with a short note that bears a single line written in Common: "In appreciation of our common cause." As a signature, the note bears only a symbol: three black teardrops. The PCs should automatically recognize this symbol as that of the Black Tears, the mercenaries they clashed against in Chapter 1. Malgorzata received this payment from an agent of the Black Tears for the express purpose of establishing a cult in the PCs' capital city; she knows little more about the mercenary group but appreciated the tip and payment. The Black Tears haven't been in contact with this cult since their initial bribe to have them begin harassing the PCs—one of several attempts to get revenge against the PCs for the party's actions at the Aldori manor.

ADDITIONAL EVENTS

In addition to the preceding major story events, the following four minor events should occur during the course of this chapter—they don't have to occur during this part, but the Troll Sightings event helps to set up Part 2 and can help turn the PCs' attention to that plot once you're ready.

Each of these events grants 30 Kingdom XP.

THE FOUNDING OF TATZLFORD — EVENT +0

BENEFICIAL HEX

Location Hex Encounter **GB16**.

Event The PCs are approached by a ruddy, friendly, and energetic couple, Loy and Latricia Rezbin. They have plans to establish a village deep in the Narlmarches at a ford on the Skunk River where, until recently, a pair of tatzlwyrms dwelled. The Rezbins ask the PCs for support getting their village started.

Kingdom Skill Exploration; **Leader** Warden

Critical Success Tatzlford is founded at **GB16** on the Skunk River. If this hex isn't part of the PCs' kingdom, it's automatically claimed and added to the kingdom (remember that if this hex isn't adjacent to other hexes claimed by the kingdom it counts as a secondary territory; page 534). Tatzlford is automatically integrated into the kingdom as a village that has 1 Water border. It occupies one block on the Urban Grid, and all 4 of its lots have structures built. These consist of the following: houses, inn, and town hall.

Success As critical success, but the village of Tatzlford isn't automatically claimed and added to the kingdom unless the PCs have already claimed that hex. Otherwise, Tatzlford becomes a freehold (page 536).

Failure As success, but clashes with additional tatzlwyrms and other dangerous local monsters cause the PCs to expend additional resources to help the Rezbins found their village. At the start of the next Kingdom turn, the PCs gain 2 fewer Resource Dice.

Critical Failure The Rezbins and any assistants provided by the PCs are slaughtered by monsters before they can get started. If the PCs haven't finished Part 2 of this chapter yet, then the Rezbins are captured by Hargulka's trolls, and they could potentially be rescued during Part 2 (after which the Rezbins thankfully return to the task of founding Tatzlford, and the PCs automatically gain a success as above). In the short term, the bad news increases Unrest by 1, Decay by 1, and reduces the Resource Dice gained at the start of the next Kingdom turn by 4.

RETURN OF THE BLACK TEARS — EVENT +0

DANGEROUS

Event After the PCs disrupted the Black Tears' plans and slaughtered several of their lower-ranking members during the raid on Lady Jamandi's manor in Chapter 1, the mercenary killers have seethed and plotted. As word of the PCs' new nation reaches Brevoy, the Black Tears take note and send a new group of killers south to infiltrate the kingdom. These Black Tears make their presence known by attempting a very public attack on the kingdom to send a clear message to its leaders: The Black Tears do not forget!

Once this kingdom event is completed, whether the Black Tears continue to cause periodic trouble for the PCs is left to you to decide. For example, you could link them to some random events like Assassination Attempts, Bandit Activity, Feuds, Public Scandals, Sensational Crimes, and Vandals.

Kingdom Skill Intrigue; **Leader** Emissary

Critical Success Your agents intercept the Black Tears before they can even get started on their nefarious plans. Reduce Unrest by 1d4, and the next time a random event occurs that includes Black Tears influence, treat the rolled result as one degree of success better than the actual result.

Success The Black Tears set their plans in motion, but the kingdom's defenses stop them before they cause any damage. Nevertheless, public knowledge that the Black Tears have taken an interest in the kingdom increases Unrest by 1.

Failure The Black Tears are successful in their plot to attack the kingdom. They publicly rob a caravan of merchants, murder some citizens in broad daylight, or vandalize several buildings while leaving their mark of three black tears as proof of their action. Increase Unrest by 1d4 and one Ruin of your choice by 1.

Critical Failure As failure, but the Black Tears also manage to establish a foothold in the kingdom. Increase Crime

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

by 2 (this increase stacks with any potential increase to Crime from the Failure result), and the next time there's a random event that includes Black Tears influence, treat the rolled result as one degree of success worse than the actual result.

TROLL SIGHTINGS EVENT +0

DANGEROUS ONGOING

Event Trolls have grown more common and more aggressive along the borders of the kingdom, and their attacks on travelers, hunters, and others coming and going from the kingdom undermine the nation's sense of safety and well-being.

This event should occur once the PCs reach 5th level, or once they come within one hex of area **NM7**. The event then continues to repeat during every Kingdom turn's event phase automatically until it is resolved, in addition to any other potential events that might take place during the turn.

Kingdom Skill Defense; **Leader** Warden

Critical Success The trolls are rebuffed with ease, with no damage to the kingdom. Even better, the kingdom's scouts manage to track the trolls back to their home, revealing Hargulka's lair at area **NM7** to the PCs.

Success Kingdom forces manage to hold the trolls back, but worry still spreads—increase Unrest by 1.

Failure The trolls manage to slaughter a few victims despite the kingdom's best efforts. Increase Unrest by 1d4 and Decay by 1.

Critical Failure As Failure, but the trolls manage to also invade the kingdom and raze some of its lands. If the kingdom has any Farmlands, one randomly determined Farmland is reduced back to its original terrain and must be rebuilt. If it has no farmlands, one hex along the border (as close to area **NM7** as possible) is lost.

Resolution This event ends once the PCs defeat Hargulka in Part 2 of this chapter.



WEIRD GNOME

TROUBLE WITH A WEIRD GNOME EVENT +0

DANGEROUS

Event Rumors of a weird gnome with bright orange hair and glowing eyes have spread through the kingdom. Some people report spotting the strange gnome lurking in unexpected and dangerous places, such as perched atop a steep roof or in the upper boughs of a tall tree, relaxing in a prison cell thought to have been empty, or wandering around in areas that are off-limits to casual visitors, such as in a private residence or the like. As the sightings increase, people begin to associate the weird gnome's appearance with minor accidents or troubles, such as missing tools, illegible graffiti showing up in difficult to reach places, dangerous animals being set loose in the streets, and increasingly isolated fires that are caught and extinguished only moments before they could have spread to something more important.

This event can occur at any time (even well after this chapter has concluded if you wish), and while the PCs themselves should never directly encounter the weird gnome, the descriptions of a man with bright orange hair, glowing eyes, and a fashionably questionable red and yellow outfit should be repeated aspects of the rumors. This weird gnome is, in fact, a mischievous manifestation of the Lantern King himself, come to the PCs' kingdom to look around, cause minor bits of mischief, and to size up what he suspects will be Nyrissa's final conquest. The point of this event is less to give the PCs something to defeat or fight, but to foreshadow a growing element of fey influence over the region. When the PCs finally meet the Lantern King at the end of Chapter 11 of this adventure, consider having him reveal himself to have been this weird gnome if this event lingers in your players' minds by that point in the game.

In any event, the weird gnome sightings end soon after they begin, leaving many to wonder at the true nature of this strange little troublemaker.

Kingdom Skill Intrigue; **Leader** Magister

Critical Success Kingdom investigators and spellcasters confirm that the weird gnome is likely no gnome at all, but a mischievous trickster fey, potentially from the First World. This knowledge allows your kingdom to both respond to the mischief more quickly and soothes the worries of the citizens. Decrease Unrest by 1.

Success Kingdom investigators fail to track down the gnome, and while sightings eventually taper off, the damage is done and the citizens continue to worry. Increase Unrest by 1.

Failure No explanation for the weird gnome's antics are ever arrived at, and in addition to making the citizens uneasy, some of the gnome's pranks had lasting effects. Increase Unrest by 1 and one Ruin of the party's choice by 1

Critical Failure As failure, but increase Unrest by 2 and two Ruins of the party's choice by 1.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



PART 2:

TROLL TROUBLE

As part of her plan to help forge a powerful kingdom to claim as a trophy, Nyrissa sent her agents to spur a powerful troll named Hargulka into forming a kingdom of his own. Whether this troll kingdom would prevail, or whether it would simply serve as a catalyst to empower the PCs' nation is irrelevant to Nyrissa as long as one of the two emerges as the clear victor. Under the leadership of Hargulka, the trolls settled in an ancient dwarven outpost in the southwest Narlmarches at about the same time the PCs founded their own kingdom; he assembled followers and began to forge alliances with other monstrous inhabitants in the region, leading raids to amass treasure and power. As it plays out, their attacks grow more numerous, leaving ripples of discord and terror in their wake.

While the PCs can certainly stumble into the troll lair before they're ready, the challenges they'll face within are significant. As soon as the PCs reach 5th level, you can use the Desperate Spies story event (page 194) or the Troll Sightings event (page 199) to lead the PCs into this part.

THE TROLL LAIR

Hargulka has claimed an ancient guard post in the forested hills in the southern Narlmarches (location **NM7**). The fort was built by dwarves ages ago to guard a forgotten trade route, but later abandoned when a purple worm caused extensive damage before the dwarves could drive it off. The trolls cleared the fort and tunnel of their few remaining inhabitants and they

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

now use the structure as a base for staging their raids in the region.

The PCs can discover the location of Hargulka's fortress via some of the events in Part 2. Alternately, they can simply explore the southern Narlmarches; it's common knowledge that the majority of troll sightings seem to come from this direction. They can also use the Hire Adventurers Leadership activity (page 524) to locate the fortress; they do so on a Successful or better result on that activity.

The original entrance to the abandoned guard post sits high on a cliff face among forested hills on the side of a rocky hill and is accessible only by a carefully concealed path. The cunningly constructed entrance cannot be seen from below. A watchtower disguised as a natural rock outcropping also rises from the top of the hill, giving a good view of the surrounding area. Once the fort is located, PCs who take the time to Search for another entrance can discover the overgrown entrance left by the purple worm with a successful DC 25 Perception check (area **A8**).

Unless otherwise noted, the rooms in the guard post are dark and are of solid dwarven construction. They're hewn stone, with smooth stone floors and uniform 15-foot-high ceilings. Doors are made of stone.

TROLL SLAYING

80 KINGDOM XP

The kingdom's citizens demand the PCs step in to defeat Hargulka's trolls.

Source: Residents of the PCs' kingdom

Completion: The PCs slay Hargulka and drive off or defeat the monsters in his fortress.

Reward: The death of Hargulka gives the people of the kingdom much cause to rejoice. Reduce Unrest by 2d6. At the start of the next Kingdom turn, the PCs begin with 3 Fame or Infamy points rather than 1.

A1. THE APPROACH

A narrow path winds its way up the hill, a steep cliff face on one side and a sheer drop-off on the other. At the top, the path follows a wide ledge, where the corner of a weathered stone building juts from the side of the hill.

Any PC climbing the path has a chance to be spotted by the harpies in the watchtower above the guard post, but these monsters aren't very observant, giving PCs a chance to slip by unnoticed (see area **A5** for details). Once the PCs reach the ledge, they can be spotted through arrow slits by the guards in the barbican (area **A2**). From the ledge, it's a 60-foot drop to the forest floor. PCs can Climb the exterior walls of the watchtower with success on a DC 20 Athletics check.

A2. BARBICAN MODERATE 5

A pair of stone doors provides the only entrance from the ledge into the guard post. When the trolls moved in, they broke one of the doors by forcing it open too far. Arrow slits overlook the approach and outside ledge to the north and east. Daylight shining through the arrow slits and the half-open door light the room with dim light. Doors in each interior wall lead further into the fort.

Creatures: A troll and two hobgoblin archers are always posted here, but they spend as much time fighting with each other as they do watching the approach to the lair. As such, they suffer a –4 penalty on initiative checks and Perception checks. Once they notice the PCs, they yell out an alarm at the top of their lungs (although only the trolls and trollhounds in area **A3** will hear it) and attack the intruders; attempt a DC 11 flat check at this time, and on a failure, the trolls in area **A3** assume the alarm is just extra vocal arguments and won't respond. The guards here are under orders to allow no one inside, but it's possible the PCs could use magic or other means to persuade them to allow a peaceful entry. If that happens, a hobgoblin first departs to warn Hargulka, who assembles his court in area **A3** to receive (and likely attack) the visitors.

TROLL CREATURE 5

Pathfinder Bestiary 314

Initiative Perception +11

HOBGOBLIN ARCHERS (2) CREATURE 4

Pathfinder Bestiary 207

Initiative Perception +10

A3. GREAT HALL SEVERE 5

Columns support the high, vaulted ceilings of this great hall. In the middle of the room, a grand staircase leads up to a massive stone throne perched on a balcony that wraps around the sides of the hall, its balustrade carved to resemble a series of stone hammers.

This room, a showcase of ancient dwarven craftsmanship, has withstood the passage of time and retains its grandeur. The balcony level is 20 feet above the main floor, while the ceiling reaches another 30 feet above that.

Creatures: The trolls and other members of Hargulka's retinue train in this room when it's not in use. Typically, two trolls and two trollhounds are stationed here. If they believe the alarm from the guards in area **A2** is real, one of the trolls goes upstairs to warn Hargulka and the other denizens of the fort, while the remaining troll pulls open the doors to the

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



barbican and orders the trollhounds to join the fight. It waits in the doorway to deal with anything that gets through. If the four hobgoblin archers in area **A12** have been alerted to an attack by the PCs, they move to line the balcony here.

TROLLS (2) CREATURE 5

Pathfinder Bestiary 314
Initiative Perception +11

TROLLHOUNDS (2) CREATURE 3

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 268
Initiative Perception +6

An Audience with Hargulka: If the PCs manage to talk their way into the fort, they're greeted by many of its denizens in this room. Hargulka sits on the throne with his consort Gurija (see area **A16**) at his side. His brutish two-headed troll enforcer, Nagrundi (see area **A11**), stands ready to defend his lord. Five trolls and four trollhounds flank the PCs on the lower level of the great hall, while six hobgoblin archers stand on the balcony, crossbows at the ready.

It should be clear to the PCs that this is a situation they're unlikely to emerge from alive if they start a fight, but it gives them a chance to see many of the forces arrayed against them. During any discussion, Hargulka maintains a position of authority, peremptorily dismissing any concerns of the PCs and responding to any threats with promises of violent retribution. If a fight does break out, wise PCs flee. In this case, the trolls do not give chase, merely laughing and taunting the "heroes" in their wake—unwisely assuming that they've seen the last of the PCs.

A4. SHRINE TO TORAG MODERATE 5

Bas-reliefs on the walls of this room depict dwarves forging weapons, fighting giants, mining precious gems, and performing many other activities. Along the northern wall, water flows out of the head of a graven warhammer to fill a font. Dust covers much of the rest of the flat spaces, though it's disturbed in a path extending from the middle of the room to the eastern door.

This room was the dwarves' shrine to Torag, the Father of Dwarvenkind. The relatively clean trail through the dust was created by a hobgoblin archer who discovered the hazard in this room the hard way. Thanks to the remaining power here, the trolls and other denizens of the fort stay out of it. As a result, PCs who have the wherewithal to withstand the haunt

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

could retreat here if they need a safe place to stay in the fort. The font provides a constant flow of cool, fresh water, draining at the same rate it flows in, so it never overflows. This is a minor magical conjuration effect that ends if the font is removed from the room.

Behind a door to the west, a spiral staircase leads up to area **A11**.

Hazard: While the dwarves long ago abandoned this fort, Torag's power remains strong in his shrine, and he disciplines those who don't offer proper obeisance.

THE POWER OF FAITH — HAZARD 7

UNIQUE | COMPLEX | HAUNT

Stealth DC 27 (expert) to hear whispered prayers in Dwarven to Torag

Description The lingering essence of the dwarven worshippers who established this shrine demand deference to Torag and punish those who don't offer it.

Disable Diplomacy DC 27 (trained) to calm the lingering essence, Religion DC 23 (expert) to perform the required obeisance, or Thievery DC 30 (expert) to disrupt and redirect the essence harmlessly.

Prostrate ↷ (divine, emotion, fear, illusion, incapacitation, mental); **Trigger** A creature moves more than 10 feet into the room. **Effect** A great weight settles on all creatures in area **A4**, and they must attempt a DC 25 Will save.

- **Critical Success** The creature is unaffected by the haunt and is temporarily immune to it for 24 hours.
- **Success** The creature feels pressed down by the weight—it takes a 10-foot penalty to all its speeds for as long as it remains in the room.
- **Failure** The creature is knocked prone.
- **Critical Failure** The creature is knocked prone and immobilized for 1 round.

Routine (3 actions; divine, enchantment, mental) Ghostly images of chanting dwarves float through the room, drifting between the creatures in the chamber. As they float, they use their 3 actions to target up to three different creatures in the room, touching their brows and filling that person's head with overwhelming but entirely mental choirs exalting the glory of Torag. The haunt targets prone creatures before other creatures, and a single creature cannot be targeted more than once per round. A targeted creature must attempt a DC 25 Will save; prone creatures take a –2 penalty on this saving throw.

- **Critical Success** The creature is unaffected.
- **Success** The creature takes 1d10 mental damage from the cacophonous choir in their head.
- **Failure** The creature takes 2d10+9 mental damage from the cacophonous choir in their head.
- **Critical Failure** The creature takes 3d10+18 mental damage from the cacophonous choir in their head and is knocked prone.

Reset The haunt deactivates as soon as no living creatures are in area **A4**, then resets after 1 hour has passed. It can be permanently destroyed by clearing the fortress of all creatures that don't follow Torag and rededicating it to the god with a *consecrate* ritual.

A5. WATCHTOWER — MODERATE 5

A flight of stone stairs winds around in this circular chamber to a trapdoor in the ceiling high above. A foul stench fills the air, emanating from layers of filth caked on the floor.

The trolls use this chamber as their latrine. The hallway to the west of this area once led to a stairwell leading up to the level above, but it has long since collapsed. The stairs to the east lead up 100 feet to the sole room at the top of the tower, which a pair of harpies recruited by Hargulka have turned into a nest. A trapdoor in the ceiling of the upper level leads to the tower's roof, 30 feet above the hillside.

Creatures: The two harpies are indifferent guards at best. Each time the PCs could possibly catch their interest, attempt a DC 11 flat check; on a failure, the harpies are occupied with their own interests rather than keeping an eye on the approach. If the harpies notice combat in area **A1**, they use their captivating song to try to fascinate PCs (possibly also affecting the creatures in area **A2**) and then Shove them off any heights; otherwise they assume the guards in area **A2** will handle any visitors. If reduced to 30 Hit Points, a harpy retreats to the watchtower; the first wounded harpy to retreat flies down inside the watchtower to alert the trolls in area **A6**, who go to the barbican to help fight.

HARPIES (2) — CREATURE 5

Pathfinder Bestiary 204

Initiative Perception +12

Treasure: Each harpy wears jewelry worth 60 gp—their share claimed from various raids and tributes.

A6. TROLL BARRACKS — MODERATE 5

The floor of this room is littered with a half dozen pallets made of branches, leaves, and smelly, uncured hides.

The rank-and-file trolls stay in this room when they are in the fort.

Creatures: The first time the PCs enter this room, two off-duty trolls are resting in this cavern unless they were earlier warned of intruders. They ignore the sounds of combat from other rooms, but they leap to their feet and attack any non-troll entering their living quarters.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

TROLLS (2) CREATURE 5

Pathfinder Bestiary 314
Initiative Perception +11

A7. LEUCROTTA DEN MODERATE 5

The rear wall of this room has collapsed, creating an opening between it and a rough cavern tunnel. Three pallets fill the remaining corners of the room, and various bones—some with a few chunks of raw meat still clinging to them—litter the floor.

This room was penetrated from the cavern by a purple worm centuries ago, though the trolls cleared much of the rubble when they arrived.

Creatures: The two leucrottas that could have been encountered in area **KL6** (page 80) are encountered here, unless the PCs slaughtered them already. The beasts ignore the sounds of combat elsewhere, assuming it's trollhounds or trolls fighting amongst themselves, but attack any strangers that enter their quarters. If reduced to fewer than 20 Hit Points, a leucrotta flees the region, not willing to give its life for Hargulka.

LEUCROTTAS (2) CREATURE 5

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 162
Initiative Stealth +11

A8. WORM TUNNEL

This rough tunnel left by the passage of the purple worm is 20 feet tall, has an uneven floor and ceiling, and has rocks littering the passageway. Thick vines lining the entrance make it hard to find and prevent much sunlight from entering even during the day—the first 20 feet is dim light before it fades to darkness. The tunnel slopes steeply upward as it travels west, where the worm's passage damaged some of the fort, knocking down a wall in one room. It also collapsed the spiral staircase just northwest of area **A7**, leaving no way to access it from below.

A9. TROLLHOUND KENNEL MODERATE 5

Thick chains are bolted to the walls of this cavern, and the floor is covered with bones, half-eaten rotting meat, and mounds of foul-smelling dung.

Creatures: A pack of four trollhounds are chained to the northern wall of this cavern. The chains, connected to iron collars around the trollhounds' necks, are long enough to allow the trollhounds to reach any part of the cavern. They attack any non-troll entering the area. Though not strong enough to break the thick iron chains, the trollhounds can Force Open the hooks that connect the chains to their collars with success on a DC 25 Athletics check. If Kargadd in area **A10** hears combat here, he rushes to the room to join the fight. It takes him a single action with the manipulate trait to unhook an adjacent trollhound's chain from its collar, should the need arise. If the trollhounds hear combat in area **A10**, they try to break free of their chains and rush to support Kargadd, pursuing PCs to the death.

If the PCs are ever captured by the trolls, they are chained to the southern wall here. The trollhounds' chains are shortened just enough that they can't reach any captives who stay close to the wall, though they remain a threat to anyone who tries to escape.

TROLLHOUNDS (3) CREATURE 3

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 268
Initiative Perception +6

A10. LARDER LOW 5

The temperature in this cavern seems somewhat cooler than that of the rest of complex, but the stench of decaying flesh hangs heavy in the air. Along the walls are stacked the carcasses of dozens of beasts, from foxes and wolves to deer and elk, as well as a couple of horses and what appears to be a skinned bear. The southern portion of the room holds a grislier collection of corpses: the bodies of several humanoids, from gnomes and halflings to humans and elves. Most of the cadavers seem to have been decapitated.

The trolls store their food in this cavern, which is naturally cooler than the other caves (though not cold enough to stave off decay). Most of the carcasses are already rotting and infested with vermin as a result. The trolls send out regular hunting parties to keep the larder well stocked. The heads of the humanoid bodies were given to Nagrundi to keep the two-headed giant happy and distracted (see area **A11**). The ceiling is 15 feet high in this cavern.

Creature: A cavern troll named Kargadd claims the larder as his personal domain. He has little grasp of tactics; the closest he comes to making decisions other than "smash the next one" in combat is racing to aid his beloved pet trollhounds in area **A9** if he suspects they're in trouble. He relies on his regeneration to keep him in the fight and is utterly surprised if he is slain.

KARGADD CREATURE 6

Male cavern troll (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 265)
Initiative Perception +14

A11. NAGRUNDI'S ROOM SEVERE 5

Gnawed bones litter the floor of this room, while shelves on

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

the eastern wall hold a collection of severed heads—some from animals, but others from humanoid victims.

The spiral stairs nearby lead down to area **A4**.

Creature: One of the most dangerous and frightening members of Hargulka's retinue is a giant, two-headed brute named Nagrundi. Claiming to be the son of an ettin father and a troll mother, Nagrundi stands erect (not hunched over, like most trolls) at 15 feet tall. Although not much smarter than the other trolls under Hargulka's command, the two-headed troll possesses a brutish cunning in both his skulls. A firm believer that two heads are better than one, Nagrundi considers himself something of an intellectual and forgoes conversation with "dose idjits" in his gang in favor of mind-numbingly vapid dialogues with himself. If he becomes aware of combat in area **A16**, he rushes to help defend Hargulka. He tries to frighten and Demoralize opponents on the first round of combat using Intimidation, then moves to engage the largest-looking foe in melee. Dim to the point of foolishness (and knowing the price of failure at Hargulka's hands), Nagrundi fights to the death, roaring defiance with both heads to his last breath.

NAGRUNDI CREATURE 8

Male two-headed troll (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 266)

Initiative Perception +18

Treasure: Nagrundi has (poorly) hidden his treasure in a niche in the northwest corner of the room. A successful DC 15 Perception check can reveal the stash, which consists of 74 sp, 35 gp, and a *clear spindle aeon stone* that Nagrundi doesn't realize is magic.

A12. HOBGOBLIN BARRACKS SEVERE 5

Two stone tables run the length of this room, their tops cluttered with tools and outdoor gear. Rough wooden stools are tucked under the tables, and a dozen bedrolls lie along the walls a short distance from the doors that lead into this room.

Creatures: This former dining room has been made into living and working quarters for Hargulka's hobgoblin supporters. The hobgoblins joined Hargulka initially out of a desire to help build a kingdom strong enough to conquer the "softer neighboring human lands," but it didn't take long for them to become frustrated at the troll's chaotic nature. Today, they mostly keep to themselves in this room, but if warned of an attack, they dutifully report to area **A3** and spread out on the balcony to fire at any PCs who enter the room.

During a fight in the barracks, as soon as two of the hobgoblins are defeated the other two immediately surrender, dropping their weapons and promising to help the PCs defeat the trolls in return for their lives. At your option, and if the PCs grant mercy to the survivors, quick action can save the two defeated hobgoblins and, with some healing, secure another two allies in the fight against Hargulka.

HOBGOBLIN ARCHERS (4) CREATURE 4

Pathfinder Bestiary 207

Initiative Perception +10



paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Treasure: In addition to the hobgoblins' armor and weapons, the room contains the equivalent of 10 adventurer's packs as well as two repair kits and a half dozen short tools the hobgoblins use to maintain their weapons and make ammunition.

A13. STOREROOM

Stacked boxes, barrels, crates, and bags fill this room from floor to ceiling and line the crude wooden shelves along the walls. Doors lead to the north, east and west.

The trolls store most of the mundane goods they have extorted or stolen in this room, which once served the dwarves as a kitchen. The more valuable items are taken to Hargulka's vault (area **A15**).

Resources: The goods stored here, including foodstuffs, lumber, mundane tools, household supplies, bolts of cloth, and so on, require several full wagonloads to transport back to civilization, but if the PCs take the time to do so, the resources grant 4 bonus Resource Dice at the start of the next Kingdom turn.

A14. KOBOLD HOLE MODERATE 5

Strange symbols are chalked in a semicircle on the floor in front of the doorway of this cramped chamber. Beyond them, a small cauldron boils merrily above a smoky fire, near a pair of threadbare blankets.

If the PCs have already slain or recruited the two kobolds, this room is empty.

Creatures: What once served as a pantry is now the quarters for Hargulka's two conscripted kobold spies, Kereek and Prazil. Kereek drew the symbols on the floor—claiming they were an arcane ward to keep the trolls out—to comfort Prazil, but in truth they're nothing more than chalk scribbles. The trolls keep the two kobolds almost as pets, forcing them to live in this somewhat cramped little room. They remain here unless ordered on a mission by Hargulka.

When the PCs enter the room, the kobolds are eager to talk and fight only if attacked. They begin as indifferent to the PCs (unless an earlier encounter already changed their attitude toward the PCs). If they can be made friendly, they can provide useful information about the fort (Kereek managed to discover the secret door connecting areas **A15** and **A16**) and its inhabitants; if made helpful, they'll volunteer this information and will even join forces with the PCs to help fight the trolls. Yet even then, their bravery remains potentially suspect, and if one of the two kobolds falls in combat, the other panics and tries to drag his fallen comrade away to safety.

KEREEK AND PRAZIL CREATURE 5

Male kobold spies (page 196)
Initiative Perception +12

Reward: If the PCs secure the kobolds' help, award XP as though they had defeated them in combat.

A15. HARGULKA'S VAULT

Piles of coins and other valuable goods sit on the floor and shelves of this room, glittering in the light from a couple of torches set in sconces on the wall.

The spiral stairs just east of this room once led down to the lower level, but the passage of the purple worm long ago collapsed the stairs below, leaving this staircase a dead end.

The secret door connecting the vault to area **A16** can be found with success on a DC 25 Perception check.

Treasure: Hargulka keeps most of the valuables the gang has acquired close to him. In addition to the two *everburning torches* on the wall, this makeshift vault holds 484 cp, 210 sp, 39 gp, a small statue of a dragon carved from rare wood worth 15 gp, a gold necklace with a jade pendant worth 30 gp, several pieces of minor jewelry worth a total 40 gp, five medium quality gemstones worth 5 gp each, three bottles of not-so-fine wine worth 1 gp each, an engraved silver tankard worth 3 gp, and a *bracelet of dashing* inside a silver goblet decorated with images of Cayden Cailean worth 8 gp.

A16. HARGULKA'S ROOM EXTREME 5

A wagon with its wheels removed sits against the western wall, heaped with smelly furs. A crude throne carved from a giant tree stump sits on a large bearskin spread on the floor in front of a large map pinned to the northern wall.

This room is the personal quarters of the troll leader, Hargulka, and his consort, Gurija. The wagon serves as their bed. The large map on the wall is drawn on the back of a thylacine hide. It notes several locations in the Stolen lands, including the troll lair and the PCs' settlements; some marked with large X marks along with several arrows and other marks showing planned raids and routes of attack. Anyone who speaks Jotun can tell that the trolls have been carrying out a series of organized, planned attacks in the region against locations where civilization has intruded on the Stolen Lands. Of particular note is a site in the Sellen Hills marked with a skull and a single word in Jotun: "DANGER." This location marks the lair of the enormous owlbear, area **SH4**.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Creatures: Hargulka spends a fair amount of his time planning raids, enjoying the latest meals and prizes his trolls have gathered for him, and daydreaming about being the ruler of his own petty kingdom. Inspired to pursue this path by vibrant dreams of himself ruling the Stolen Lands, Hargulka doesn't suspect that those dreams were implanted by Nyrissa—a mistake his current consort Gurija has capitalized upon.

Gurija possesses a powerful inborn magical quality, elements granted by her deep faith in Urxhel, the demon lord of trolls and storms. Alone among the trolls who flocked to Hargulka's call to violence, Gurija sees beyond the immediate potential for violence and swiftly convinced Hargulka she was "sent by the thunderclouds" to guide him into his new role as king of the Stolen Lands.

Unless an alarm has been raised, the two trolls are quite surprised if the PCs make it all the way here and leap to their feet to take care of the intruders themselves. Hargulka takes up a defensive position in front of Gurija, not out of any true protectiveness, but rather because he knows her magic can be a powerful aid. They both fight to the death, certain of their own power and destiny to rule.

HARGULKA CREATURE 8

Page 598

Initiative Perception +16

GURIJA CREATURE 5

UNIQUE | CE | LARGE | GIANT | TROLL

Female troll sorcerer

Perception +11; darkvision

Languages Abyssal, Common, Jotun

Skills Athletics +10, Deception +13, Intimidation +13, Religion +11

Str +3, **Dex** +2, **Con** +4, **Int** +0, **Wis** +0, **Cha** +4

Items hide armor, *wand of shocking grasp (2nd)*

AC 21; **Fort** +13, **Ref** +13, **Will** +11

HP 95, regeneration 20 (deactivated by acid or fire); **Resistances** electricity 5; **Weaknesses** fire 10

Speed 30 feet

Melee ❖ jaws +12 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 2d10+5 piercing

Melee ❖ claws +12 (agile, reach 10 feet), **Damage** 2d8+5 slashing

Primal Spontaneous Spells DC 22, attack +14; **3rd** *lightning bolt*, *slow*; **2nd** *dispel magic*, *hydraulic push*, *resist energy*; **1st** *fear*, *magic fang*, *shocking grasp*; **Cantrips (3rd)** *electric arc*, *prestidigitation*, *ray of frost*, *read aura*, *tanglefoot*

Sudden Stormburst ↻ (evocation, primal, water) **Requirement** An ally within 60 feet is suffering persistent acid or fire damage. **Effect** Gurija summons a torrential but localized rainstorm around the ally that washes off any acid or douses any fire on it to immediately end persistent acid or fire damage.

ENDING THE TROLL THREAT

The PCs must defeat Hargulka and Gurija to put an end to the threat the trolls pose. If Gurija survives, she takes up his mantle—feel free to have her relocate to another location in the Stolen Lands, but if the PCs leave this location abandoned, she'll have no problem moving back in and, in time, recruiting more allies to a new cause—revenge!



GURIJA

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



PART 3:

HUNTING THE BEAST

While the trolls of Hargulka's nascent monster kingdom are an organized threat to the PCs' own nation, it's far from the only threat. The immense owlbear driven to furious rage by the actions of the bandit Eirikk is poised to lash out at the closest civilization: the PCs' fledgling kingdom!

At some point after the PCs return to their capital city (or, at your discretion, any of their settlements located near the giant owlbear's lair), they'll be greeted with a horrific sight: buildings and structures in shambles. Newly plowed fields have been torn up, trees have been knocked down, livestock have been slaughtered, and buildings have been flattened. A pall of smoke and dust hangs over the settlement, and the few people left on the streets mill about in shock, as if they have just come from a war zone. Any inquiries are met first with blank stares, but eventually the whole story comes out.

Several hours before the PCs returned to town, an enormous owlbear attacked it. The locals have already taken to naming the creature after the settlement it attacked, calling it the "Beast of (settlement name)." The creature is referred to simply as the "Beast" in this chapter, but you should personalize it to the name of the settlement it attacked.

Once the PCs have learned the basics, run the following story Kingdom event. This event doesn't progress the timeline of your adventure; play it out in the context of a flashback, giving the PCs the opportunity not just to catch a glimpse of the Beast in action, but also to have an impact on the amount

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

of damage done by the Beast. Build up to the die roll describing images and sounds of chaos and fear among the townsfolk. Don't be afraid to put some of the players' favorite NPC citizens in apparent danger; if the event ends in success or better, describe those NPCs playing heroic roles in the aftermath. After the roll, as you describe the event's outcome, make sure that the PCs' influence as leaders of the community is part of the story: With success, explain that even while absent, the PCs inspired and influenced the citizens' response; with failure, describe how the townsfolk sorely missed the PCs' support on this day.

RAMPAGE OF THE BEAST — EVENT +4

DANGEROUS | SETTLEMENT

Location A settlement of the GM's choice (preferably the PCs' capital city)

Event The city was attacked by a terrifying owlbear of immense size that crashed into the town and potentially killed dozens before it had its fill of destruction and lumbered off into the Sellen Hills.

Kingdom Skill Defense (if the settlement has only Water borders, then the Beast has a more difficult time reaching the settlement; increase the rolled result by one degree of success); **Leader** Warden (even if the Warden is a PC and thus wasn't present during this event, the PC's prior service as the kingdom's Warden still allows them to influence this event)

Critical Success The enormous owlbear inflicted only relatively minor damage, and while it wounded dozens, miraculously no one was killed. Increase Unrest by 1.

Success The Beast managed to destroy a portion of the city, killed a few citizens, and wounded dozens. Increase Unrest by 1d4 and Decay by 1. Choose one Walled border or one lot with a structure in it; that structure or improvement is destroyed.

Failure The Beast rampaged through the settlement, killing dozens and laying waste to structures. Increase Unrest by 1d6 and Decay by 1d4. Choose one Walled border and two lots with structures in it; those structures and improvements are destroyed.

Critical Failure As Failure, but the Beast's rampage is even more devastating. Increase Unrest by 2d4 and Decay by 1d6. Choose one Walled border and four lots with structures in it; those structures or improvements are destroyed.

Resolution If the PCs don't defeat the Beast by the next Kingdom turn, it becomes a Monster Activity event (page 560). Award the PCs 30 Kingdom XP for this event.

THE BEAST'S DEN

The settlement's citizens make plain their desire—they want the Beast slain before it can return to rampage through the town again. This section assumes the PCs follow the owlbear to its lair to destroy it; adjust if circumstances are different in your game.

The Beast's trail is simple to follow, requiring success on just a DC 10 Survival check to Track. It leaves a swath of felled trees, trampled brush, and churned earth across the southern Kamelands as it returns to its cavern lair at area **SH4**. Splashes of blood dot the trail, indicating that the Beast was at least wounded by the attack on the town; if the PCs hasten in their pursuit, they may be able to confront the monster in its lair before it fully recovers.

The owlbear makes its home in a small cavern complex beneath a rocky tor overlooking the Little Sellen River. There are two entrances to the lair, both normally obscured by vegetation, but the owlbear's rage has resulted in the utter destruction of the vegetation in front of area **B1**, so when this part begins, locating this entrance is automatic once the PCs explore the hex or track the owlbear to its den. A smaller entrance to the shambler's cave in area **B3** can be found only by succeeding at a DC 20 Perception check while exploring the area.

Ceiling height varies from room to room, but the main tunnels average about 10 feet high. Unless otherwise noted, all caves within the hill are dark.

HUNTING THE BEAST

80 KINGDOM XP

The kingdom's citizens demand the PCs hunt down and slay the Beast.

Source: Residents of the PCs' kingdom

Completion: The PCs slay or otherwise defeat the enormous owlbear.

Reward: Defeating the Beast gives the people of the kingdom much cause to rejoice. Reduce Unrest by 2d6. At the start of the next Kingdom turn, the PCs begin with 3 Fame or Infamy points rather than 1.

B1. BLOODY FEATHERS

A dark, gaping hole yawns in the side of a large, rocky hillock. The earth in front of the cave is trampled flat, and shattered trees and stumps bear the marks of powerful claws. Tufts of dark fur are snagged in branches, and huge feathers litter the ground.

As long as the Beast remains active, this entrance remains impossible to miss once the region is explored.

B2. MIDDEN — MODERATE 5

The cave mouth widens into a large cavern filthy with carrion and offal. A bewildering variety of molds and fungi grow on the floor and walls, some as big as a person, and

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



countless insects scuttle about underfoot, feeding on the mounds of waste. A large tunnel slopes down to the east, with smaller tunnels to the north and south.

This 20-foot-high cavern is the owlbear's midden, where it deposits the remains of its kills and leaves its waste in the form of huge regurgitated pellets.

Creatures: Four violet fungi inhabit this cavern. Normally content to feed on the room's filth, they attack any creatures that remain in the room for more than 3 rounds, or that approach within five feet of the southern or northern walls, where they typically lurk.

VIOLET FUNGI (4) — CREATURE 3

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 286
Initiative Stealth +9

Hazard: In addition to the four violet fungi, two shriekers grow in the cavern, one near the western entrance and the other next to the eastern passage. If the shriekers are triggered, the giant owlbear in area **B6** comes to investigate in 2d4 rounds.

SHRIEKERS (2) — HAZARD -1

Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide 77
Stealth DC 12

Treasure: Ten minutes spent Searching the chamber turns up the following items of value: a battered breastplate, a suit of rusted chainmail, three daggers, two longswords, a shortsword, a low-grade silver warhammer, a vial of *silversheen*, a set of infiltrator thieves' tools, and 121 sp in scattered coins.

B3. CAVE OF THE SHAMBLER — MODERATE 5

Rotting leaves and other vegetation fill this irregular cavern. Passages enter from the northeast and southwest, while a smaller opening leads to a narrow tunnel to the east.

Creatures: A shambler dwells in this cavern. It occasionally feeds on the refuse harvested from the midden (area **B2**), but it gives the owlbear a wide berth, preferring to use its own smaller cave entrance to hunt fresh prey in the surrounding woods. The twisted vines of the shambler's body also provide a home to a swarm of bright red centipedes which live in a kind of symbiosis within the plant creature, feeding on bits of flesh and gristle that remain in its body after it feeds. The centipedes have greater cover as long as the shambler is alive. If the shambler is killed, the centipede swarm boils up from its remains and attacks any nearby creatures.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

SHAMBLER CREATURE 6

Pathfinder Bestiary 290

Initiative Perception +12

Symbiotic Swarm ↷ **Trigger** A creature is Grabbed by the shambler. **Effect** The creature is dealt 1d8 piercing damage (DC 20 basic Reflex save) and is exposed to centipede swarm venom.

CENTIPEDE SWARM CREATURE 3

Pathfinder Bestiary 61

Initiative Perception +9

Treasure: A PC succeeding at a DC 20 Perception check turns up a *wand of shocking grasp (2nd)* and all that remains of a hapless (and fatally misinformed) wizard who tried to use it against the shambler.

B4. TWISTING TUNNEL TRIVIAL 5

This narrow tunnel is only about five feet high and slopes gently to the east. Water drips from numerous cracks in the ceiling to flow down the passage in small rivulets.

Hazard: Water seeping down through the hillside above has weakened the floor of this tunnel and carved out a chasm beneath it, leaving a thin layer of deceptive ground that collapses once anyone walks over it.

WEAKENED FLOOR HAZARD 5

ENVIRONMENTAL

Stealth DC 26 (expert)

Description A section of the cave floor collapses under a creature, plunging it 40 feet into a chasm filled with jagged stalactites.

Disable Survival DC 20 to knock loose the unstable floor and reveal a traversable ledge to the south.

Floor Collapse ↷ **Trigger** A Small or larger creature enters the marked portion of the map; **Effect** The triggering creature falls, taking 20 damage from the fall plus 3d6 piercing damage (DC 22 basic Reflex save) from the stalagmites. A creature can Grab an Edge to avoid falling, or succeed at a DC 20 Athletics check to climb out of the chasm.

B5. SPIDER NEST MODERATE 5

The narrow tunnel widens here into a natural cavern, the dimensions of which are hard to discern due to the thick sheets of webbing that fill the place.

Creatures: Several giant spiders, black-and-red monsters known as caveweaver spiders, inhabit this cavern. They are protected from the owlbear by the narrow width of their tunnels and know better than to creep too closely into its actual cave. The spiders attack any other creature invading their lair.

CAVEWEAVER SPIDERS (6) CREATURE 2

Elite hunting spiders (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6, 306)

Initiative Perception +9

B6. LAIR OF THE BEAST EXTREME 5

The ceiling of this huge cavern arches thirty feet into the air. A murky pool of water stands in the southern portion of the cavern in front of a narrow passage, little more than a crack, that opens in the wall. Wider, sloping tunnels lead out of the cave to the west and northeast. A jumble of bones, rocks, fur, and feathers sits piled against the eastern wall.

This cavern serves as the Beast's nest. The pool provides drinking water for the owlbear and many of the other denizens of the caves.

The body of Eirikk, the barbarian beast-handler sent by Nyrissa to control the owlbears but killed before he could get the monster under control (page 187), lies



THE BEAST

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

stashed behind the owlbear's nest. A search of the body turns up a map of the Greenbelt with the PCs' town and the owlbear lair clearly marked. Of course, Nyrissa never intended Eirikk to live to see the plan through; she used him as nothing more than a tool to enrage the owlbear and send it on its way. Eirikk's remains are far too mangled to be of use for a *talking corpse* spell.

Creatures: The first time the PCs reach this chamber, the giant owlbear is sleeping in this cave, either recovering from its recent attack on the PCs' kingdom or other regional rampages if the PCs took longer than a week or so to reach this room.

While the Beast is a 9th-level creature, its hit points are lower than normal as a result of its wounds from the recent attack on the PC's settlement. Even if the PCs haven't confronted the Beast within a month of its attack, the creature's continued rampages on nearby areas keep it from ever fully healing. If you wish to have the PCs be confronted by a fully healed beast, increase its HP to 160.

THE BEAST — CREATURE 9

UNIQUE | N | HUGE | ANIMAL

Variant owlbear (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 259)

Perception +19; low-light vision, scent (imprecise) 30 feet

Skills Acrobatics +18, Athletics +20, Intimidation +18

Str +7, **Dex** +3, **Con** +6, **Int** –4, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +3

AC 28; **Fort** +21, **Ref** +16, **Will** +19

HP 120

Speed 30 feet

Melee ❖ talon +21 (agile), **Damage** 2d10+10 piercing plus Grab

Melee ❖ beak +21, **Damage** 2d12+10 piercing

Bloodcurdling Screech ❖ (auditory, emotion, fear, mental) As owlbear, but DC 25 Will save.

Gnaw ❖ As owlbear, but DC 28 Will save.

Screeching Advance ❖❖ (auditory, emotion, fear, mental) As owlbear.

Treasure: Eirikk's body is still outfitted with his gear: a chain shirt, a *+1 striking longsword*, a *ring of bestial friendship* (page 588), two *+1 throwing axes*, a jar of lesser antiplague, a vial of lesser antitoxin, two lesser smokesticks, a moderate tanglefoot bag, a moderate thunderstone, 3 gp, and 4 sp.

B7. TOMB OF THE FALLEN — SEVERE 5

The buzzing of flies fills this twenty-foot-high cavern. At the eastern end, a wide ledge runs along the wall at fifteen feet. Two tunnels exit the cavern to the west, one narrow and one wide. In the northern portion of the cavern lies the giant carcass of a great beast, surrounded by at least a half dozen torn-apart humanoid bodies.

The giant carcass is the body of the owlbear's mate, slain by Eirikk's bandits. The corpses of these bandits are scattered around the carcass, killed by the Beast after they slew his mate.

A web-choked hole in the ceiling above the ledge leads to a natural chimney. Success on a DC 15 Athletics check is required to Climb the chimney, which leads up 15 feet to area **B8**.

Hazard: The traumatic slaying of the Beast's mate and the subsequent brutal deaths of the bandits left a psychic stain on this room, creating a haunt that may play out in yet more violence. If the PCs defeat the Beast before entering this room, the otherworldly energies that sustain the haunt maintain it for a week, after which, if the PCs still haven't entered this cave, the haunt fades away.

ENDLESS STRUGGLE — HAZARD 8

UNIQUE | CE | COMPLEX | HAUNT

Stealth +18 (expert)

Description Vicious spirits of the two owlbears, Eirikk, and the rest of the bandits rise and resume their final battle.

Disable Nature DC 24 (expert) three times to empathize with the bestial spirits that comprise the haunt and to calm them, or Religion DC 28 (expert) two times to exorcise the haunt and disperse its energy.

AC 27; **Fort** +12, **Ref** +12, **Will** +18

HP 66, negative healing; **Immunities** critical hits, precision damage; **Weaknesses** positive 10; **Resistances** all 10 (except force, *ghost touch*, or positive; double resistance vs. non-magical)

Spectral Uprising ↻ **Trigger** More than three Small or larger living creatures are in area **B7** at the end of a turn. **Effect** Spectral figures of the bandits and owlbears manifest in a sudden and overwhelming battle of endless violence. All living creatures in area **B7** must make a successful DC 28 Will save or become frightened 1 (frightened 3 on a critical failure).

Routine (3 actions; emotion, fear, mental) The spectral violence churns and flashes through the room, targeting three separate creatures with ghostly claws, beaks, swords, and arrows. At the end of the haunt's turn, it takes its Spectral Uprising reaction.

Melee ghostly attack +20, **Damage** 2d10+7 negative plus 1d6 bleed

Reset The haunt resets after 24 hours; it can be permanently destroyed if it is either disabled or destroyed after the Beast itself has been slain.

Treasure: The corpses of the bandits still wear their gear, consisting of six suits of studded leather armor, six wooden shields, six daggers, six longswords, six shortbows, 84 arrows, and a mix of coins worth 30 sp.

Owlbear Cub: At your option, a hungry, lonely

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

owlbear cub can be found here as well; if rescued, it could be raised as a pet, guardian, or companion for a PC.

B8. THE BACK DOOR — MODERATE 7

Thousands of tiny spiders scurry among the walls of this small cave, and several large web cocoons hang from the ceiling. An opening leads outside onto a ledge on the eastern face of the hill, and two smaller rooms open off the main cave to the north and south. In the rear of the cave, a wide hole drops into the earth.

This cave sits about 30 feet up the eastern side of the hill. It provides an alternate entrance to the caverns that can be used to avoid most of the dangers of the owlbear's lair. The ceilings in this cave are about 10 feet high. The hole in the back of the cave is choked with webs and is the top opening of a natural chimney. Success on a DC 15 Athletics check is required to Climb down the chimney, which drops down 15 feet to a ledge in area **B7**.

Creatures: A pair of web lurkers and their three caveweaver spider companions inhabit this cave; they avoid the owlbear's lair. The web lurkers live in the central cave, while the caveweaver spiders lair in the smaller side caves. The web lurkers attack any creature entering their cave, calling their pet spiders to their aid, then trying to immobilize foes with their web attacks. They try to avoid melee combat, but they will use their poisonous fangs to subdue difficult enemies. If one of the web lurkers is slain, the survivor tries to flee into the forest outside.

WEB LURKERS (2) — CREATURE 3

Pathfinder Bestiary 325
Initiative Perception +10

CAVEWEAVER SPIDERS (3) — CREATURE 2

Elite hunting spiders (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6, 306)
Initiative Perception +9

Hazard: The web lurkers have strung a line of sticky webbing across the entrance to their cave to catch any intruders.

WEB-LURKER NOOSE — HAZARD 2

Pathfinder Bestiary 325
Stealth DC 22

Treasure: The cocooned body of an unfortunate explorer hangs in the western cave. He still wears his leather armor and his *healer's gloves*, and the pouch on his belt contains a large amethyst worth 40 gp and a darkwood but empty hip flask worth 10 gp.

CONCLUDING THE CHAPTER

Of all the story-focused chapters in Kingmaker, this one is the most open-ended. There's no real timeline of threats the PCs need to follow during the course of the adventure, nor is there a single "boss monster" that signals the end. The next chapter has its own set of events to get it going once the PCs reach 6th level. The events of "Rivers Run Red" can continue to play out once that chapter's events begin.



ENDLESS STRUGGLE

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



CHAPTER 5

CULT OF THE BLOOM

BY STEVEN T. HELT AND JAMES JACOBS

PART 1: SEEDS OF RUIN 216
The PCs should be 6th level before the invitation to join the hunting expedition is delivered to them.

PART 2: FULL BLOOM 228
The PCs should be 6th level during their investigation of the Cult of the Bloom and their visit to Greengripe.

PART 3: CRADLE OF LAMASHTU 238
The PCs should be 7th level before attempting to explore the Cradle of Lamashtu.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



PART 1:

SEEDS OF RUIN

In the wake of obvious threats including troll kingdoms and elephant-sized owlbears, a new threat grows subtly in the kingdom's shadows. A band of Lamashtu worshippers called the Cult of the Bloom seeks to make an offering to the Mother of Monsters by sacrificing the citizens of the kingdom to her glory. They plan to accomplish this by converting the Stolen Lands into a region of marauding monsters by capitalizing on the region's growing connection to the raw forces of life itself in the First World.

The method of corrupting energies from the First World to further the demands of Lamashtu came to a fanatical cleric named Darivan in the form of a ritual learned during a series of fevered meditations. Whether or not this ritual, *monstrous bloom*, was actually sent to him by Lamashtu herself as Darivan claims, it is both effective and awful in its effects. Its power allowed Darivan to gather a sizable following and bring them into the Stolen Lands. The cult has settled their base of operations in a cave network in the western foothills of the Tors of Levenies. Their prayers and ceremonies, combined with the use of the *monstrous bloom* ritual, have cursed the ground there, creating the first of the cursed bloom pods—plants the cult can use to spread their influence throughout the Stolen Lands.

The nature of the curse is as horrifying as it is insidious. Darivan's seeds corrupt the meat of any animal that eats them. Any predator who eats a pod-infected creature in turn is also cursed, including humanoids all the way up the compromised food chain.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

This infestation takes root within, growing in the flesh of the victims and eroding their minds, causing them to become increasingly wild and emotional. The curse itself isn't particularly efficient as it spreads out through the environment—for most of those who become infected, the sensation manifests as little more than a temporary lapse of inhibitions followed by belly aches—but for those who are particularly susceptible through chance or fate, the curse takes root and eventually uses the body to fuel a burst of energies from the fecund planes of the First World and the Abyss alike. The result is a spectacular explosion as the creature transforms from within into a writhing tangle of alien plants from the heart of which emerges a ravenous monster that immediately sets out to hunt. With Lamashtu's blessing, these seeds of ruin will blossom into a brand-new season in the Stolen Lands—the Season of Bloom.

AN INVITATION TO HUNT

With Hargulka defeated and the Beast slain, the kingdom settles in for some well-deserved peace. After all, court antics and political intrigue might seem preferable to most in the wake of an army of trolls or a rampaging giant owlbear. Certainly, the work of governance has more to offer than the risk of being murdered and devoured by green-skinned giants.

Consider having several Kingdom turns play out between the end of the previous chapter and the start of this one, both to give the PCs a chance to enjoy their growing nation and to let its level and strength rise. Once some time has passed, and the PCs and their kingdom are 6th level, the Season of Bloom begins.

At this time, a hunter's guild known as the Embeth Travelers comes to the PCs' kingdom with an invitation. Whether the invitation is hand delivered by a courier or read aloud by a guild member making an official visit to the kingdom's leaders is left to you to decide. Either way, guild leader Jamel Visser's invitation is short and succinct; it is presented nearby as **Handout 5–1**.

(Feel free to adjust the timing of when Jamel hopes to meet the PCs at the rebuilt hunting lodge, which is located at area **KL7**.)

It's possible that the PCs might be suspicious of the invitation. A PC can attempt a DC 22 Society check or a DC 18 Hunting Lore check to Recall Knowledge about the Embeth Travelers. Alternatively, they can take the time to Gather Information with a DC 20 Diplomacy check. On a success, the PC recalls that the group is a hunter's guild that acts as guides and teachers to those who share their reverence for the natural world and its bounty. They hire out to governments from time to time to stamp out bandits and monsters, but mostly they're known for their expertise in tracking, hunting, and woodland survival. On a critical success, the character knows that Jamel Visser, the leader of the Embeth Travelers, has a reputation for fairness and compassion for the common folk, but has little patience for government inefficiency and corruption.

A kingdom that cares for its people meets with the grand ranger's approval, but those who use their leadership for personal gain aggravate the man and compel him to do what he can to make life better for the general citizenry. The PCs' actions against the trolls and the owlbear have caught his attention, and he wants to get to know these new regional rulers in the best way he knows how: by inviting them on a hunt.

KINGDOM IN THE BACKGROUND

This chapter assumes that the citizens are pleased with their new rulers after having been saved from the predations of monsters and trolls. Festive feelings and hopefulness are everywhere, and the invitation to the PCs to take part in the hunt is but one manifestation of this. But as this chapter progresses, the kingdom begins to suffer heavily from the fear that anyone could suddenly transform into a monster, causing the citizens to look to their leaders more than ever, not only for protection, but for a solution to the horrors.

The kingdom expands in size during this chapter to encompass Zones 1 through 5, with some expansion into Zone 6. The nation's capital of Shrikewall has already expanded into a town in Zone 3, but it isn't quite at the level of a city yet. Olegton in Zone 1 also gains town status, as does Tatzlford in Zone 2. Two new villages are established as well: Silvershore in Zone 4 where Lake Silverstep drains into the Gudrin River, and Huntvale in Zone 5 around the site of the Statue of Erastil (area **NM1**). The monsters at area **KL8** have been causing difficulty for river trade to Silvershore, so defeating them later in Part 1 of this chapter will be particularly helpful.

MORE MONSTERS

Throughout this chapter, those cursed by the cult explode into rampaging monsters. As a result of this increase in monstrous activity, the number of random encounters as the PCs travel the Stolen Lands during this chapter increases; check for random encounters one additional time every 24 hours. Once the PCs progress into Part 2 of this chapter, consider having some of these random encounters begin with a wild animal, traveler, bandit, or less threatening creature suddenly bursting to release a bloom-fresh monster. As always, keep an eye on your players' interest: if all these wandering monster encounters seem to be bogging down play, ease off on them for a time.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Esteemed Defenders of the People
and new regents of the Stolen Lands!

As civilization comes to these wilds, you have distinguished yourselves in seeing to the safety of your people, yet much danger remains. I invite you to attend to a hunting trip to a particularly monster-infested reach on the banks of the Gudrin River, along with several other hunters and explorers of note. Three days hence, on the eve of the hunt, we shall all meet for a night of friendship and revelry at an old hunting lodge we have recently rebuilt, some 24 miles upriver from Tuskwater Lake on the Gudrin.

As your kingdom grows, integrating with neighbors on peaceful terms is important, and this event will not only give us all a chance to become friends, but to make the Stolen Lands a little bit safer for us all.

Yours in good trust,
Grand Ranger Jamel Visser

HANDOUT 5-1

THE HUNTING LODGE

The hunting lodge where the Embeth Travelers have set up the meeting with the PCs and others is located in area **KL7**. Two other groups arrive before the PCs do along with the Embeth Travelers themselves. In addition, the Travelers have hired a small staff of cooks, servers, and cleaners to turn the formerly abandoned hunting lodge into something more like a tavern.

As with the feast in Chapter 1, the PCs' interactions with the other hunters at the lodge are presented as influence encounters (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 151–153). The meeting itself begins a few hours before sunset, lasts for three hours, and plays out in three one-hour rounds. During each round, a few short, scripted scenes occur, after which each PC has a chance to Influence or Discover information about the NPCs. Influence statistics for the three groups appear at the end of this section.

Round 1—Meet and Greet: As the PCs arrive, they are greeted by Jamel Visser himself, a grinning, affable man whose congeniality can vanish in an instant if he perceives an insult or challenge. Jamel introduces the PCs to the others he has invited on this trip: Edina and Jolia Aldori from Varnhold, and Annamede Belavarah from Pitax; the latter is attended by two gruff men sent more to keep her safe than to hunt monsters. Following the introductions, Jamel informs the PCs they have a little time to mingle and chat while the lodge's staff prepares the evening's meal. If the PCs arrived on horseback, a former farmhand named Timol sees that their mounts are tended to. Jamel and the invited guests spend the hour relaxing in the outdoor seating area surrounding the lodge. Conversation ranges from small talk about the local flora and fauna to deeply interested inquiries about the PCs' plans for their kingdom. Throughout the evening, Timol regularly checks in on each of the guests to ensure their needs are being served.

Round 2—Dinner: An hour later, Timol calls everyone to dinner, and the conversation moves indoors to the lodge's dining hall. Dinner is prepared by a talented, grizzled man named Orline and served by Timol. The food is robust and tasty but not that fancy; Annamede is amused, commenting that the "rustic presentation adds an unusual texture to the flavor of the feast." A recurring conversation topic during dinner is Jamel's difficulty in deciding on a name for the hunting lodge, which the Travelers would like to open as a public tavern; he invites everyone to offer suggestions, but he isn't quite ready to make a final decision.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Round 3—Preparations for the Hunt: As dinner winds down, mugs of cider, coffee, and tea are offered alongside cheese and fruit. Jamel requests everyone's attention and explains why he arranged this hunt. The Embeth Travelers found a grievously wounded local named Vath Locher washed up on the shore of the Gudrin River; the man perished from his wounds soon after imparting a warning about the wyvern that attacked his family in their cabin upriver. The Travelers investigated but broke off their hunt after discovering evidence of two additional monsters in the area: a hydra and a krooth. Faced with a greater concentration of threats than he was comfortable handling with his own group, Jamel initiated this gathering to make a friendly competition out of it.

At this point, he produces a small coffer and explains that the group that makes the most monster kills tomorrow shall win a prize: 80 gp, a *returning weapon runestone*, and a *wand of cure moderate wounds*. After this, the PCs and NPCs are free to chat for the remainder of the night (and play out the final round of the influence encounter). As each guest wishes to retire, Timol leads them to their room for the night.

ANNAMEDE BELAVARAH CREATURE 8

CN | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Female human bard 5

Perception +16

Will +16

Discovery DC 24 Perception, DC 22 Pitax Lore, DC 24 Society

Influence Skills DC 20 Performance (to catch Annamede's attention with your artistic talent), DC 22 Society (to impress Annamede with your social graces), DC 24 Diplomacy, DC 16 Deception, DC 26 Intimidate

Influence 2: Annamede enjoys the PCs' company and responds well to them if they encounter her the next day in the hunting grounds (area **A4**).

Influence 4: Annamede takes a favorable view of the PCs. She remembers them should they meet again and may provide assistance during the Rushlight Festival in Chapter 8.

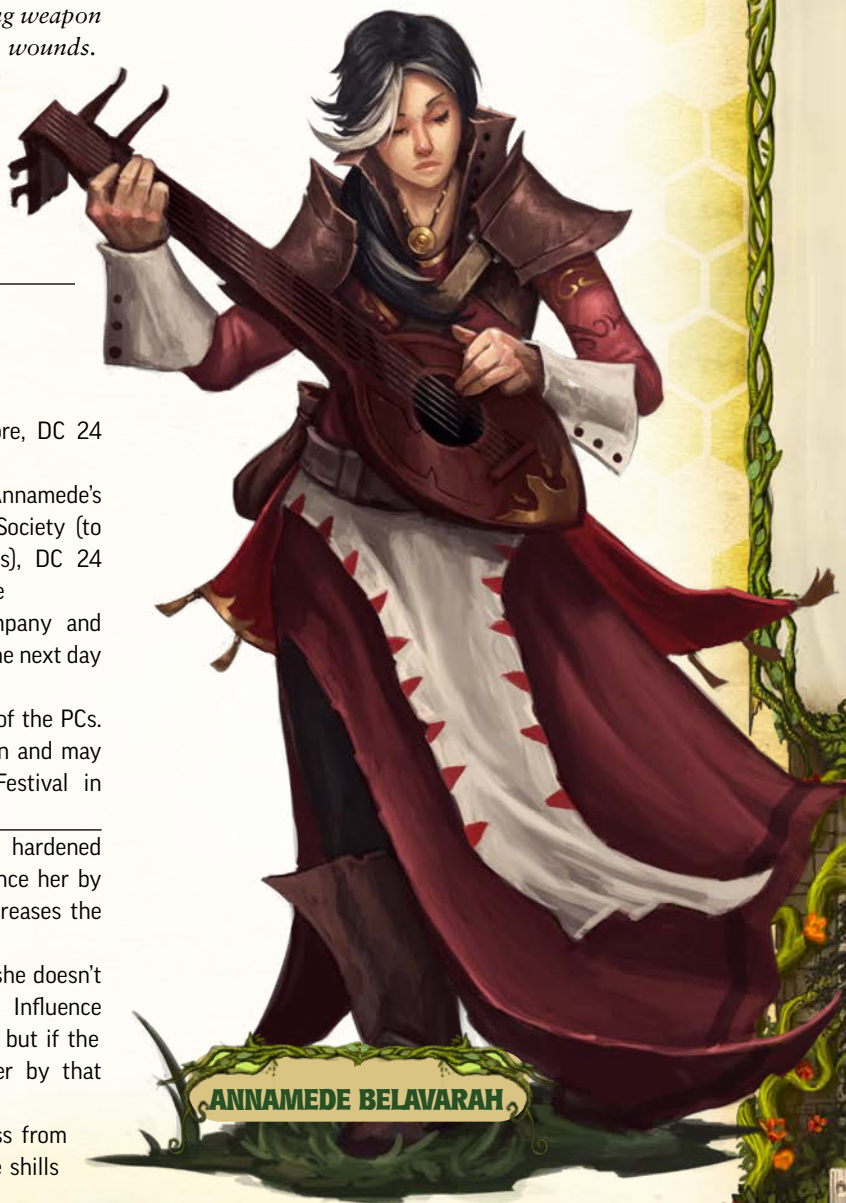
Resistances Years of living in Pitax have hardened Annamede to criticism. Attempting to Influence her by criticizing her performance or reputation increases the DC by 5.

Weakness Flattery is quite effective, provided she doesn't see through the attempt. An attempt to Influence Annamede via flattery reduces the DC by 5, but if the attempt fails, future attempts to flatter her by that character instead increase the DC by 2.

Background A popular pundit and songstress from Pitax, Annamede's few critics maintain that she shills for King Irovetti, possibly even to the extent that she's on his payroll. While it's true that her agenda at this hunt is to observe the "nobility" of both Varnhold and the PC's kingdom in hopes of getting material to bolster her sense of superiority, her first loyalty is to herself, not King Irovetti. Depending on how the PCs interact with her here, she may become an ally later in the campaign (as described in Chapter 8 on page 344).

Appearance Annamede is a beautiful Tian woman who dresses in elegant clothing that includes masterfully crafted leather armor. A striking blonde streak adorns the side of her black hair, and she's rarely found without her lute nearby. Annamede smiles sweetly but condescends with clever backhanded compliments.

Personality If the PCs win the hunt, Annamede is begrudgingly silent about their victory. If the PCs don't win,



ANNAMEDE BELAVARAH

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

she'll exaggerate the details of their incompetence and loudly wonder if their lack of martial skill is why criminals thrive in the River Kingdoms. Her suggestion for the hunting lodge's name is a snarky one—"The Pest Rest."

EDINA AND JOLIA ALDORI CREATURE 7

LN MEDIUM HUMAN HUMANOID

Female human fighters 7

Perception +17

Will +15

Discovery DC 23 Perception, DC 21 Brevoy Lore, DC 23 Society

Influence Skills DC 19 Athletics (to impress the Aldori sisters with your physique), DC 21 Society (to impress them with your comportment and upbringing), DC 23 Diplomacy, DC 25 Deception, DC 25 Intimidate

Influence 2: The Aldoris are impressed; if they're rescued by the party from the hydra attack the next day (area **A2**), they automatically cede that victory to them.

Influence 4: The Aldoris are impressed enough by the PCs that—assuming they survive the hunt—the sisters put in good words about them in their next communication to Restov. (This communication goes out before the Varnhold Vanishing in the next chapter.) As a result, at the start of the next Kingdom turn, the PCs gain 2 bonus Resource Dice and one additional point of Fame or Infamy (as appropriate).

Resistances The Aldoris have no patience for whimsy. If they consider a PC to be foolish or not taking the hunt seriously, increase the DC of that PC's Influence checks by 2. If the PC incorporates comedy or whimsy into the Influence check itself, instead increase the DC by 5.

Weakness The Aldoris are proud of their legacy and traditions, and if a PC demonstrates their own skill with an Aldori dueling sword or invokes their own connections to the Aldori family while attempting an Influence check, reduce the DC of that check by 2.



JAMAL VISSER

Background These sisters from Restov seek an increased reputation as hunters and warriors, and securing the heads of several monsters on this hunt should do just the trick. They're part of Maegar Varn's operation to the east, and if they win this hunt, they hope to use their fame and proceeds to secure additional funding from Restov to help expand Varnhold's reach.

Appearance Each has short dark hair, a rugged physique with plenty of scars, and a stern expression, yet both warm quickly to fellow adventurers and diplomats—provided they take their roles seriously. Neither sister has much of a sense of humor, and both are quick to assume punchlines they don't get are being made at their expense.

Personality Edina often chides her sister impatiently and encourages her to greater valor. To Jolia, though, discretion is the better part of valor; she maintains she is still dangerous with her swordplay but respects the high stakes of tangling with a monster the size of her family's summer home. Both Aldoris greet the PCs with respect and a friendly attitude. The sisters each have a similarly unimaginative suggestion for the hunting lodge's name: Edina prefers "Kamelands Lodge" while Jolia prefers "Gudrin Lodge."

JAMEL VISSER CREATURE 8

NG MEDIUM HUMAN HUMANOID

Male human ranger 8

Perception +16

Will +16

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Discovery DC 24 Perception, DC 20 Hunting Lore, DC 22 Survival

Influence Skills DC 18 Survival (to impress Jamel with your wilderness skills and knowledge), DC 20 Hunting Lore (to "talk shop" with Jamel), DC 22 Deception, DC 24 Diplomacy, DC 26 Intimidate

Influence 2: Jamel takes note of the PC as even more competent than he expected. His approval is noted by the others, so the DC of Influence checks made by the PC against anyone in this encounter is decreased by 1.

Influence 4: Jamel is impressed with the PCs and promises that the Embeth Travelers will support their kingdom. At the end of this chapter, he completes work on the hunting lodge and pledges fealty to the PCs. If this hex isn't already part of their kingdom, it is automatically claimed at that time. If it was already part of the kingdom, the Embeth Travelers instead provide additional resources, granting 2 bonus Resource Dice at the start of the next Kingdom turn. The completed tavern functions as a Refuge, and if the PCs build a settlement here, it grants that settlement a Popular Tavern structure on the Urban Grid.

Resistances Jamel became a hunter in part to escape the frustrations of politics and urban life. He has little patience for politics, and if he gets the impression that a PC is trying to angle for political gain or is using bureaucracy in an attempt to Influence him, increase the DC of that check by 2.

Weakness Boasts impress Jamel. If a PC manages to include a boast or brag about one of their previous successes, reduce the DC of that Influence check by 2. If the result is a failure, Jamel interprets the boast as a lie, and future attempts to boast by that PC instead increase the Influence DC by 2.

Background Jamel Visser is the host of the hunt and the leader of the Embeth Travelers, a group of rangers who regard themselves as the greatest hunters and guides in all of the River Kingdoms. Jamel cares little for regional politics but is concerned about the effect huge monsters have on trade and travel, with an emphasis on the safety of those helpless against a barrage of claws and teeth.

Appearance Jamel is a rugged man with a friendly demeanor—provided the topic doesn't get too bogged down in politics. He's never far from his longbow, and his studded leather armor looks well-worn.

Personality Jamel is proud of his accomplishment in building up the Embeth Travelers, and he is quite protective of them and their ability to freely travel the River Kingdoms. He hopes to impress the PCs and secure their friendship, or at the very least, assure his ability to continue hunting within the kingdom's borders. If no other suggestion pleases him, he's likely to settle on "Embeth Hall" as the name of the hunting lodge.

Reward: Grant the PCs 80 XP for this event.

THE HUNTING GROUNDS

The region the Embeth Travelers have identified as dangerous and infested with monsters—the hunting grounds—is located upriver from the lodge on the Gudrin River, at location **KL8**.

An hour before sunrise, the hunting party boards the Embeth Travelers' barge and heads upriver to the western edge of the hunting grounds. During the trip, Jamel lays out the rules for the competition: The Travelers know of three specific monsters in the region—a wyvern, a hydra, and a krooth—though they suspect there are other dangers. The groups have until noon the next day to return to the barge with proof of their kills—the three monsters the Travelers have targeted or others they haven't yet discovered—at which point the group that has secured the greatest success is declared the winner.

The journey is uneventful, and at midday, the barge anchors at a small island in the river. From this starting point at the south end of the hunting grounds, the group can see a ruined shack to the west (area **A1**), cliffsides to the northwest (areas **A3** and **A8**), a rise to the north that dips down into what may be an obscured hollow (area **A2**), and an escarpment on the river's eastern shore (area **A4**). Jamel tells the hunting party that the shack belonged to the family of Vath Locher—the local who was recently killed—and that the Travelers have not yet given it a good look over.

Annamede and her two bodyguards head east up the river. She has no intention of hunting and wants only to spend the time relaxing while she watches events play out in the valley below, lazily gathering information about the PCs and the others (area **A4**).

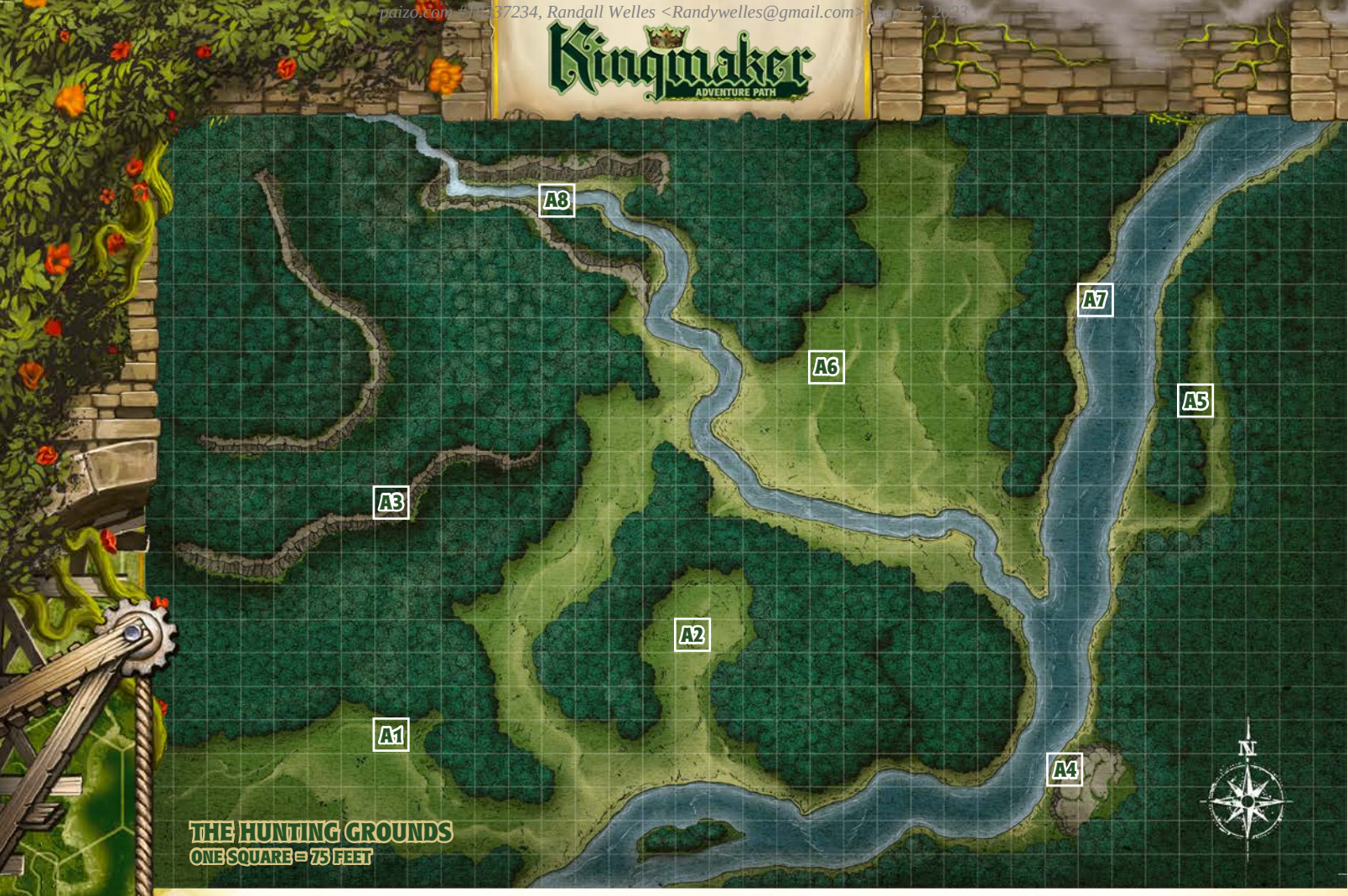
The Aldori sisters head directly north. It's not long before they're in a fight for their lives (area **A2**).

The three rangers Jamel brought to represent the Embeth Travelers in the contest head upriver along the northern bank in search of the krooth (area **A7**). Jamel himself stays at the barge, which is a safe place for any hunter to rest or recover during the hunt.

The route the PCs take is left up to them, but if they attempt to accompany the Aldoris or the Embeth Travelers, the other hunters bristle and suggest the PCs "seek their own prey." Annamede welcomes company if the PCs have managed to gain at least 2 points of influence with her, but she makes clear to them her intent to not hunt and instead spend the day relaxing "on that lovely escarpment upriver." She isn't interested in helping the PCs hunt. If the PCs haven't managed to gain any influence with Annamede, she instead rebuffs them, observing that they should probably head north into the woods and bristly thickets, snidely observing that "You're all dressed for all of that filthy bushcraft nonsense, after all."

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



EXPLORING THE HUNTING GROUNDS

The hunting grounds have an unusually high density of monsters; this is the result of several creatures succumbing to the Bloom. A typical party can cover ground in this area relatively quickly, but the high density of dangerous monsters is likely to reduce PC resources faster, to the point they may need to rest for the night to recover resources and heal up. Since the monsters in the area are still adjusting to their new lives, they haven't yet come into direct conflict with each other. If the PCs choose to make camp within 300 feet (4 squares) of a monster lair, attempt a DC 6 flat check; if you succeed, that creature comes to investigate and attacks the camp at some point during the night.

After the PCs have spent 4 hours in the hunting grounds or have earned at least 2 Hunt points (Winning the Hunt, below), the PCs can attempt a DC 22 Nature or Survival or a DC 18 Hunting Lore check to Recall Knowledge. On a success, the character notes that the high concentration of apex predators in the area is not only unusual, it's unnatural—especially considering evidence that these monsters don't often travel far from their lairs to hunt. On a critical success, the PC also notes how unusually lush the vegetation is in the area, as if the plants were receiving some strange source of nutrient that bolstered their growth. If this information is noted, a successful DC 27 Nature or DC 22 First World Lore check confirms that this entire area seems to have been infused with life-giving energies from the First World, which may explain why the plants are so lush and the creatures seem to lack the compulsion to go out and hunt—this infusion seems to be providing the local flora and fauna with sustenance. Beyond this, the PCs must investigate the source of these effects at area **A8** to learn more.

WINNING THE HUNT

Each time the PCs slay a monster whose level is equal to or higher than the party's level, they earn one Hunt point. In a few encounters, the PCs can earn additional Hunt points by helping NPCs. To win the hunt, the PCs must earn a minimum of 3 Hunt points before the hunt ends the following noon.

A1. THE LOCHER RUINS

A wooden shack lies in smashed, bloodstained ruins near the edge of the woods.

Pioneers, hunters, and trappers have long attempted to harvest the resources of the Stolen Lands. The Lochers were a family of hunters who built a cabin

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

here to try to live off the land, only to be savaged by the wyvern during the recent uprising of monster activity. The eldest of the Locher siblings, Vath, escaped the attack on the shack, surviving only long enough to tell the Embeth Travelers about the monster. None of his siblings or parents survived; their corpses can be found in the wyvern's roost in area **A3**. The shack itself is now a ruin—PCs who Search the building find splashes of blood amid the devastation and claw marks on shattered timbers, but not much else. A PC who succeeds at a DC 22 Perception check discovers a trail of weeks-old blood splatters leading north through the woods. On a critical success, the PC notes that this blood seems to have rained down from above, as if a mortally wounded victim had been hauled away to the north by a flying creature. The blood trail leads up to the nook in the cliffside at area **A3** and can be Tracked with a successful DC 25 Survival check.

A2. HYDRA NEST — LOW 6

This forest clearing consists of a nearly two-hundred-foot-wide bowl-shaped hollow in the terrain, at the center of which sprawls a large, nest-like structure made of broken underbrush and saplings.

Creature: This nest is the lair of one of the dangerous monsters—an elite hydra with bright green and red stripes on its scales. The monster slithers up out of its nest with a series of roars to attack any intruders as soon as it notices them and fights to the death. This hydra is particularly hale and vigorous, and emerged from the body of an elk that became corrupted from the tainted water in the creek soon after the cult performed their ritual to the north. The elk's split remains can be found in the depths of the nest itself.

If the PCs immediately follow the Aldori sisters to this area at the start of the hunt, the hydra attacks them all. If the PCs visit within an hour of the start, they'll find the hydra already in combat with the Aldori sisters; the women have each taken 60 points of damage while the hydra has taken only 10 points, thanks to its regeneration. Otherwise, the PCs find the hydra in the nest with the sisters' savaged bodies and ruined gear; their gear can be scavenged, but the hydra has already healed its wounds.

ELITE HYDRA — CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 6, 210
Initiative Perception +17

EDINA AND JOLIA ALDORI — CREATURE 7

Female hunters (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 219)
Initiative Perception +17

Items *+1 Aldori dueling sword*, composite longbow (20 arrows), leather armor
Melee ❖ *Aldori dueling sword* +18 (finesse, versatile P), **Damage** 1d8+9 slashing

Reward: If both Aldori sisters survive, they'll thank the PCs for their help but argue that they had the situation under control and should get credit for the kill. Convincing the sisters that the PCs deserve credit requires a successful DC 25 Diplomacy check to Request or Intimidation check to Coerce. Alternately, if the PCs gained at least 2 points of Influence with the sisters the night before, the pair is much more thankful and cede the victory to the PCs automatically. If only one sister survives, the mourning survivor abandons the hunt to return to Varnhold, defaulting the win to the PCs.

If both sisters survive this encounter, grant the PCs an additional 30 XP.

TAINTED WATERS

The nameless creek that runs from area **A8** to the Gudrin River is still somewhat tainted with the influence of the *monstrous bloom* the Cult of the Bloom performed in area **A8**, but it is no longer concentrated enough to cause those who drink from it to become cursed. A person who drinks from this water becomes immediately satiated and doesn't need to eat or drink for the next 24 hours, but they must succeed at a DC 25 Fortitude save to avoid becoming sickened 3. The water radiates faint conjuration magic, and its effects can be learned with a DC 22 check made to Identify Magic (a success using Nature on this check reveals that the source of the magic may be from the First World). In another few weeks, this effect will fade entirely, and surviving creatures in the region will need to hunt for their food.

A3. WYVERN ROOST — MODERATE 6

A jagged escarpment of stone scars the forest here. A narrow cleft splits the escarpment in the middle, forming a short cave-like overhang under which several mangled corpses are strewn. A larger corpse of some unidentifiable animal lies near the back of the cave, partly obscured by a carpet of brightly colored plants and wildflowers.

The bodies that lie strewn in this lair are the remains of the Locher family. A successful DC 15 Nature check to Recall Knowledge made while surveying the carnage is all that's needed to note the disturbing irregularity that the bodies do not seem to have been eaten at all; they were merely mutilated and played with.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

An investigation of the larger corpse reveals it to be a bear's carcass that appears to have exploded from within. Succeeding at a DC 22 Nature check or a DC 17 First World Lore check to Recall Knowledge is enough to confirm that the rampant growth of plants and wildflowers on it is strange (given the lack of soil or direct sunlight), while a critical success reveals that the colorful plants are likely supernatural in nature, and possibly tied to influence from the First World.

Creature: The source of the carnage (and the Locher family's doom) is a particularly dangerous wyvern, a bulky green monster with a nest of spikes adorning its back. The wyvern burst from the body of the region's previous apex predator, a grizzly bear, after the bear fed on bloom-tainted elk. Alone among the monsters in the region, this wyvern has enough intellect to speak. It does so in roaring Draconic as it attacks, howling out single words like "meat," "die," or "mine," but doesn't really have anything of import to say. A character who can understand Draconic can attempt a DC 24 Arcana check to Recall Knowledge to note that while wyverns aren't the most intelligent of dragons, the way this particular wyvern speaks suggests something unusual in its history—along with the unusual coloration of its scales and spiky back.

BLOOM WYVERN CREATURE 8

UNIQUE | NE | LARGE | DRAGON

Variant wyvern (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 133)
Perception +16; darkvision, scent (imprecise) 30 feet
Languages Draconic
Skills Acrobatics +17, Athletics +18, Stealth +15
Str +6, **Dex** +3, **Con** +4, **Int** –2, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +0

AC 27; **Fort** +18, **Ref** +13, **Will** +16
HP 135; **Immunities** paralyzed, unconscious
Attack of Opportunity ↷
Savage ↷ As wyvern.

Speed 20 feet, fly 60 feet
Melee ❖ fangs +20 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 2d12+9 piercing
Melee ❖ claw +20, **Damage** 2d10+9 slashing plus Grab
Melee ❖ stinger +18 (agile, reach 10 feet), **Damage** 2d8+9 piercing plus wyvern venom
Powerful Dive ❖❖ (move) As wyvern.
Punishing Momentum ❖ As wyvern.
Wyvern Venom (poison) As wyvern, but DC 26 Fort save.



BLOOM WYVERN

A4. ANNAMEDE'S VACATION SEVERE 6

A large slab of granite looms above the placid waters of the Gudrin River below. The slab's upper surface is relatively flat, with a thirty-foot drop from the edge to the waters below.

Success on a DC 20 Athletics check to Climb allows a creature to clamber up the face of this escarpment, but it's simpler to reach the top by moving up the steep-but-navigable slopes to either side from the river's banks.

Creature: Annamede has no real interest in winning the hunt; she accepted the invitation primarily to watch and observe the region's newest settlers and to take some personal time to relax away from the city of Pitax. She has her two bodyguards erect a wooden frame for a hammock and a collapsible table within an arm's reach;

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

the latter is soon covered with fruits, cheeses, and wine. Annamede intends to spend the next 24 hours relaxing, making music and singing, writing her own highly fictionalized account of the hunt, and basking in the glory of nature while her guardians stand watch at a respectable distance.

Annamede has little interest in spending time with the PCs unless they impressed her the previous night by earning at least 2 points of Influence with her, in which case she invites them to join her in enjoying the wonders that nature has to offer—although the PCs will need to make do with sitting on the bare rock. At your option, the PCs can spend time here to further influence Annamede, but it should become obvious soon enough that she has no interest in taking part in the hunt.

If the PCs get a look at Annamede's notes, what they find depends on Annamede's view of them. If any PC manages to gain 4 Influence with her, their appearance in her writing is at least not unflattering, and at your option could even be positive—otherwise, the PCs are portrayed as backwater fools, uncouth vagrants, and barely better-than-bandits mercenaries.

If the PCs threaten or attack Annamede, she calls for her two bodyguards to protect her while she uses her magic to flee the region before heading back to Pitax; in this event, her interactions with the PCs during the Rushlight Festival will be even more pointed and hostile.

ANNAMEDE BELAVARAH CREATURE 8

UNIQUE CN MEDIUM HUMAN HUMANOID

Female human bard

Perception +16

Languages Common, Hallit, Sylvan, Tien

Skills Acrobatics +16, Deception +18, Diplomacy +16, Intimidation +18, Performance +19, Occultism +14, Society +16

Str +0, **Dex** +4, **Con** +2, **Int** +2, **Wis** +2, **Cha** +4

Items *+1 dagger*, leather armor, *lesser maestro's lute*, 12 gp

AC 26; **Fort** +14, **Ref** +18, **Will** +16

HP 120

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *dagger* +19 (agile, finesse, thrown 10 feet, versatile S); **Damage** 1d4+2 piercing

Occult Spontaneous Spells DC 26, attack +18; **4th** (3 slots) *dimension door*, *invisibility*, *suggestion*; **3rd** (3 slots) *dream message*, *enthrall*, *sound burst*; **2nd** (3 slots) *comprehend language*, *mirror image*, *telekinetic maneuver*; **1st** (3 slots) *command*, *floating disk*, *sanctuary*, *soothe*; **Cantrips (4th)** *dancing lights*, *daze*, *ghost sound*, *prestidigitation*, *shield*

Bard Composition Spells 2 Focus Points, DC 26; **3rd** *dirge of doom*; **1st** *counter performance*, *inspire courage*

ANNAMEDE'S GUARDS (2) CREATURE 4

Bounty hunters (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 227)

Initiative Perception +14

A5. GLAZULIN'S PACK MODERATE 6

This dry riverbed remains relatively free of overgrowth as it winds up into the woodlands on the river's eastern bank. Numerous bones lay strewn about the area, indicating that something carnivorous dwells nearby.

Creatures: Humanoids aren't the only hunters in the region. A powerful winter wolf named Glazulin and his pack of wargs have long prowled the reaches from the Gudrin's banks to the hills to the south and east. When the PCs enter this area, Glazulin quietly signals his packmates to fan out and surround the party. They move through the woods on the eastern perimeter of the encounter map. While they do this, their alpha attempts to distract the PCs with conversation, asking if the humanoids hunt only the larger monsters or his kind as well.

Glazulin's pack has lost a few wargs to the influx of the monsters that plague the countryside, so he prefers to avoid conflict if the party present themselves as competent hunters. If they parley, Glazulin's initial attitude is indifferent. He inquires whether the party has any information about the woman and her bodyguards at the camp south of them (he's referring to Annamede and her contingent)—he has no issue with hunters or monsters on the far side of the river, but Annamede's intrusion on "his side of the river" has his hackles up. Glazulin makes no secret of his intent to attack her camp this evening; if the PCs promise to not interfere, he offers to impart some knowledge regarding the rising population of monsters across the river.

If the party gains Glazulin's trust (either by agreeing to his deal or making a successful Request, Coercion, or Lie to gain his cooperation), he reveals to the PCs that the monsters on the other side of the river are new arrivals to the region. He describes watching an elk across the river explode into a blast of plants, then watched as a giant multi-headed snake crawled out of the mess and slithered into the woods nearby. Glazulin suspects the other monsters came from similar places and suggests the PCs stay on the lookout for "exploded corpses" as proof. The winter wolf doesn't know what's causing these events or why the monsters aren't expanding their territories, but he worries that his pack will need to relocate if the monsters grow more territorial.

Glazulin is sly and his voice drips with menace. Born far to the north, he abandoned his frozen homeland to seek a place in the south where he could lord over

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

"lesser wargs" and be respected as the alpha he always saw himself as. He's eager to negotiate an understanding with the party, but just as happy to eliminate them and feed his pack if it comes to it. If the party insults or threatens the winter wolf or his pack, he directs the others to attack. The pack maximizes use of their avenging bite and pack attack abilities in combat.

If the PCs leave Glazulin and his pack alone, the animals attack Annamede's group that evening. The bard herself manages to escape, but her two guards are slain unless the PCs provide assistance. If the PCs get involved after promising not to interfere, the wargs are infuriated and focus their attacks on them.

GLAZULIN CREATURE 6

Elite winter wolf (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6, 322)
Initiative Perception +16

WARGS (4) CREATURE 2

Pathfinder Bestiary 322
Initiative Stealth +9

Reward: If the PCs learn about the regional dangers from the wargs, grant them 80 XP.

A6. NERVOUS ELK MODERATE 6

An expanse of grassland slopes gently upward here, its southern edge bounded by a slowly running creek.

Creatures: A herd of megaloceroses once dwelt here, but only four of these primeval elk now remain. Ironically, the presence of the dangerous monsters nearby has made the field here somewhat safe, since the monsters themselves are sustained (for now) by the life-giving energies that infuse them. These four megaloceroses are very protective of their field, so they lower their impressive antlers at anyone they spot crossing into this area.

Characters who can use magic like *speak with animals* are able to calm the megaloceroses and can learn much of the same information about the monsters in the area as can be learned from Glazulin. In addition, the megaloceroses can warn the PCs about the krooth lair (area **A7**) and the giant flytrap in the northern ravine (area **A8**).

MEGALOCEROSES (4) CREATURE 4

Page 608
Initiative Perception +10

Reward: If the PCs establish a way to communicate with these elk and learn about the regional dangers, grant them 80 XP.

A7. KROOTH MENACE MODERATE 6

There is no obvious indication that a dangerous monster dwells here along the western bank of the Gudrin River, but as the PCs pass through the area, success on a DC 25 Nature or Survival check or a DC 23 Hunting Lore check is enough for a character to note that what appears to be nothing more than a large tangle of dead brush gathered along the shore may actually be a creature's den.

Creature: This area is the lair of a single krooth—a monster recently emerged from the body of a megaloceros that drank from the creek to the southwest. Since this krooth doesn't travel back to drink from the tainted creek, it has grown hungry and spends most daylight hours hunting along the riverbanks upstream.

The three Embeth Travelers on the hunt discover this site early in the first day, recognize signs of the creature's lair, and hide nearby, intending to ambush the krooth when it returns. If the PCs arrive before sundown, the three hunters remain silent and watch—spotting them requires a successful DC 23 Perception check. If the PCs spot the hunters, or if they decide to settle in here to ambush the krooth as well, the hunters make themselves known and claim rights for this site. If the PCs persist in the area, the hunters grow increasingly frustrated but won't attack unless the PCs attack them first. Their initial attitude is indifferent—they'll also attack if the PCs manage to make them hostile. If the PCs can successfully Request or Coerce them, the hunters will cede this site to them and leave the area to seek out another foe.

At your option, the krooth could return during the middle of an argument with the rangers; otherwise, the monster returns at sundown to rest in its nest. If the PCs aren't here at this time and the Embeth Travelers are still waiting in ambush, they'll slay the krooth after a pitched battle.

KROOTH CREATURE 8

Pathfinder Bestiary 215
Initiative Perception +16

EMBETH TRAVELERS (3) CREATURE 6

Monster hunters (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 227)
Initiative Stealth +13

A8. THE SOURCE SEVERE 6

A steep crevasse cut into the earth forms a narrow valley lined with rough stone. The bottom of the ravine lies twenty feet below the clifftops to the north and south, with the eastern side opening to a steep decline. A cascading waterfall at the west end is the source of a creek running through the ravine. On the shores, swaths of strange-

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

looking dead plants bear dozens of rotting, withered fruits the size of watermelons.

Climbing the rock walls here requires success on a DC 25 Athletics check. The strange dead plants growing along the banks of the creek here defy casual attempts to identify them, and the stink rising from the decaying fruits they once bore requires any PC who approaches within 10 feet of the river bank to attempt a DC 20 Fortitude save to avoid being sickened 1; once exposed to the smell, a character is temporarily immune to this effect for 1 hour.

A character who takes 10 minutes to examine the dead plants can attempt a DC 24 Nature check or a DC 22 First World Lore check to Recall Knowledge. Even on a failure, the PC notes that the strange plants seem to be completely unlike anything that should be growing in the region. On a success, the PC confirms the plants are alien and probably magical in nature, likely vegetation that has been influenced by or even potentially transplanted from the First World, but the plants are too far decayed to be of much use to determine whatever qualities they may have had while they were living. On a critical success, the character notes that there's more than First World influence here—there's an element of Abyssal taint as well.

Success on a DC 25 Perception check attempted while Searching the area uncovers a swath of ground near the densest patch of these plants where it appears that several humanoids gathered in a circle several weeks ago. Once this area is noted, success on a DC 25 Arcana, Nature, Occultism, or Religion check confirms that this seems to have been the epicenter of a magical ritual performed here within the last month; a critical success confirms it was a Divine ritual, but not enough evidence remains to reveal more.

Creature: Before the PCs can fully investigate this area, they'll need to deal with one surviving plant that, while suffering from the aftereffects of the *monstrous bloom* ritual, is still quite dangerous. This giant flytrap looms at the northern bank of the creek in the middle of this cleft in the land, its leaves withered and browned and its roots tangled and diseased. In a few more weeks, the giant flytrap will perish from the influence of the ritual, but for now it remains dangerous and ravenous; it attacks as soon as anyone approaches within the 60 foot range of its tremorsense, or as soon as it's damaged from ranged attacks. It fights to the death but does not pursue victims from this region—the same fell influence that is slowly killing it ironically compels the plant to remain in close proximity to the source of the magic.

WEAK GIANT FLYTRAP **CREATURE 9**

Pathfinder Bestiary 6, 160

Initiative Perception +15

FINISHING THE HUNT

At noon, the day after the hunt begins, the event draws to a close. The surviving hunters return to Jamel's barge on the river island at the southern edge of the hunting grounds to compare stories and trophies. If any hunters fail to return, Jamel recruits the PCs to help him look for them for a few hours before heading back.

In order to win the hunt, the PCs must have accumulated 3 Hunt points—slaying the hydra, the wyvern, and the krooth are enough to win, for example, with Glazulin the winter wolf and the weakened giant flytrap being other opportunities for bonus points. If the PCs failed to achieve 3 Hunt points, the Embeth Travelers win the competition. The Aldori sisters, at best, manage only the hydra (and may well have died), while Annamede never bothered trying to win at all.

Jamel invites the hunters to return to the Travelers' lodge for another feast celebrating the hunters' accomplishments (and mourning their losses, if any), where he'll present the promised reward to the winning team (see page 219 for details of the reward). The barge makes it back to the lodge just at sunset, with most of the hunters ravenous for a meal and eager for a good night's rest in comfortable beds.



paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



PART 2:
FULL BLOOM

In Part 1 of this chapter, the PCs got their first exposure to the monstrous curse the Cult of the Bloom seeks to spread through the kingdom. In this part, the PCs encounter the bloom in all of its awful glory, then investigate these strange and frightening occurrences, do their best to keep an increasingly frightened populace comforted and protected, and eventually track down the cult's headquarters to confront them in Part 3.

BACK TO THE LODGE

Once the PCs return to the lodge after the hunt, Jamel Visser and his rangers offer to prepare a meal from one of the cleaner beasts killed during the day (preferably the krooth). The lodge staff prepares side dishes, sets the table, and makes up the attendees' rooms; as before, Timol makes sure the guests' needs are satisfied.

The PCs can rest, socialize, or even try get in one more attempt to Influence other hunters while the meal is being prepared. The topic of some sort of supernatural influence over the monsters is unlikely to be brought up unless the PCs do so themselves, at which point the other hunters, who hadn't noticed much amiss, are a combination of incredulous, intrigued, and worried.

TIMOL'S DOOM — SEVERE 6

As the meal wraps up, Visser awards the contents of the coffer he displayed earlier to the faction with the most successful hunt—the PCs if they achieved 3 Hunt points, or the Embeth Travelers otherwise.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

Jamel thanks all the hunters for participating and announces the new name of the hunting lodge he's decided on—this should be a PC's suggestion of your choice—but before the group can offer much in the way of congratulations to the winning suggestion, something horrific occurs.

Creature: A sudden howl and scream interrupts the proceedings as Timol suddenly doubles over in pain, clutching at his stomach before tearing his shirt open to reveal protrusions moving under his skin. His ribs separate unevenly, as if something is forcing them apart from the inside. With a wild-eyed look of pain, Timol suddenly screams before exploding into a mass of coiling plants, vines, and vibrant wildflowers. From the midst of this sudden burst of verdant material crawls a hissing, eight-legged creature—a basilisk!

Timol has become the latest victim of the Cult of the Bloom, having inadvertently exposed himself to the curse several days ago by feasting on rabbits and drinking water from another infected stream similar to the one in the hunting grounds during his journey to the lodge to join its staff. When he ate some of the beast cooked for this feast, the curse took hold and used his body and his life to pull a powerful basilisk from the First World, infused it with Abyssal energies, and burst it forth into the midst of the lodge's dining hall.

The freshly bloomed basilisk is a deadly threat to the entire group, so the surviving hunters all leap to join the battle as well. The monster acts on a purely instinctual basis fueled by the evil of the ritual that created it; it attacks immediately and fights to the death.

FRESHLY BLOOMED BASILISK CREATURE 9

UNIQUE | CE | MEDIUM | BEAST

Perception +18, darkvision
Skills Athletics +19, Stealth +18
Str +6, **Dex** +1, **Con** +6, **Int** –3, **Wis** +3, **Cha** +2

AC 26; **Fort** +21, **Ref** +14, **Will** +18
HP 188

Petrifying Glance ↷ (arcane, aura, transmutation, visual) As basilisk, but DC 25 Fortitude save.

Speed 20 feet
Melee ❖ jaws +21, **Damage** 2d12+9 piercing
Petrifying Gaze ❖❖ (arcane, concentration, incapacitation, transmutation, visual) As basilisk, but DC 27 Fortitude save.

Aftermath: Once the basilisk is defeated, the hunters, lodge staff, and likely the PCs are shocked and concerned about what could have caused this unexpected event.

Jamal Visser puts on hold his plans to build the lodge into a way station for travelers, making clear his intent to use the Embeth Travelers to investigate the cause of Timol's unnatural demise—and he strongly suggests the PCs do the same. Annamede and the Aldori sisters depart for their own homes.

The remainder of this chapter focuses on the PCs' investigation into the mystery, which can start here in the lodge's dining hall, then proceeds into the wilds of the Stolen Lands and, potentially, into the heart of the PCs' kingdom.

Once the PCs do move on, no specific additional role exists for the lodge itself in the *Kingmaker Adventure Path*, but that doesn't mean it should fade from your game entirely. It can continue to serve as a base of operations for the PCs as long as they wish.

INVESTIGATING THE BLOOM

Throughout this chapter, the Cult of the Bloom continues to escalate their plans. They've performed *monstrous bloom* rituals in numerous locations throughout the Stolen Lands, and their focus now shifts toward "curation" of their victims. Whereas the primary victims of the bloom have so far been wild animals, the curse is beginning to afflict humanoids with alarming frequency. The fate of poor Timol serves as a sudden warning to the PCs about the danger facing their kingdom.

In order to defeat the cult, the PCs must learn not only the location of their hideout in the foothills of the Tors of Levenies, but also the nature of the curse itself. While the PCs may fear that they are themselves in danger of succumbing to the curse, the way this chapter is presented leaves it entirely in the GM's hands who does and doesn't succumb. Season of Bloom assumes the PCs are never truly in danger of becoming infected by this affliction, but the players themselves shouldn't know this.

The best place to learn more of the cult and their secrets is the small, remote goblin village of Greengripe, a stockade settlement that has recently fallen under the cult's control. The cultists hope to use Greengripe as a sort of smoke screen, so that when the heroes of the land inevitably seek to stop it, they'll mistake the source of the cult as coming from the goblins rather than the actual perpetrators. What the cultists don't count on is the Greengripe goblins' potential willingness to ask the PCs for help—that is, once the characters follow up on the clues the cult left, which lead them to the goblins in the first place.

In order to learn more about the curse and its source—and eventually determine the best way to defeat it—the PCs must research clues, investigate rumors, and examine evidence using the research rules as presented on pages 154–155 of the *Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide*. Rather than performing this research in a single library, though, these investigations

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

take place throughout the PCs' kingdom and the surrounding Stolen Lands. And rather than having different divisions in a library to perform this research, the PCs must physically travel to one of several research sites where clues can be found.

Since much of this part of the chapter plays out over downtime and exploration mode, time will pass more quickly than it did in Part 1 of "Cult of the Bloom," and it's likely that the PCs will have at least one or more Kingdom turns during this part. Each time a Kingdom turn takes place during this part, a new Monster Activity continuous event automatically begins during the turn's Event phase (in addition to any other events—random or otherwise—that would otherwise occur). If the PCs don't handle the Cult of the Bloom soon, each following month brings a new automatic Monster Activity event to the Kingdom turn, which can quickly spiral out of control as the curse spreads.



BLOOM CULTIST

DISCOVERING A RESEARCH SITE

There are several research sites the PCs can learn about in their quest to discover more about the Cult of the Bloom. At the start of Part 2, the PCs already know of two research sites: the hunting grounds and the lodge where Timol met his fate. As they perform research at these sites, and as more bloom-related events occur, additional research sites open up for the PCs to investigate.

Researching at a site takes a day of work spent between on-site investigations, ruminating on the evidence, and supporting actions such as interviewing locals, consulting texts, praying for guidance, comparing theories, and so on.

CULT OF THE BLOOM — INVESTIGATION 6

DIVINE | FIEND | PRIMAL

Hunter's Lodge The PCs investigate Timol's remains and the body of the slain basilisk that bloomed from his body (page 228); **Maximum RP** 5

Research Checks DC 20 Medicine, DC 22 Nature, DC 24 Perception

Hunting Grounds The PCs further investigate strange corpses, the remnants of strange plants at the ritual site, and the fading taint in the nameless creek (page 223); **Maximum RP** 10

Research Checks DC 20 Hunting Lore, DC 22 Nature, DC 24 Survival

Attack Site Whenever a Too Close to Home or Urban Outbreak event occurs (page 232), a new Attack Site becomes available to research in the hex or settlement where the monster attack took place; **Maximum RP** 5

Research Checks DC 20 Medicine, DC 22 Nature, DC 24 Survival, DC 26 Perception

Cult Site Whenever a Cult Activity event occurs during this chapter and the PCs manage to locate the cult headquarters, a new Cult Site becomes available to research in the settlement where the cult activity took place; **Maximum RP** 10

Research Checks DC 20 First World Lore or Abyss Lore, DC 22 Religion, DC 24 Occultism

Library If the PCs have an Academy or a Library in any of their settlements, they can use that building to research the Cult; **Maximum RP** 10 per Academy or Library

Research Checks DC 20 Religion, DC 22 First World Lore or Abyss Lore, DC 24 Occultism, DC 26 Perception

5 Research Points The PCs confirm that more individuals have been bursting into masses of colorful, strange vegetation that unleashes a single ill-tempered and powerful monster. These monsters don't seem to be driven to violence out of an instinctual need to eat, but instead

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

from a deeper, more sinister urge to cause pain. The PCs hear initial rumors that a cult is responsible for spreading the affliction through the region.

10 Research Points The source of the affliction seems to be a sinister curse associated with conjuration magic. The victims don't transform into these monsters—it's more like their bodies are transformed into some sort of strange portal through which the creature is created. It seems that any living creature may be subject to this curse, but the method of its spread is unknown at this time. Rumors about a cult being responsible are now widespread; this cult is said to be based primarily in the wilderness, and it's trying to return the Stolen Lands to the rule of monsters.

15 Research Points Those who suffer the curse show no symptoms until near the end, when crippling pain ripples through their entire body. The type of creature that emerges from a victim's body is unpredictable. It may be possible to save someone from the curse if the affliction can be detected before it runs its course, but doing so is difficult given the widespread nature of the curse. While a wide range of people are supposedly joining the cult, most of the rumors suggest the original cultists were goblins.

20 Research Points Armed with their knowledge from previous research, the PCs confirm that the bodies spawning the strange plant growth and monsters also have tiny, difficult-to-spot black seeds embedded along their throats, esophagi, and stomach linings. These seeds seem to be mostly inert, but evidence suggests that it takes only one active seed to trigger the effect. The knowledge that the affliction is gained via ingestion is a breakthrough, and if the PCs make this knowledge available to the public, the kingdom's citizens become more watchful of the food and water they take. At the same time, the PCs discover more evidence implicating goblin cultists said to keep a hideout somewhere in the Sellen Hills.

25 Research Points The PCs confirm that when the curse is triggered, it transforms the victim's body from the inside out into a portal to the First World that draws in a dangerous monster, but that the process infuses the monster with Abyssal energies as well. The combination of these planar energies from two particularly fecund planes is key to the curse's power, but the element of chaos also present in the curse makes it, fortunately, unreliable. Most of those who become infected by the seeds never know it, but the number of so-called "blooms" is growing. The PCs also learn the location of the goblin village of Greengripe in the Sellen Hills, with evidence suggesting it may be the genesis of the curse. If that's the case, it's quite likely that a method of undoing or neutralizing the curse entirely could be found there.

30 Research Points The fact that this affliction seems to manifest so sporadically suggests that the cult spreading it hasn't yet managed to fully integrate it into the region. It may be but a matter of time before every cursed seed that pollutes the region's food and water supplies will transform those who ingest them! PCs who reach this research threshold also start to see deeper hints that the actual cult, known to them now (if they haven't learned already) as the Cult of the Bloom, may be using the goblins of Greengripe as a scapegoat. Finally, the PCs' research confirms that if they could find the site where the Cult first created this affliction, they could neutralize its effects in one fell swoop throughout the Stolen Lands.

35 Research Points The PCs confirm that the Cult of the Bloom are worshipers of Lamashtu, and that while the goblins of Greengripe also worship the Mother of Monsters, their faith is very different than that pursued by the Cult. The goblins of Greengripe are certainly patsies for the cult, but there may be additional clues about the cult to be found there nonetheless. It's very unlikely that the curse's source is located in Greengripe.

40 Research Points The Cult of the Bloom is using the goblins of Greengripe as a distraction. They've managed to keep the actual location of their headquarters very well hidden, but the PCs who reach this research threshold find strong evidence that the cult has a hidden agent among the goblins in Greengripe who is likely to know more about the cult's true hideout. Finally, the PCs confirm that the curse's source has been hidden in the true hideout.

50 Research Points After studying enough clues, the PCs have narrowed down the most likely location of the cult's base of operations: It's somewhere in the foothills of the Tors of Levenies, directly south of the Little Sellen River. At this point, the PCs have exhausted their research; to discover anything more, they'll have to either investigate Greengripe in person or discover the true cult headquarters on their own.

THE CULT SPREADS

At the end of each day that the PCs spend performing research, attempt a DC 20 flat check. On a success, a bloom-related event takes place somewhere in their kingdom—resolve this event at once as if it were a standard Kingdom event (see Appendix 2 on page 553), rather than waiting until the end of the net Kingdom turn to do so. On a failure, the DC for this flat check is reduced by 2. Once a bloom-themed Kingdom event occurs, the base DC for another one occurring resets to 20. You can choose which event occurs or roll on the Random Cult Events table. The Cult Activity event is detailed on page 556, while the other events are unique to this chapter and are detailed below.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

The first time one of these Cult events occurs, the PCs earn 80 Kingdom XP regardless of how successful the kingdom was in dealing with the event; they do not earn additional Kingdom XP for repeated events.

RANDOM CULT EVENTS

d10	Result
1–3	Cult Activity
4–6	Public Outburst
7–9	Too Close To Home
10	Urban Outburst

CULT ACTIVITY — EVENT +1

See page 556 in Appendix 2.

PUBLIC OUTBURST — EVENT +0

DANGEROUS

Event The citizens of the kingdom grow particularly nervous and fearful about the spread of monster attacks, with more reports of monsters bursting out of random victims. Each time this event occurs, increase the event's level modifier by 1 to a maximum of +2, at which point the curse has become the populace's greatest fear. The PCs must work to calm the nation and convince the people that they are doing everything they can to stop this supernatural affliction.

Kingdom Skill Politics; **Leader** Ruler

Critical Success The citizens are comforted by promises. This occurrence of Public Outburst does not increase the level modifier of the next occurrence.

Success The citizens are somewhat comforted, and you prevent Unrest from rising.

Failure Rumors that the affliction might be beyond the party's capability to stop make it difficult to quell fear. Increase Unrest by 1.

Critical Failure As failure, but the rumors spread more quickly and have kernels of truth to them. Increase Unrest by 1d4, and at the end of the next day, a Cult event automatically happens.

TOO CLOSE TO HOME — EVENT +1

DANGEROUS | HEX

Location A hex of the GM's choosing within the influence of the settlement that's closest to the PCs' current location.

Event A monster blooms from a citizen and begins to rampage the area. The type of monster should be chosen by the GM; its level should equal the party's level + 1 (a Low threat encounter). The PCs can choose to resolve this event with a Kingdom skill check, or they can travel to the hex the monster is rampaging in to challenge it in encounter mode. If they don't defeat the monster by the end of the next day, treat this event as having a Critical Failure result.

Kingdom Skill Defense; **Leader** Warden

Critical Success The monster is defeated before any more lives are lost.

Success The monster is defeated but may have slain some citizens. Attempt a DC 11 flat check. On a failure, a few locals were slain; increase Unrest by 1.

Failure The monster slays several citizens before it is defeated. Increase Unrest by 1.

Critical Failure The monster continues to rampage unopposed. This event becomes Continuous and occurs every day until the monster is defeated; additional Cult events still occur as normal. Increase Unrest by 1d4 and Decay by 1.

URBAN OUTBREAK — EVENT +2

DANGEROUS | SETTLEMENT

Location The settlement the PCs are currently located in, or the closest settlement to the PCs' location if they're not in a settlement.

Event A monster blooms from a citizen in the city itself and runs rampage through the streets! The type of monster should be chosen by the GM; its level should equal the party's level + 2 (a Moderate threat encounter). The PCs can choose to resolve this event with a Kingdom skill check, or they can travel to the settlement the monster is rampaging in to challenge it in encounter mode. If they don't defeat the monster by the end of the next day, treat this event as having a Critical Failure result.

Kingdom Skill Defense; **Leader** Warden

Critical Success The monster is defeated before any more lives are lost.

Success The monster is defeated but slew a citizen. Increase Unrest by 1.

Failure The monster slays several citizens before it is defeated. Increase Unrest by 1d4 and Decay by 1.

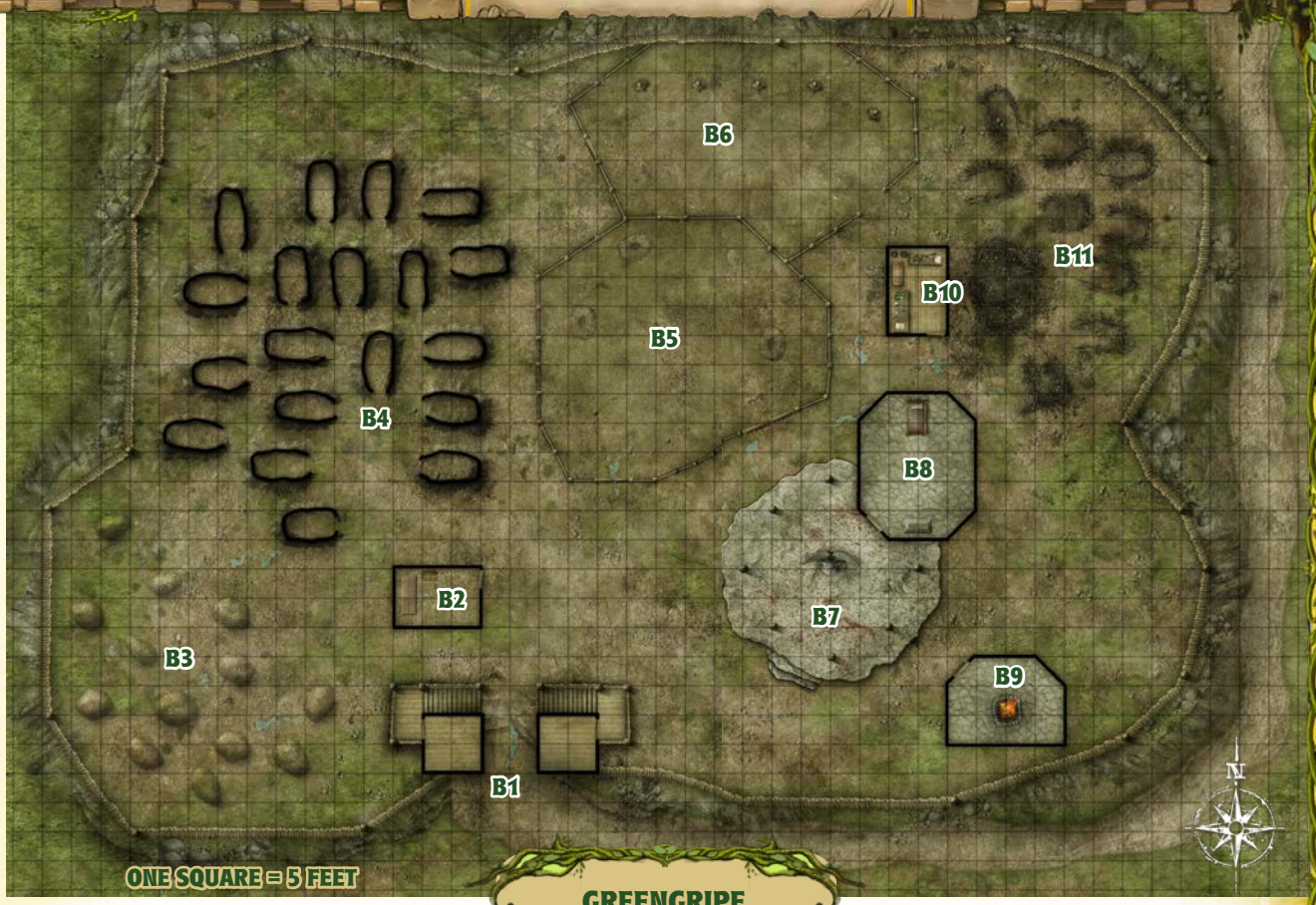
Critical Failure The monster continues to rampage unopposed. This event becomes Continuous and occurs every day until the monster is defeated; additional Cult events still occur as normal. Increase Unrest by 1d6 and Decay by 2.

GREENGRIPE

The goblin village of Greengripe (encounter site **SH5**) has been quietly thriving in the Sellen Hills for several years. Their chosen home, situated atop a narrow mesa and surrounded by a solid wooden palisade, is inconveniently far from trade routes or villages (or at least, it had been until the PCs' kingdom began to expand). More by accident than intent, this isolation has caused the Greengripe goblins to avoid antagonistic activities and pursue lives of self-sufficiency. They get all the water they need from a creek about a hundred feet north of the mesa that eventually flows into the Little Sellen River, and they learned to supplement their diet of local goats and deer with what was once

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



GREENGRIPE

a relatively robust pickling operation overseen by Greengripe's lead alchemist.

Unfortunately for the goblins, the Cult of the Bloom's manipulation of Greengripe has increasingly forced them into a desperate situation. Darivan, the leader of the Cult of the Bloom, knew that it would take time before the repetition of the *monstrous bloom* rituals would reach a point where the curse's effects would cascade out of control. Until then, there would be a delicate phase where the PCs could potentially step in and halt the process before it could reach the tipping point. He chose the goblins of Greengripe as his smokescreen, laying clues that he hoped would distract the heroes into thinking that defeating the goblins would bring an end to the curse, when in fact that false sense of accomplishment would merely afford the curse the final few weeks or days it needed to reach full spread throughout the Stolen Lands.

In addition to laying clues throughout the region to lead the PCs to suspect Greengripe (the PCs uncover these clues at the lower thresholds of their research into the Cult of the Bloom), Darivan sent one of the Bloom's own cultists to infiltrate Greengripe and replace its current religious leader. This replacement is a doppelganger priest of Lamashtu named Virthad, who murdered Greengripe's previous priest Muglund and replaced him. Since then, Virthad has been using their influence to manipulate the goblins' behavior so that when the heroes do inevitably come, they'll find the goblins acting in a very suspicious manner indeed.

There are two things, though, that Darivan and Virthad didn't count on. First, the fact that the PCs have already likely encountered this tactic before with Tartuccio's invasion of the Sootscale kobolds is likely to make them more able to notice tactics to manipulate a society (see the We've Seen This Before sidebar on page 237 for more details). Second, the goblins of Greengripe are cannier than the cult expected, and rather than react immediately with violence to the PCs' arrival, the goblins may well see them as saviors and recruit their help.

APPROACHING GREENGRIPE

Greengripe is located about two day's travel to the south of the Embeth Travelers' hunting lodge. There are no obvious paths or trails to the goblin village, but once the PCs approach area **SH5**, the hilltop palisade is difficult to miss. Within several hundred feet of the village, a trail up to Greengripe becomes apparent, beaten into the earth by the passage of countless goblin feet as they travel out of the village to hunt or scrounge for food. Virthad has let the goblins know

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

GREENGRIPE ENRAGED

While it's not the intent of this encounter, the PCs could decide to use violence against the goblins of Greengripe. In all, there are 19 goblin warriors and 1 goblin war chanter living in Greengripe, and if the PCs start a fight, the goblins bravely gather together to protect their village. When the attack begins, the war chanter is at area **B9**, 2d4 warriors are at area **B4**, 2d4 warriors are at area **B6**, 2 warriors are at **B1**, 1 warrior is at **B5**, and any other goblins are out hunting or foraging. The goblins' morale breaks once at least 10 goblins are slain, at which point the survivors abandon the village and flee into the wilds, never to return. At some point during the fight, the true danger in Greengripe—the doppelganger Virthad—abandons the site and stealthily makes their way back to the cult's hidden headquarters, expecting that the PCs will leave Greengripe believing (incorrectly) that they've stopped the curse. See *Pathfinder Bestiary* pages 180–181 for goblin statistics.

that "longshank bandits" are likely coming for the village soon, so the goblins are on high alert as the PCs approach, yet they are not eager to start a fight.

The majority of Greengripe's goblins are very low level, and even in large groups, they're likely to be a trivial encounter at best for a 6th-level party. Certainly a clash with Virthad will challenge 6th-level PCs, but until that confrontation occurs, Greengripe should offer the PCs a combination of levity and potential answers to the true nature of the Cult of the Bloom; it's meant more to be a site of awkward investigation than simple combat. If the PCs do attack the goblins (and thus play right into the Cult's plans), all the village's inhabitants marshal to the cause to defend their home, taking the PCs' aggression as proof that their leader "Muglund" was right about them.

Greengripe itself is completely surrounded by a wooden wall constructed of timbers, branches, logs, and stumps. It's ten feet tall and can be scaled by succeeding at a DC 20 Athletics check to Climb.

Unless the PCs make an effort at stealth, any approach to the village results in them being spotted by a pair of goblin guards; this adventure assumes that the PCs are spotted at the village gate (area **B1**). Once the goblins notice the PCs, proceed with the Wary Guards encounter (page 236).

B1. VILLAGE GATE

The main entrance to Greengripe consists of a ramshackle gate made of lashed-together branches and twigs bound by lengths of thorny vine. Two wooden watchtowers have platforms about ten feet off the ground. A goblin warrior stands guard on each watchtower—see the Wary Guards encounter on page 236 for their reaction to the PCs. The gate itself is not actually attached to the watchtowers but is merely wedged in between the structures. Success on a DC 12 Athletics check to Force Open the gate wrenches it aside, or a character can take three Interact actions to wriggle it open (this is the option the goblins generally take to come and go from the village).

B2. PICKLE STORAGE

One of the four permanent structures in Greengripe is this solid stone building. Within sit several barrels of pickled vegetables—emergency food stores for the village. The door to the structure is solid and kept "locked" with ropes tied between its handle and a nearby iron piton driven into the wall. Success on a DC 15 Athletics check can Force Open the door; otherwise it takes three Interact actions to unlock the door. While the contents of this building are not particularly valuable, the goblins are very protective of their pickles, and if they notice the PCs attempting to gain entry, they'll confront them—see the Greengripe Enraged sidebar.

B3. CEMETERY

This region of the village is Greengripe's cemetery, consisting of dozens of low mounds of earth and stone where the goblins have traditionally buried their dead. The goblins haven't bothered to adorn these locations with gravestones or other markers. Succeeding at a DC 20 Perception or Survival check is all that's needed to note that more than half the mounds here are fresh; these graves house victims of the fire (area **B11**). Persistent local goblin rumors that burning ghosts haunt the cemetery are purely tall tales, but that doesn't keep the goblin citizens from keeping an eye out here in hopes of spotting a fiery spirit.

B4. GOBLIN HOMES

A large collection of tents once occupied the east and west sections of Greengripe, but after a recent devastating fire at area **B11**, this grouping of wood-framed tents covered in hides and furs now houses the bulk of Greengripe's 19 goblin warriors. At any given time, 2d4 goblin warriors can be found resting here.

B5. LIVESTOCK

The walls of this large pen consist of a relatively solid five-foot-high stick fence. The ground within is muddy. The goblins use this pen to keep animals they manage to capture alive for eventual use as food, but with fears of upcoming longshank attacks, the stock here has

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

grown thin: a single muddy goat wanders aimlessly in here now. A goblin warrior is always perched on one of the fence posts surrounding the pen. "Goat-watching" is a pretty important job since the doomed goat is the tribe's last reserve of fresh meat until the latest hunting party returns to the village. The goblins are eager to make sure the goat, who they've taken to calling "Tomorrowfood," remains in place.

B6. MARSHALLING GROUNDS

This fenced-in area has hard-packed dirt, with several movable combat dummies made of straw and sticks scattered around the place. The goblins use this area to practice warcraft, and at any one time, 2d4 goblin warriors can be found here, taking turns at hacking away or repairing the human-sized dummies.

B7. LAMASHTU'S ROCK

A forty-foot-wide slab of stone protrudes five feet from the ground here. The goblins set two smaller slabs of stone along its southern side to serve as steps up to its surface, and they have long used the slab as an open-air temple to their goddess, Lamashtu. Along the slab's edges stand seven tree trunks, each adorned with hides stripped from the bodies of Greengripe's greatest victories over "monsters" (several of these are horse hides, but there are also a few crocodile hides, two owlbear hides, and even a hide from a manticore slain several generations ago by one of Greengripe's founders). A ten-foot-tall stone statue of Lamashtu stands at the center of the rock; it has recently been adorned with a two-foot-high mound of earth surrounding its feet. Thick tangles of strange plants grow in this soil, their long creepers coiling up along the statue's frame to shroud the figure in green vines and strangely colored flowers. Success on a DC 25 Nature or DC 20 First World Lore check to Recall Knowledge confirms these strange vines are not natural to this world but are intrusions from the First World that bear many similarities to the plants that grow out of creatures that burst to release bloom monsters. This addition to the statue is recent, placed by Virthad while disguised as Muglund to help convince the goblins that Lamashtu dwells in the very plants of the world (and also to make it appear that Greengripe has links to the cult). The plants wrapping the statue are strange and unsettling but ultimately harmless.

B8. LAMASHTU'S SHRINE

The largest building in Greengripe sits on a dozen solid tree-trunk stilts so that its floor is at an even level with Lamashtu's Rock. The current occupant of this shrine is the doppelganger Virthad, disguised as the village's priest-chieftain Muglund. The building itself is relatively empty save for a bed, a personal altar, and a wooden chest in which Virthad has secured Greengripe's treasures; the doppelganger plans to return to the cult with this treasure as an offering to Lamashtu once Greengripe has outlived its usefulness. The chest isn't locked and contains 1 pp, 37 gp, 190 sp, 800 cp, and 30 gp in gems and jewelry. One of the pieces of jewelry is a *ring of the ram*. See the Confronting the Priest encounter on page 236 for further details.

B9. CRAFTSGOBLIN

This small stone building houses Greengripe's only remaining workshop (since the alchemy lab at area **B11** burned down). A lone goblin war chanter named Zangel lives and works here; while she isn't particularly skilled at crafting weapons, she's the best Greengripe has since its previous crafter perished in the fire. She spends her time cobbling together dogslicers, arrows, bows, and other weapons or tools needed by the village, and has only recently managed to catch up to the demand. Zangel harbors concerns that Muglund might have "gone rotten," and she has whispered her fears to a few other goblins. If the PCs manage to contact Zangel before the doppelganger confronts them, see the Confronting the Priest encounter on page 236.

B10. "GREENHOUSE"

Greengripe's previous alchemist perished in a tragic fire (area **B11**) that also burned down the laboratory. This structure, the newest building in Greengripe, was built by the goblins at "Muglund's" command, with a promise that a new alchemist would be chosen soon. Until then, the doppelganger has forbidden any goblin from entering this building. As a result, the goblins have taken to viewing the "replacement" alchemy lab with a mix of curiosity and frustration, with each day that passes without a local alchemist to look to for inspiration weighing heavy on goblin morale.

Within, Virthad has set up several alchemical stations and strange potted plants to make it appear that the goblins have been using this building to grow the strange plants responsible for the affliction ravaging the lands. Any PC who examines the laboratory here and succeeds at a DC 20 First World Lore or Crafting check to Recall Knowledge confirms that the equipment here seems to be focused on cultivating alien plant life, but there are no dangerous plants here at this time. As this is part of Virthad's deception, the PCs may gain a bonus on these checks to Recall Knowledge (We've Seen This Before, page 237). A critical success at this check reveals to the PCs that the gear kept here is, in fact, not what one would expect, and that the whole greenhouse seems to be staged.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

B11. BURNT BUILDINGS

Soon after Virthad infiltrated the goblin village, the doppelganger realized that the village's alchemist (and Greengripe's local pickling expert) had a canny mind and would likely see through their deceptions. So Virthad lit the alchemy lab on fire under the cover of night, using the fire to dispose of Muglund's body as well. The alchemist perished quickly, but the fire spread to several nearby goblin tents before it was contained. Ironically, Virthad's use of magic to help extinguish the flames helped cement their deception as Muglund. The superstitious goblins have avoided this part of the village since the fire out of fear that the alchemist's ghost might be haunting the area. If the PCs succeed at a DC 25 Perception check while searching the laboratory ruins, they'll find the partial skeleton of a goblin that still clutches a metallic object in its hand: a silver religious symbol of Lamashtu worth 2 gp. If the PCs discover this evidence, they'll have an easier time convincing the goblins of Greengripe to rise up against Virthad; see the Confronting the Priest encounter on below.



VIRTHAD

WARY GUARDS TRIVIAL 6

Creatures: When the PCs approach Greengripe, they're likely to be confronted by the two goblin warriors on guard duty at area **B1**. While all of Greengripe's goblins have been warned by their leader "Muglund" of the likelihood that violent longshanks will soon attack the village, the goblins themselves aren't automatically eager for a fight. They'll demand to know if the approaching characters are lost, warning that there's no place for them here. The goblins are initially unfriendly to the PCs; it requires success at a DC 18 Diplomacy check to Make an Impression on them. If there's at least one goblin character in the PCs' party, the DC for this check is reduced to 13.

If the PCs can manage to convince the guards that they mean no harm and want only to talk things over, they'll need to successfully Lie, Request, or Coerce the guards. On a success, the guards agree to let the PCs in to speak to their leader Muglund—continue with the Confronting the Priest encounter below. On a critical success, the guards let the PCs in and follow them but don't escort them directly to Virthad. In this case, every 10 minutes, attempt a DC 16 flat check; on a success, Virthad notices something strange is going on and steps out of the temple to investigate. Virthad automatically comes to investigate if a fight starts, if the PCs climb onto Lamashtu's Rock, or if they enter the shrine.

GOBLIN WARRIORS CREATURE -1

Pathfinder Bestiary 180

Initiative Perception +2

CONFRONTING THE PRIEST SEVERE 6

Eventually, the PCs' presence in Greengripe attracts Virthad's attention. Maintaining the disguise as Muglund—a goblin priest of Lamashtu armed with a dogslicer, wearing bloodstained green robes, and carrying a weirdly bulging cloth sack—Virthad accuses the PCs of plotting the destruction of Greengripe even as its goblins have done their best to live off the land and avoid confrontation. Virthad's hope is to simultaneously goad the PCs and the goblins to attack each other and then flee from the resulting battle.

If Virthad realizes that the PCs aren't interested in fighting—or worse, that they suspect something else is going on—the doppelganger accuses them of being unbelievers and says their bodies shall be fertilizer for Mother Lamashtu's glorious garden. Virthad attacks at once, starting by deploying the snapping flytraps against the PCs, hoping to defeat the party and therefore solve the cult's hero problem all at once.

Virthad won't reveal their true form in this battle, as they know that to do so would undo all their hard

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

work at deceiving the goblins and the PCs. Upon their death, though, Virthad reverts to their true form as a doppelganger, which shocks, frightens, and shames the goblins significantly. See Greengripe's Future below for the ramifications of this revelation.

VIRTHAD CREATURE 8

UNIQUE CE MEDIUM HUMANOID

Doppelganger priest of Lamashtu (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 103)
Perception +18; darkvision
Languages Abyssal, Common, Goblin
Skills Deception +18, Diplomacy +16, Nature +15, Religion +17, Society +15, Stealth +18
Str +4, **Dex** +4, **Con** +3, **Int** +3, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +4
Items +1 *striking dogslicer*, robes, sack of flytrap pods

AC 26; **Fort** +13, **Ref** +16, **Will** +18
HP 135
End the Charade ↻ (attack) As doppelganger.

Speed 25 feet
Melee ❖ *dogslicer* +19 (agile, backstabber, finesse, goblin); **Damage** 2d6+7 slashing
Arcane Innate Spells DC 23; **3rd** *mind reading* (at will)
Divine Prepared Spells DC 26, attack +18; **4th** *divine wrath*, *heal*, *fear*; **3rd** *blindness*, *dispel magic*, *sound burst*; **2nd** *ghoulish cravings*, *heal*, *silence*; **1st** *command*, *ray of enfeeblement*, *sanctuary*; **Cantrips (4th)** *daze*, *divine lance*, *message*, *read aura*, *shield*
Change Shape ❖ (arcane, concentrate, polymorph, transmutation) As doppelganger.
Deploy Flytraps ❖❖ (divine, manipulation, transmutation) **Requirements** Virthad is carrying a sack of prepared flytrap pods; **Effect** Virthad dumps the contents of the sack into two adjacent squares while invoking prayers to Lamashtu. The pods grow into two elite snapping flytraps that immediately attack any non-worshipper of Lamashtu they can detect.

ELITE SNAPPING FLYTRAPS (2) CREATURE 4

Pathfinder Bestiary 6, 160
Initiative Perception +9

GREENGRIPE'S FUTURE

The *Kingmaker Adventure Path* assumes that the PCs take a less violent route. If the PCs manage to save the goblins and successfully expose Virthad for the monster they truly are, the future of the goblin village of Greengripe lies very much in the PCs' hands.

In the unlikely event that Virthad is captured alive, the doppelganger's attitude is hostile, but they can be convinced to give up the cult's location if the PCs manage a critical success at Coercing them; magical solutions may work at your discretion. Virthad takes advantage of any opportunity to escape and return to the cult.

WE'VE SEEN THIS BEFORE!

If the PCs have handled the Sootscale problem and learned how Tartuccio deceived the kobolds by posing as a leader via shape-changing magic, they'll notice clues and similarities to the situation in Greengripe even if they aren't suspicious initially. Each PC gains a +2 circumstance bonus to checks made to see through deceptions and trickery put in place by the doppelganger Virthad; decrease the Perception DC by 2 when Virthad attempts to Lie to them.

If the PCs slaughter the goblins or scatter them to the wilds, it's likely that Virthad escapes the attack, in which case the PCs might find themselves at a dead end in tracking down the cult. It's possible to find Virthad's tracks and follow them all the way to the cult's actual hideout; doing so requires a success at a DC 20 Perception check made while Searching to notice the doppelganger's footprints leaving the village, at which point it's a DC 20 Survival check to Track them all the way southeast to the cult's lair in encounter site **SH8**. This DC increases to DC 30 if the PCs don't immediately start following the trail, and if they haven't started following the trail within a week, the prints can no longer be followed. If the PCs don't Claim the hex and rebuild it, the village falls into ruin in time; at your discretion, a more powerful monster might move in at a later date.

If Virthad is defeated, the goblins of Greengripe are thankful and their attitude becomes friendly to the PCs; they promise to work with them and help them in reward for saving them from the pretender. At this point, Greengripe's Negotiation DC drops from 25 to 15, and as such, the PCs will have a much easier time establishing diplomatic relations with the village (see Appendix 2 for details on Negotiation DCs and diplomatic relations). While the goblins are still shocked that a doppelganger infiltrated their village, they quickly rally to the cause and volunteer to scour the region for clues to help the PCs track down the cult's actual hideout; as a result, the PCs can track the doppelganger at once as detailed above without having to attempt the Perception check to find the footprints. The PCs can, of course, still discover the cult lair on their own (such as by tracking a fleeing Virthad, simply stumbling upon the cult site while exploring, or by achieving a threshold of 50 RP by researching the cult), but each day after the PCs' defeat of Virthad, attempt a DC 20 flat check; this DC drops by 3 each day that follows. On a success, the goblins discover the location of the cult's lair at area **SH8** and report their findings to the PCs as soon as they can.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



PART 3:

THE CRADLE OF LAMASHTU

In the weeks before Season of Bloom begins, the Cult of the Bloom claims a cave network in encounter site **SH8** in the foothills of the Tors of Levenies—if, in your game, the PCs have already explored and claimed the hex where the hideout is located, you can either have the cult remain where it is or relocate it to a hex that's still unclaimed. The Cult of the Bloom calls their cavern hideout the "Cradle of Lamashtu," and it was here that the cult leader Darivan created the *monstrous bloom* ritual.

Darivan didn't simply pick these caves at random—he was guided here by his visions for this was one of the few places that the first *monstrous bloom* ritual could even be attempted, due to the presence of a breach scar.

First World breach scars occur when the barriers between the Material Plane and the First World are worn thin by overuse of powerful conjuration magic, a malfunctioning portal between the two planes, magical "erosion" in the underlying structure of reality, a disruptive convergence of shifting ley lines, or another unusual magical effect. Despite the wide range of features that can cause breach scars, they remain incredibly rare events, and the fact that the First World itself works to heal these scars over time means that even when a breach scar does form, it almost never persists for more than a few years.

The breach scar in these caves is an exception to this rule, for before it could heal properly, it became "infected" by a taint from the Abyss when, several decades ago, a demonologist tried to capitalize on the fragility of reality to redirect the scar from the First World to the Abyss. The resulting backlash of magic

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

obliterated the demonologist, but it did infect the breach scar and make it such that it simply couldn't heal on its own.

Fortunately, the corrupted breach scar wasn't enough to allow unaided intrusions across the planes, and so for years it simply festered in the caves until its presence was discovered by chance by a wandering druid named Jin Durwhimmer, who noticed the strange fluctuations after performing a *commune with nature* ritual in the nearby foothills. He investigated, was shocked at what he found, and attempted to heal the breach scar on his own, but the same magical backlash that slew the demonologist lashed out at him, blasting away his arm. Jin died soon thereafter, his attempt to heal the scar worse than failing, for it was this pulse of energies that caught the attention of another: Darivan.

When he arrived at the caves, Darivan didn't try to redirect or remove the scar's energies; instead, he harnessed them and developed the *monstrous bloom* ritual to weave both the First World and the Abyss into a singular monstrosity—a bloom of Lamashtu. This discovery was the key to his plot to spread the curse through the region, and as long as this sinister sorcerer lives, his curse continues to threaten the Stolen Lands.

CRADLE FEATURES

The Cradle of Lamashtu is a sizable cavern with a single entrance in the side of a sheer cliff wall where the rugged foothills of the Tors of Levenies transition into a jagged mountainscape. Little in the surrounding terrain gives away the true nature of what awaits discovery inside the caverns themselves.

Inside, the caves are warm and humid as a result of the breach scar. Water condenses on the walls and pools on the floor, and as the caves themselves slope gently upward overall, this condensation constantly drains out of the cavern entrance in tiny little trickles. Mold grows on many surfaces and in many colors, and the air smells musty with an unpleasant undercurrent of decaying plant matter. The first time breathing PCs enter the Cradle, they must succeed at a DC 15 Fortitude save to avoid becoming sickened 1 by the foul smell, after which they are temporarily immune to the scent in the Cradle of Lamashtu for 24 hours. The caverns are lit dimly by softly glowing patches of phosphorescent fungi, and ceiling height averages at a roomy fifteen feet.

THE BREACH SCAR

The breach scar itself suffuses the entire cave complex with its energies. To heal it, the PCs must defeat the bloom of Lamashtu, as the Abyssal corruption from the scar itself was largely drawn out to empower the evil plant's creation. Until the plant is slain, the humidity, warmth, and awful smell in the caverns will persist. Yet these are only minor side effects to the scar's true and insidious danger.

As a result of the scar, the Cradle of Lamashtu exists in two realities at the same time. One of these is within the Material Plane (where the Cult of the Bloom dwells) and one is within the First World (where several dangerous monsters have been attracted to the caverns). The cultists and the dangers from the First World have come to terms with one another and either avoid or (in the case of the redcaps in area **C8**) have allied with each other.

SHIFTING REALITIES

The Cult of the Bloom drew upon energies from the First World and the Abyss to create their curse, and these energies infuse the Cradle of Lamashtu. At your discretion, you can present the encounters in these caves as shifting between realities–now and then giving the PCs glimpses of strange skies above where a cave ceiling loomed only moments before or dense walls of vegetation instead of cavern walls. If you wish, you could even have additional foes manifest in the caverns from the First World on repeat visits!

C1. CRADLE ENTRANCE — LOW 7

A fifteen-foot-wide cave entrance looms at the base of this cliffside. Tendrils of vibrantly colored plant life coil out from the cave's edges along the cliff and across the ground like verdant arteries, with strangely colored flowers blooming here and there along the growth. Rivulets of water run from the cave to drain away into the surrounding terrain, while the smell wafting from the entrance is that of rotting plants.

The cave entrance is at all times warded by an *alarm* spell, renewed as needed by the bloom cultists. The *alarm* is triggered if a Small or larger creature enters the cavern without speaking the password, "Kurnugia" (the name of Lamashtu's Abyssal realm), creating an audible sound of jackals yipping and barking.

Creatures: A group of three bloom cultists stand guard here at posts about twenty feet beyond the cave entrance. If they notice a disturbance, or if the *alarm* is triggered, one of the cultists instantly retreats into area **C2** to alert their fellows therein. If the PCs surprise the cultists, the guards shout warnings toward area **C2**, alerting the cultists there. Once a bloom cultist engages in combat, they fight to the death.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

BLOOM CULTISTS (3) CREATURE 5

RARE CE MEDIUM HUMAN HUMANOID

Human cleric of Lamashtu

Perception +13

Languages Abyssal, Common

Skills Deception +11, Intimidation +11, Nature +13, Religion +13

Str +3, **Dex** +3, **Con** +2, **Int** +0, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +0

Items *+1 kukri*, robes

AC 22; **Fort** +11, **Ref** +12, **Will** +15

HP 75

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *kukri* +13 (agile, finesse, trip); **Damage** 1d6+5 slashing

Divine Spells Prepared DC 21, attack +13; **3rd** *chilling darkness*, *harm*; **2nd** *dispel magic*, *heal*, *spiritual weapon*; **1st** *alarm*, *command*, *ray of enfeeblement*; **Cantrips (3rd)** *divine lance*, *forbidding ward*, *message*, *read aura*, *shield*

Rituals *monstrous bloom* (page 586)

Absorb the Bloom ❖ (divine, manipulate, necromancy) The bloom cultist places a hand against the wall or floor in the Cradle of Lamashtu and utters a prayer to the Mother of Monsters. Filaments of fungus slither up into the cultist's flesh, healing 4d6 points of damage. The cultist can't Absorb the Bloom for 24 hours.

C2. CULTIST BARRACKS LOW 7

The tunnel walls widen here, forming a larger cavern with fifteen-foot-wide exits to the north and south. To either side of the cavern sit six low wooden pallets that allow bedrolls to lie a few inches above the glistening wet, fungus-encrusted ground below.

Creatures: The beds here are where the bloom cultists rest and relax—by utilizing a chamber so near the entrance for the cultists' barracks, Darivan not only ensures these, his "most disposable" minions, bear the brunt of any initial invasion, but also allows the more dangerous threats deeper in the caves to persist without having to introduce unwanted safety measures.

While there are a dozen beds in this room (revealing the total number of bloom cultists active in the Cradle at this time), when the PCs first arrive there are only three cultists resting here; the other cultists currently located in the Cradle (apart from the three guards the PCs likely already encountered in area **C1**) are either attending the seeds in area **C3** or the shrine in area **C5**. Even if particularly loud combat breaks out here or in area **C1**, the other cultists do not come to the aid of those here and instead prepare to defend their charges in areas **C3** and **C5** respectively.

If the PCs catch these bloom cultists off guard, they are all sleeping in their beds. If the cultists here are woken by a guard from area **C1**, though, they wake quickly and prepare to defend the cavern. Once a fight starts here, a cultist flees to area **C5** to warn the others there as soon as another cultist is slain.

BLOOM CULTISTS (3) CREATURE 5

Page 240

Initiative Perception +13

C3. BLOOM BED MODERATE 6

The floor of this cave slumps downward at a slight angle, resulting in a shallow slurry of fungus, mud, and foul-smelling water pooling on the ground. Over a dozen watermelon-sized pods of pulsating plants grow within tangles of greasy-looking foliage in the slop, amid swaths of rotting meat and bone.

The most important components of the *monstrous bloom* ritual are seed pods harvested from the bloom of Lamashtu in area **C10**. The cult chose this cave to grow and nurture the pods for use in further rituals due to the depression in the floor. In addition to feeding the pods flesh harvested from animals and sapient victims alike, the cultists keep a constant cycle of prayer to Lamashtu in order to infuse the pods with Abyssal energies. A PC who studies the pods for a minute (either before or after they burst—Hazard, below) and succeeds at a DC 25 Nature or Religion check recognizes the plants as being some sort of supernatural hybrid of First World and Abyssal vegetation.

A character can move through the bloom bed normally or treat it as difficult terrain; anyone who moves through the bloom bed normally triggers the hazard below.

Creatures: A group of four cultists tends the bloom pods, periodically adding new flesh for the plants to sup upon while constantly maintaining their prayers. These prayers can be paused for short periods now and then, such as when a group of cultists swaps out for a new shift, or when the four band together to attack intruding PCs. The cultists prefer to fight the PCs in the ten-foot-wide tunnel leading into the bloom bed to prevent them from potentially damaging the pods, but if the PCs manage to defeat three of the four, the final cultist retreats into the pods to try to lure the PCs into following and, potentially, triggering the hazard. This will destroy the current crop of pods, of course, but the cultist hopes that the burst will slay the PCs and thus begin a new crop.

BLOOM CULTISTS (4) CREATURE 5

Page 240

Initiative Perception +13

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



Hazard: While the slowly pulsing bloom pods growing here haven't yet matured to the point where they can be used in *monstrous bloom* rituals, they remain a dangerous hazard to anyone who doesn't move carefully through the bloom bed.

EXPLODING BLOOM PODS — HAZARD 8

ENVIRONMENTAL

Stealth DC 28 (expert)

Description Moving too quickly through the bed of pods causes them to shudder, emit eerie gurgling sounds, and then burst.

Disable DC 28 Survival (expert) (4 checks) to slice through all four of the larger shared root systems to render the dangerous pods inert, or inflict enough damage to the pods on the first attempt to reach the hazard's BT (damage that doesn't reach the hazard's broken threshold causes it to trigger)

AC 24; **Fort** +19, **Ref** +13

HP 66 (BT 33); **Immunities** critical hits, object immunities, precision damage

Burst ↷ Trigger A Small or larger creature moves at normal speed through the area, or the area takes less than 33 points of damage from any source; **Effect** The pods explode into a burst of toxic foliage, mold, and poisonous vapors. All creatures in area **C3** must attempt a DC 28 Reflex save, while all creatures in the ten-foot-wide tunnel leading south must attempt a DC 24 Reflex save.

Critical Success The character takes no damage.

Success The character takes 1d10+6 bludgeoning damage and 1d10 poison damage from the explosion.

Failure The character takes 2d10+11 bludgeoning damage and 2d10 poison damage from the explosion and also takes 1d10 persistent poison damage as the toxins in the fungus and vapor continue to work in the character's flesh. Being restored to full hit points automatically ends this persistent poison damage.

Critical Failure As failure, but the character is also affected by Lamashtu's bloom (page 242) and automatically starts at Stage 1 of the affliction, bypassing the regular onset period entirely.

C4. STONE WALL

At two locations in the Cradle, areas **C4a** and **C4b**, Darivan has used several *walls of stone* to seal off access to deep caves within the Cradle, shaping the wall to resemble a cavern wall. At area **C4a**, he did so to hide access to area **C10**, where the first *monstrous bloom* ritual was performed, while at area **C4b**, he did so to block access to area **C9** and the troublesome ghost therein. Success at a DC 26 Perception check is enough to recognize the *walls of stone* for magical

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

LAMASHTU'S BLOOM CURSE 7

CONJURATION CURSE DISEASE MAGICAL

While some NPCs become afflicted by Lamashtu's bloom curse during Parts 1 and 2 of this chapter, during Part 3 the PCs may be exposed to it as well. While the bloom is itself a curse, it functions mechanically more like a disease, and as such features both of these affliction traits. As long as the curse persists, a creature cannot recover from the disease, and removing the curse does not automatically remove the disease element of the affliction. Both elements must be dealt with individually before a victim suffering from Lamashtu's Bloom is safe. As with all elements of this curse, slaying the bloom of Lamashtu in area **C10** automatically removes this affliction.

Saving Throw DC 23 Fortitude; **Onset** 1 week; **Stage 1** no ill effects (1 day); **Stage 2** enfeebled 1 (1 day); **Stage 3** enfeebled 1 and 2d6 poison damage (8 hours); **Stage 4** unconscious and 4d6 poison damage (10 minutes); **Stage 5** death; **Special** a creature that dies from Lamashtu's bloom explodes in a blast of First World foliage, releasing a monster. This creature is typically a low-intelligence beast or dragon between 7th and 9th level, depending on the GM's whim.

creations, although the walls do not themselves radiate magic. Darivan uses *passwall* to come and go through these walls as needed.

Hazard: While Darivan believes he has sealed away the troublesome ghost of the caves' previous inhabitant, Jin's lingering presence allows a manifestation to appear before non-cultists who approach the *wall of stone* at area **C4b**.

Jin's presence manifests as a flickering, nearly completely transparent image of his ghostly self that emerges out of the wall. This manifestation eagerly beckons for the PCs to follow him, then it fades back into the wall. Every few rounds the PCs remain in the area, the haunting presence emerges again to beg them to follow. This is not Jin's actual ghost, as that undead spirit cannot travel far from his physical remains in area **C9**, but a PC who studies the spirit and succeeds at a DC 21 Nature check or a DC 25 Religion check to Recall Knowledge recognizes the gnome's attire as being that of the druidic order of the Green Faith.

C5. SHRINE OF THE MOTHER TRIVIAL 8

Tunnels exit from this cavern to the north and west, while to the east, the cave widens into a chamber that has been cleared of debris. The walls and floor remain encrusted with the dank, moist mold and strange flora seen elsewhere in the caverns, but several long rows of stone risers form a two-tiered amphitheater surrounding a square wooden lectern in the center of the room. The walls are adorned with bas-reliefs of three-eyed jackals cavorting in a verdant forest while they chase and feast upon fey creatures.

Through the application of *shape stone* and *wall of stone*, Darivan sculpted this cave into a shrine to the Mother of Monsters, forming the rows of seats and the sculptures adorning the walls. It was here that he taught his cultists the *monstrous bloom* ritual, but more recently, he uses it as a place to give sermons and bolster resolve among his followers.

A successful DC 15 Religion check to Recall Knowledge confirms that the wall carvings depict images sacred to the worship of Lamashtu, while a critical success on this check reveals something more: These images represent the worship of Lamashtu merged with a twisted reverence for the First World.

Creatures: A pair of cultists attend this shrine at all times, either working to keep the quickly growing layers of mold and strange foliage from obscuring the carvings and benches or simply offering prayers to Lamashtu. If the alarm is raised, it is to here that the cultists eventually retreat—at your option, Darivan himself may come to join the fight from area **C7**, but keep in mind that he's a powerful foe and pairing him up with a large number of cultists can quickly overwhelm a 7th-level party.

BLOOM CULTISTS (2) CREATURE 5

Page 240

Initiative Perception +13

Sermon Schedule: Darivan gathers his cultists to this area at midnight every three days to perform his one-hour sermons, so if the PCs time their investigation of the cult just right, they'll find all twelve bloom cultists and Darivan himself gathered here. During the sermon, they take a –4 circumstance penalty to Perception checks as a result of their focus on the unholy prayers. Of course, a fight against Darivan and a dozen bloom cultists is well beyond an Extreme encounter for 7th-level characters, so wiser PCs might use this hour instead to scout out other locations in the Cradle rather than launch an attack.

C6. MOLD FARM LOW 8

Whereas the other caverns elsewhere in this complex have had a fair amount of fungus and strange plant growth clinging to the walls and growing on the floor, this large cavern is almost a jungle of fungus and unusually vibrant

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

plant life. A thin layer of softly tawny fungal matter grows over everything in this cavern.

Hazard: Experienced cavern explorers may swiftly suspect this entire cavern to be infested with dangerous yellow mold, but such suspicions are only partially right. Indeed, a few patches of yellow mold grow in here, but the majority of the layer of yellow fungus that grows in this room is harmless. The yellow mold itself has been carefully cultivated by Darivan, not so much as a defense but because the spores are a component of the *monstrous bloom* ritual.

Five patches of yellow mold grow on the floor here; the locations of these patches are indicated on the map.

YELLOW MOLD (5) HAZARD 8

Pathfinder Core Rulebook 524
Stealth DC 28 (trained)

C7. DARIVAN'S RETREAT SEVERE 7

The floor of this cavern slopes upward to the south, slowly ascending out of the soggy mess of water and fungus that stains the cave floor elsewhere. Rivulets of condensation still drip from the walls, forming trickling trails of water that run down the cave floor to the north. The walls to the far south are decorated with bas-relief images of three-eyed jackals with plants and flowers growing from their bodies.

As in area **C5**, the decorations on the wall were placed via *shape stone* and can be recognized in the same way.

Creatures: Darivan, leader of the Cult of the Bloom, uses this cavern as a personal retreat to rest, relax, and study. A few times a day, he emerges from this area to check on his followers or the growth of the pods in area **C3**, to confer with his redcap allies in area **C8**, to harvest spores from area **C6**, or even to spend time meditating in area **C10**—it's up to you if the cult leader is found in one of these other areas, but it's recommended that the first time the PCs investigate the Cradle, they encounter him here.

When Darivan is here, he uses his *explorer's yurt* to shelter within, filling much of the southern area of the cavern with its confines. The cult leader is entirely convinced that it is his destiny to transform the Stolen Lands into a region ruled by monsters, and as such he regards intruders as yet another offering arrived for his sacrifices to Lamashtu. He sneers in combat and brags that the Mother's Bloom will continue to slaughter the fools and unleash the monsters, regardless of anything the PCs do to try to stop him. He fights to the death.

DARIVAN CREATURE 10

Page 594
Initiative Perception +19

Treasure: In addition to Darivan's magical gear, Darivan's collected books and folios (mostly prayer books devoted to the worship of Lamashtu) lie on tables within the *explorer's yurt*. Here, the PCs can uncover the full details of Darivan's plan to transform the Stolen Lands into a haven for Lamashtu's monstrous minions. These notes mention how he first learned of



BLOOM CULTIST

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

the caverns via a vision showing his success at creating the *monstrous bloom* ritual in area **C10**. The notes conclude with his (correct) theory that the bloom of Lamashtu that "quickened within the body of a most unusual chimera my Goddess saw fit to provide" drew its power directly from the corruption in the breach scar, effectively transferring the site's magical energy into the creature itself. Darivan spends time gloating that "now the chimeric host sees me as its master, and when I speak to it in the Mother's tongue, it obeys without question." The notes also mention his fear that "should the bloom host be destroyed, all my work will have been for naught," concluding with tentative plans for relocating the "chimeric host" to somewhere more secure so the curse can spread through the Stolen Lands with ease.

C8. VIOLENT VISITORS — SEVERE 7

The layer of fungus that grows across the floor of this cave has been scraped and pushed into mounds along the edges of the chamber, leaving swaths of moist, bare stone.

Creatures: While most of the fey who learn about the Cult of the Bloom oppose the cult's goal of merging the worship of Lamashtu with the vibrant energies of the First World, some of that realm's more sadistic inhabitants are intrigued and delighted by the plot.

A small band of redcaps approached Darivan with an offer to help spread the curse. Darivan intends to use this group to seed the next crop of pods from area **C3** into the surrounding region, but until the latest crop is ripe, he's given this cavern over to the redcaps to use as they see fit. The redcaps are allowed to come and go (they know the locations of the yellow mold patches in area **C6**), but for the moment, they are content here. They've recently been passing time with a macabre game involving the construction of a set of baskets made from the tangled legs of a dozen dead grigs that they intend to then use as target practice for severed grig heads. The redcaps abandon this activity as soon as they notice the PCs, and they attack at once. Once four redcaps are slain, the remaining two flee, racing through area **C6** in hopes that the PCs stumble into patches of yellow mold as they seek to exit the Cradle entirely.

REDCAPS (6) — CREATURE 5

Pathfinder Bestiary 278
Initiative Perception +12

C9. ALL THAT REMAINS — MODERATE 7

The air in this cave is much cooler and drier than that of the caverns leading up to it, with not a spot of mold or vegetation growing on its floors or walls, which are entirely free of the shine of condensation. Very little of interest lies within this empty, dry cavern, save for the skeletal remains of a gnome slumped against the southwestern wall, one of its arms missing beyond a fragmented stump of bone.

Creature: The gnome druid Jin Durwhimmer came to these caverns years ago when a *commune with nature* ritual revealed the presence of the corrupted breach scar within. He explored the cave system before realizing there was no centralized point of corruption for the scar, and he chose this cavern as the place to attempt to heal the breach only to meet his end when the attempt backfired. Tormented by his failure and mocked by the corruption's continued presence, Jin's spirit rose as a ghost after death. Darivan fought Jin when he first encountered the ghost, but decided to wall the cave over, leaving Jin to suffer in his undeath alone—far enough away that he couldn't directly influence the cult, but near enough at hand that he could feel their corruption of the First World breach.

As a ghost, Jin is neither cruel nor violent; his driving motivation at this point is to see to the defeat of the cult and the healing of the breach scar. Anger and shame at Darivan's use of the site for his own corrupt needs have wreaked havoc on the gnome's mind, but he recognizes those who do not belong to the cult instinctively and begs them for help. The PCs likely experienced a brief glimpse of Jin calling for aid at area **C4b**.

Once the PCs encounter him in this cave, though, Jin is more vocal, pleading for the PCs to "cut out the sickness within the breach," "banish the jackal's breath from these caverns," and "heal the scar." If the PCs press for more information, Jin reveals that "the bloom of Lamashtu has grown within and feeds on the scar itself. It drew in the corruption to grow strong, but that gives us the key to finally cleanse these caves: Defeat the bloom, and the scar will heal itself!"

He won't attack the PCs unless they attack first, in which case his pleas shift to rage as he calls the PCs "pawns of Lamashtu" and "playthings of the demon's bloom." He's lost access to his druidic spellcasting power (although he retains knowledge of three rituals he knew in life), but he remains a dangerous foe. If the PCs defeat Jin, then return here at a later date, they find the ghost has rejuvenated (assuming that the corruption in area **C10** is still active) and carries no memories of their previous violence against him.

Jin's primary story purpose here is to fill in gaps in the lore the PCs have gathered, or to confirm their suspicions about what is truly going on in the Cradle with the Cult of the Bloom, but not to solve their problems for them. Use the one-armed ghost to push the PCs toward a confrontation with Darivan if needed, but also to help the PCs realize that the source of the curse lies to the west in area **C10**.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

JIN DURWHIMMER CREATURE 9

UNIQUE | N | SMALL | GHOST | INCORPOREAL | SPIRIT | UNDEAD

Male gnome ghost (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 166)

Perception +19; darkvision

Languages Common, Gnomish, Sylvan

Skills Nature +17, Religion +17, Stealth +17

Str –5, **Dex** +4, **Con** +2, **Int** +2, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +2

Site Bound

AC 25; **Fort** +15, **Ref** +19, **Will** +19

HP 120, negative healing, rejuvenation; **Immunities** death effects, disease, paralyzed, poison, precision, unconscious; **Resistance** all damage 10 (except force, *ghost touch*, or positive; double resistance vs. non-magical)

Rejuvenation (divine, necromancy) Jin is put to rest if both Darivan (area **C7**) and the bloom of Lamashtu (area **C10**) are defeated.

Speed fly 25 feet

Melee ❖ ghostly hand +19 (agile, finesse, magical), **Damage** 2d8+10 negative

Rituals *awaken animal*, *commune with nature*, *primal call*

Frightful Moan ❖❖ (auditory, primal, emotion, enchantment, fear, mental) DC 28

Telekinetic Assault ❖❖ (primal, evocation) 5d6 bludgeoning, DC 28

Reward: If the PCs promise Jin that they'll do their best to defeat the cult and destroy the bloom of Lamashtu, Jin tells them he'll reward them with some of his knowledge of primal magic as his soul moves on to the Great Beyond. He tells the PCs about the three rituals he knows, and once the bloom of Lamashtu is defeated, he'll focus his remaining ghostly energies on one PC of the party's choice (preferably a druid or a primal spellcaster), automatically imparting full knowledge of all three of these rituals in that character's mind as he goes.

If the PCs manage to put Jin's ghost to rest before they fight him, grant them XP as if they'd defeated him in combat. They don't earn this extra XP if they already had to defeat the ghost once before in a previous encounter, though.

C10. GARDEN OF THE BLOOM SEVERE 7

It's difficult to discern the exact dimensions of this vast, sprawling cavern due to the riot of strange vegetation and fungus that grows within. Clouds of mist roiling twenty feet above obscure both the cave roof and the tops of the strange trees, oversized ferns, and enormous mushrooms that grow within. The ground below is a moist tangle of roots, moss, soil, and decaying plant matter, and the air is uncomfortably warm, humid, and thick with the stink of decay. Somewhere above, a sickly yellow light sifts through the mist to light the entire cavern below, almost as if there were no roof to the chamber and sunlight were drifting down through the vapors.

Upon entering this room, the very heart of the corrupted bloom that maintains the effects of the cult's curse, breathing PCs must succeed at a DC 25 Fortitude save to avoid becoming sickened 1 (or sickened 2 on a critical failure). This sickened condition stacks with any caused by the general odor of the Cradle, but once the PCs are exposed to the stink here, they will not have to attempt the save again for 1 hour.

The thick vegetation in this chamber, combined with the sloppy unstable footing, constitutes difficult terrain. The cave itself is 50 feet



JIN DURWHIMMER

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

BYPASSING STONE WALLS

Two key areas in the Cradle of Lamashtu, areas **C9** and **C10**, lie beyond *walls of stone* that the PCs must bypass. Even if the PCs lack magic like *shape stone* or *dimension door*, they can always attempt to smash through the walls; see page 383 of the *Pathfinder Core Rulebook* for statistics. Some parties might have difficulty figuring out that there is more to explore beyond what appears to be a solid wall; the manifestation of Jin's ghost at area **C4b** and Darivan's journals at area **C7** are meant to serve as clues to the PCs that these walls hide secrets, but if you find that your players are having trouble progressing beyond these walls, feel free to have Jin's ghost be clearer in his hints, or add in a few *scrolls of shape stone* as additional treasures in area **C5**.

high—the "light" glowing above is a manifestation of the chamber's proximity to the First World.

Creature: While the PCs might initially fear that they'll need to completely destroy all the strange foliage in this cavern, the vegetation is merely a side effect. The focus of the first *monstrous bloom* ritual performed in this chamber by Darivan and his cultists is in fact an immense, mutated chimera named Akuzhail, a creature drawn decades ago into these caves by the strange lure of the breach scar, and interpreted by Darivan as a gift placed here by Lamashtu to serve as the initial focus for his plot. Now that it has become the host for the bloom of Lamashtu, as long as this ferocious chimera lives, the energies that maintain the curses the Cult of the Bloom has spread through the region persist.

Akuzhail no longer needs to feed and barely has the capacity for nonviolent thought. It exists now as a living manifestation of the first *monstrous bloom* rather than as an individual creature with plans or desires or motivations of its own. The creature spends its time nesting in the center of the room, and while the foliage prevents it from having line of sight to the entrance, it has keen hearing and scent; as soon as it notices anyone approaching, it gives out a ferocious triple roar and moves to attack. It won't attack anyone it believes to be Darivan and follows the commands of anyone it believes is Darivan, provided those orders are spoken in Abyssal, up until the point "Darivan" or his allies attack the chimera or an attempt to Lie to it fails. At this point, the chimera becomes confused for 1 round, after which it focuses its fury on the one posing as Darivan.

Akuzhail's three heads are those of a vulture in the center, a rattlesnake on the left, and a centipede on the right. It has feathered wings, a lion's body, and a tail that ends in a rattlesnake's rattle. A foul stink of rotting vegetation wafts from the creature, although in this room, that unpleasant smell is hard to tell apart from the rest of the chamber's odor. Once a fight begins, the mutant chimera battles to the death, yet slaying it only starts a new conflict as the bloom of Lamashtu that lives within the chimera's body bursts from its remains to continue the fight. Only by slaying this monstrous Abyssal plant can the PCs end the threat posed by the curse and the Cult of the Bloom!



AKUZHAIL

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #13237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

AKUZHAIL CREATURE 10

UNIQUE | CE | HUGE | BEAST | MUTANT

Variant chimera (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 63)

Perception +21, darkvision 60 feet, scent (imprecise) 30 feet

Languages Abyssal

Skills Acrobatics +19, Athletics +21

Str +7, **Dex** +3, **Con** +5, **Int** –3, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +0

AC 29; **Fort** +21, **Ref** +17, **Will** +19

HP 195; **Resistances** acid 10, poison 10

Life Bloom (conjuration, death, primal) When Akuzhail dies, its body explodes in a riot of seething vegetation and raw life. All living creatures within a 60-foot radius are restored 12d6 Hit Points from this energy. A fully grown bloom of Lamashtu (below) emerges from the carcass, but it can take no actions on this round. Next round, this bloom of Lamashtu enters combat at the same point in the turn during which Akuzhail perished on the previous round, but the bloom is slowed 1. At the end of the bloom's turn, it attempts a DC 11 flat check; on a success it loses the slowed 1 condition at the start of its next turn.

Of Three Minds ↻ **Trigger** Akuzhail fails or critically fails a Will save; **Effect** Akuzhail rerolls the Will save with a –4 penalty. If it fails this second save, it may make a third attempt but with a –8 penalty. It cannot make a third attempt if its second attempt was a critical failure.

Three Headed As chimera.

Triple Opportunity As chimera.

Attack of Opportunity ↻

Speed 25 feet, fly 40 feet, bloom stride

Melee ❖ vulture beak +23, **Damage** 2d8+11 slashing plus 1d8 bleed

Melee ❖ snake fangs +23, **Damage** 2d12+11 piercing plus bloom venom

Melee ❖ centipede mandibles +23, **Damage** 2d6+11 piercing plus 2d6 acid

Melee ❖ claw +23 (agile), **Damage** 2d8+11 slashing

Bloom Stride Akuzhail can move through the undergrowth in area **C10** without issue and does not treat this cavern as difficult terrain.

Bloom Venom (poison, primal) **Saving Throw** Fortitude DC 29; **Maximum Duration** 6 rounds; **Stage 1** 2d6 poison and enfeebled 1; **Stage 2** 2d6 poison and enfeebled 2; **Stage 3** 2d10 poison, enfeebled 2, and exposure to Lamashtu's bloom (sidebar on page 242).

Breath Weapon ❖❖ (primal, evocation) Akuzhail breathes a 60-foot line of venom from its snake mouth that deals 11d6 poison damage (DC 29 basic Fortitude save). Akuzhail can't use Breath Weapon for 1d4 rounds.

Frightening Rattle ❖ (emotion, enchantment, fear, mental, primal, sonic) Akuzhail shakes the rattle at the end of its tail to distract and frighten its enemies. Any creature within 30 feet must succeed at a DC 29 Will save or become frightened 1 (frightened 2 on a critical failure). On a critical success, a creature is temporarily immune to Akuzhail's Frightening Rattle for 24 hours.

Three-Headed Strike ❖❖ Akuzhail makes a Strike with its vulture beak, snake fangs, and centipede mandibles, each at a –2 penalty and targeting a different creature. These Strikes count as only one attack for its multiple attack penalty, and the penalty doesn't increase until it has made all three attacks.

BLOOM OF LAMASHTU CREATURE 10

Page 611

Initiative Perception +21

CONCLUDING THE CHAPTER

Slaying the bloom of Lamashtu in area **C10** immediately ends the curse afflicting the kingdom and saves all of those who otherwise would have been doomed to burst into fresh new monsters, but unless the PCs also defeat Darivan and his cultists, the Cult of the Bloom could return in the months or years to come to attempt to spread the *monstrous bloom* again. At your option, Darivan could even ally with Pitax, Fort Drelev, or another enemy, agreeing to use the bloom only against the PCs in return for a safe place to set up a brand new cult headquarters.

If Darivan does manage to escape, feel free to have the PCs continue to encounter monsters born from his sinister influences. The easiest way to adjust existing monster statistics to represent those capable of transmitting the curse is to have one of their melee Strikes become capable of inflicting a creature damaged with them with Bloom Venom (using the monster ability from Akuzhail, but with the Fortitude DC adjusted to be a standard save DC for the monster in question). Don't forget to give these infected monsters a little bit of extra unique flavor so that the PCs can tell that the creature is a familiar-looking mutant. At the very least, a successful Recall Knowledge check to identify such a monster should alert the PC that they face yet another of the infectious monstrosities that have fallen under the influence of the Cult of the Bloom.

Even if the PCs defeat the cultists and slay the bloom of Lamashtu, fears about the curse linger in the kingdom. While these worries generally don't cause problems in and of themselves, you should pepper in rumors about fears of a new bloom curse whenever the kingdom gains Unrest, or flavor random kingdom events with elements that can point to the unease caused by the cult. In time, an even more dangerous contagion of blooms wrack the kingdom—these sent by Nyrissa herself—but until then, keeping the threat of such events at least in the back of the PCs' minds can help to keep them prepared for almost anything to come.

paizo.com #13237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023



CHAPTER 6

THE VARNHOLD VANISHING

BY GREG A. VAUGHAN

PART 1: BEFORE THE VANISHING 250
The PCs can be of any level if they visit Varnhold before Part 2 begins.

PART 2: THE VANISHED VILLAGE 252
The PCs should be 8th level before investigating the vanishing at Varnhold.

PART 3: AMONG NOMEN 266
The PCs should be 8th level during their meeting with Nomen centaurs.

PART 4: VORDAKAI'S TOMB 270
The PCs should be 9th level during the exploration of Vordakai's tomb.

paizo.com #18237234, Randall Welles <Randywelles@gmail.com>, Sep 27, 2023